



General Assembly

Seventy-ninth session

Official Records

14th plenary meeting
Friday, 27 September 2024, 3 p.m.
New York

President: Mr. Yang (Cameroon)

In the absence of the President, Ms. 'Utoikamanu (Tonga), Vice-President, took the Chair.

The meeting was called to order at 3.15 p.m.

Agenda item 8 (continued)

General debate

Address by Mr. Gaston Alphonso Browne, Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, Corporate Governance and Public Private Partnerships of Antigua and Barbuda

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, Corporate Governance and Public Private Partnerships of Antigua and Barbuda.

Mr. Gaston Alphonso Browne, Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, Corporate Governance and Public Private Partnerships of Antigua and Barbuda, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Gaston Alphonso Browne, Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, Corporate Governance and Public Private Partnerships of Antigua and Barbuda, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Browne (Antigua and Barbuda): Today we all stand at the edge of a precipice. Never before has humankind been confronted with such stark choices: to end wars or condemn humankind to endless suffering; to eliminate poverty or watch millions starve; to act on climate change or doom future generations to a scorched planet. The choices we make today here in the Assembly and in every institution of governance will shape the survival of entire nations and the future of our world.

For small States like Antigua and Barbuda, those are not distant realities; they are existential threats. Our islands are on the front lines of a climate catastrophe we

This record contains the text of speeches delivered in English and of the translation of speeches delivered in other languages. Corrections should be submitted to the original languages only. They should be incorporated in a copy of the record and sent under the signature of a member of the delegation concerned to the Chief of the Verbatim Reporting Service, room AB-0928 (verbatimrecords@un.org). Corrected records will be reissued electronically on the Official Document System of the United Nations (<http://documents.un.org>).



did not cause, a debt crisis we did not create and conflicts in which we have no part. And yet we suffer the heaviest toll. The world is at a pivotal point and inaction is no longer an option for any of us.

Small island developing States (SIDS) are the first to suffer, but we will not be the last. All will be consumed if we continue to dither and delay. SIDS have learned to fight for our survival against the rising seas and violent storms, but today we must also fight for something greater — the survival of justice, equity, peace and human dignity itself. The time for games and lofty rhetoric has passed. We demand committed, concrete action and we demand it now. We do so not only for ourselves, but for all of humankind.

The fourth International Conference on Small Island Developing States is the pinnacle of monumental achievement, a milestone that marks not only our collective progress as SIDS, but also our unrelenting resolve. The Conference gave birth to the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for SIDS (ABAS), a renewed declaration for resilient prosperity. The Agenda is not just a road map for the future; it is a lifeline for now. For SIDS, ABAS represents the difference between thriving and perishing; it is our road map to a prosperous future.

At its core is the Centre of Excellence for the Sustainable Development of Small Island Developing States, built by SIDS for SIDS. The Centre is intended to be more than just an institution; it is an instrument for meaningful change, a centre for groundbreaking technologies, revolutionary processes and, certainly, pioneering solutions. With its Global Data Hub, Innovation and Technology Mechanism, Island Investment Forum and Debt Sustainability Support Service, the Centre of Excellence can literally transform how we adapt to our vulnerabilities and set a path for resilient prosperity.

However, that vision cannot succeed in isolation. We need the cooperation and support of the global community to ensure its success. Without global cooperation, our hope of a secure future within our own countries will crumble under the weight of inaction. That is why today I call for the unwavering commitment of the international community to the Centre's success. Our survival depends on it.

Climate change is not an abstract or academic threat. For my people and the people of SIDS, it is a persistent and destructive reality. Intense hurricanes are now an annual terror. Coastal erosion is wiping away our productive areas for tourism and agriculture. The climate crisis is not on the horizon; it is here, now, burning through our ecosystems, flooding our villages and leaving us with fewer tomorrows. And yet we find ourselves in an absurd situation, continuing to subsidize the very industries that are accelerating our destruction. Fossil fuel companies have become the architects of our demise, while generating ostentatious profits for their owners.

We must fight to end that madness in protection of our planet and in the interest of humankind. We need a fossil fuel non-proliferation treaty to halt the reckless destruction of our environment, to end fossil fuel subsidies and to chart a course toward a sustainable future, with a negotiated and graduated transition. Let the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (COP29) be the moment we draw a line in the sand. Let it be known that we can no longer afford the luxury of delay.

While we recognize that fossil fuels still play a role in the energy security of many countries and we do not expect their production to cease overnight, we should not support companies that extract oil and gas to continue generating extravagant profits at the expense of our planet. It is only fair and just that those companies pay a global levy to fund mitigation efforts and compensation for the damage they continue to inflict. That is not a punishment. It is climate justice. It is a moral and

legal responsibility in which the polluter pays, and it is very appropriate that the time for action is now.

While we face the climate emergency, we are also drowning in a sea of plastic pollution that is choking our oceans and devastating our biodiversity. It is no longer a question of if we act, but how swiftly we can mobilize against the threat. Our nations must commit to a binding treaty, as required by United Nations Environment Assembly resolution 5/14, to put an end to plastic pollution and safeguard our world's most fragile ecosystems. Let us not allow this tightening suffocation of our planet to continue.

Antigua and Barbuda, in concert with other small island developing States, has played a leading role in the pursuit of climate justice. We cannot relent on the issue of climate justice. At COP26 in 2021, together with Tuvalu, we established the Commission of Small Island States on Climate Change and International Law. Today an expanded membership from the Caribbean and the Pacific stands united in its demand for accountability. In 2022, the Commission sought the first-ever advisory opinion from the International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea on the obligations of States to mitigate greenhouse gas emissions. In May of this year, the Tribunal rendered a historic opinion, affirming that major polluters are under a legally binding obligation to protect the oceans — and by extension, small island States — from the catastrophic harm of climate change. That precedent sets the stage for the advisory proceedings now before the International Court of Justice, initiated under the leadership of Vanuatu, with the co-sponsorship of Antigua and Barbuda and other SIDS.

It is remarkable that the smallest nations are those driving that global response to the greatest threat to human survival. Yet, despite our efforts, the COP process continues to fail us. Instead of limiting global warming to 1.5°C — an essential threshold for survival — the world is hurtling towards a disastrous 2.8°C rise. That is nothing less than a death sentence for small island States, but it is also a harbinger of grief for the rest of our planet. We must demand that major polluters not only respect their obligations under international law, but also compensate us for the loss and damages we have suffered. Those who preach about a rules-based international order must now lead by example. Rules must apply equally to all, including the mighty, and not just to the poor and powerless. At COP29, we expect no further delay in the capitalization and operationalization of the Loss and Damage Fund, for which we have struggled so long and so hard. Equity and fairness demand it.

The fight for survival is not just about climate; it is also about financial justice, reparatory justice, other injustices and equity. The international financial system is skewed, outdated and unjust, punishing the most vulnerable while rewarding the already rich and prosperous with favourable terms for their financial instruments. For too long, small States like mine have been shackled by debt we did not cause — debt that arose from recovery spending on recurring disasters that are beyond our control. We cannot achieve climate justice without addressing the structural inequities in the international financial architecture.

It is time to lift the burdens that keep us bound to the past and unable to invest in our future. The SIDS Debt Sustainability Support Service is a critical mechanism that can provide tailored solutions, utilizing debt for climate swaps, debt relief, the repurposing of special drawing rights and carbon pricing funding to help us escape the cycle of unsustainable debt. That is not charity; it is the justice of financial inclusion and in the end, by remedying past injustices, it will establish a world that is fairer, more just and more at peace with itself.

The adoption of the multidimensional vulnerability index (MVI), which Antigua and Barbuda was honoured to help advance in the Organization, offers a path towards

correcting the imbalance of unjust treatment accorded to small and vulnerable nations. It is a vital tool designed to acknowledge the complexities we face, not just in terms of limited economic capacity and other structural vulnerabilities and a lack of resilience, but also in our exposure to myriad external shocks. International financial institutions must act on that, integrating the MVI into their policies to ensure that support is targeted where it is needed most.

The work has been done; the case has been made; the arguments are irrefutable. There can be no just and sustaining reform of the World Bank, other international financial institutions and multilateral banks without their effective implementation and use of the MVI. There can be no legitimate excuse for failing to utilize the MVI. As I said before, the arguments for its use are irrefutable and just.

The initiatives that SIDS have taken are a small component of the wider and more fundamental necessity for reform of the international financial architecture to provide greater funding accessibility and better terms, to include lower interest rates and longer maturity transformations. They are part of the wider need for change to effectively address the historic imbalances against SIDS, including financial exclusion. The international financial institutions and the nations that sit on their controlling boards must develop bespoke funding instruments that meet the needs of small, vulnerable States and other developing countries, taking into consideration their vulnerabilities and lack of resilience.

We must also recognize that the principles of justice and equity we champion here apply equally to all nations and are conditions precedent for a peaceful world. In that spirit, Antigua and Barbuda calls for the end of the designation of Cuba as a State sponsor of terrorism and for the lifting of the long-standing, senseless embargo that has restricted its economic development. The time has come to cast off the chains of that outdated measure, which no longer serves the interests of our modern, interconnected world. Let us work together towards a future built on mutual respect and cooperation where Cuba, like all nations, can fully participate in the global community. That is not a matter of politics; it is a matter of fairness and human dignity. The delegitimization of Governments based on ideological differences and utilizing misinformation and disinformation, including atrocity propaganda, serves no useful purpose but creates unnecessary tensions and conflicts. Let us embrace and respect our differences, standing in solidarity with each other in defence of global peace and prosperity.

I wish now to address the grave issue of the small arms and light weapons that are routinely exported from wealthy nations to our shores, creating havoc and instability. I call on the United States and other small arms and light weapons-producing countries to put systems in place to curb the exportation of those lethal weapons to our shores. They are causing immense harm. The issue is now emerging as a public health epidemic among SIDS, to the extent that I hereby make the call for a high-level meeting to be held at the eightieth session of the General Assembly to debate the threats of those weapons to peace and security and to devise solutions. Antigua and Barbuda cannot remain silent as innocent lives are destroyed and generations are condemned to fear and hatred.

The events unfolding in the Middle East, particularly the conflict between Israel and Hamas and Hizbullah, are deeply troubling. The violence is destabilizing the entire region and reverberating across the world. Every missile fired, every life lost, deepens wounds already too many to bear. The violations of international humanitarian law are alarming. We call on all parties to end the suffering by sitting down at a table of peace, where sincere negotiations can lead to a lasting solution. We believe that the only sustainable resolution is the creation of two sovereign States, with borders respected and rights upheld. It is time for the people of that region and

all conflict zones to end those conflicts and to give peace a chance. Let us give peace a chance.

From Gaza to the Sudan, Ukraine to Yemen, the scars of conflict run deep, leaving devastation in their wake. The anguish of families torn apart by war reverberates across the globe and it is our collective humanity that bleeds. Conflict kills the victims of bullets and bombs, but it also diminishes all humankind. On 17 September, inspired by the Secretary-General's impassioned call for peace, I wrote to him proposing an initiative that transcends borders, language and conflict. With that letter, I transmitted a concept note, setting out a proposal for holding international music concerts for peace across every region of the world. The initiative is intended not only to raise our global voices in a unified chorus against the horrors of war and other conflicts, but also to raise critical funds to support displaced persons and those who continue to suffer.

Music is a universal language. It speaks to the soul in ways that words cannot. In moments when words fall short, music carries our collective cries for peace and justice. This would be more than a performance; it would be a global appeal, a powerful demonstration that peace is not just an ideal but an absolute necessity, a survival imperative for this and future generations. I call on all nations large and small to support the concept of international music concerts for peace.

The world is crumbling under the weight of crises, including poverty, wars, pandemics and the climate devastation. We are at a defining moment and the choices we make now will determine the fate of every nation, large and small. We can end those grave challenges, but that will require more than words. It demands decisive, concrete, unified action. Antigua and Barbuda, like all small States, does not stand on the sidelines. We stand on the principles of peace and love for our common humanity and in the path of struggle against global predicaments we did not create. Yet we fight not just for ourselves, but for a world where justice reigns, where peace endures and where future generations will inherit not a planet in peril but one that prospers.

The world must act now, for the choices we make today will resonate through history. Let us choose peace. Let us choose justice. And let us choose the survival of our one human race, in our one homeland — planet Earth.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, Corporate Governance and Public Private Partnerships of Antigua and Barbuda for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Gaston Alphonso Browne, Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, Corporate Governance and Public Private Partnerships of Antigua and Barbuda, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Mr. Edi Rama, Prime Minister of the Republic of Albania

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister of the Republic of Albania.

Mr. Edi Rama, Prime Minister of the Republic of Albania, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Edi Rama, Prime Minister of the Republic of Albania, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Rama (Albania): As we meet today, we confront yet another year of complex crises and conflicts, as a deeply divided world watches. Our prospects for a more peaceful, just and equitable world are blurred today. Our times are challenging.

A few days ago, we committed to the Pact of the Future (resolution 79/1), a sound framework with a high level of ambition and actionable deliverables. We have made other, similar major commitments in the past. We have not always kept them, to put it very mildly. We have paid the price. This is yet another chance — one we take under pressure — to make a difference for a more peaceful and prosperous future even as the times we live in could not be grimmer.

Albania humbly joins this discussion after the conclusion of its mission, for the first time, as a member of the Security Council. Albania sought to represent the community of countries that stand together for values and principles that are non-negotiable, and we sincerely hope that we have met the expectations of many. Today more than ever, we need tolerance, trust and a hand of friendship extended to each other. Make no mistake — by “tolerance”, I do not mean complacency. Tolerance demands that we go beyond our comfort zones and not merely tolerate but tolerate respectfully, actively and graciously by not simply accepting other views but constantly engaging with the complexity of all our own histories.

Tolerance for us Albanians is not merely the passive acknowledgement and grudging acceptance of someone’s diversity. Our form of tolerance — the tolerance that Muslim and Christian Albanians expressed during the Second World War towards the Jews by putting their lives on the line against evil and making Albania the only country in Europe to end the war with more Jews than it had when the war began — requires its own partisan spirit. It requires engaging with those who are different from us, accommodating disagreements with respect and continuing to build bridges so that we can continue to debate and foster further understanding and peace by putting ourselves in the other’s shoes. But it also requires that we continue to challenge ourselves by reflecting on the possibility of our own biases and prejudices, by reflecting on the arbitrariness and unilaterality that we attribute to others, and by constantly interrogating our own double moral standards.

It is with that trust in humanity and humanism that Albania became a safe haven for people who escaped death after the fall of Kabul to the Taliban, who were welcomed and accepted by my country while bigger and richer States members of the European Union (EU) and NATO turned their backs on them. In the same spirit, we gave shelter to several thousand Iranian refugees whose lives were in daily danger in Camp Liberty, in Iraq, where they were raided and killed by Tehran’s assassins. We paid a dear price for being their hosts. The Tehran totalitarian regime engaged in a large-scale cyberattack on Albania that was aimed at bringing the country to its knees by wiping out all the digital infrastructure of our public services. They were very brutal, but they failed miserably. We did not waver and we will not waver in our commitment to sheltering those people in our country for as long as it takes. Our hospitality was and is related in no way to any political stance against Iran, but only to a humanitarian belief engraved in our spirit as a nation.

We recently extended a hand of help to our neighbour and special friend, Italy, in an effort to ease the difficulties that geography has burdened it with in one of the most pressuring phenomena of our times — immigration. Meanwhile, instead of just talking, we tried to act, without claiming that we could solve the huge immigration problem in Europe but, on the other hand, without just sitting around and by trying instead to build and add something constructive. We just played our part. That attitude of solidarity, cooperation and good-neighbourly relations is the linchpin of our policy in our region, the Western Balkans.

In our region, after more than a quarter of a century, the deep wounds left by the violent disintegration of the former Yugoslavia still need to be healed, but we have also seen the construction of peace, reflected above all in the vision, unparalleled wisdom and courage that led to the creation of the European Union. All of us in the Western Balkans have tried for over a decade to come together and meet to talk about

our challenges and plan our futures. It is Albania's firm belief that we need to look at the past with the eyes of the future and not look at the future with the eyes of the past.

Today the peoples of the Balkans have a moment of historical opportunity in a context of historical danger in the wider Europe, where the Russian aggression against Ukraine should serve us all as a permanently ringing bell. I would say that the Western Balkans is in a much better position today than ever before, but we must work tirelessly and patiently among ourselves in the region and, above all, with our partners to ensure that a return to the past is not just impossible, but simply unimaginable.

In that context, our brotherly Republic of Kosovo is an irreversible reality as a State among the six countries of the Western Balkans, with a clear European perspective and an undisputed allegiance to the large democratic community of nations. Any artificially drawn parallels between Kosovo and the occupied areas of Ukraine are meant to distract and confuse whomever they can under this roof and international public opinion, but they will never manage to dilute the truth that Kosovo is now an intrinsic part of the international reality and an aspiring member of the Euro-Atlantic community, and must not be held hostage by anyone with false pretensions and excuses, starting with the group of five EU members that still do not recognize Kosovo's rightful place in every international forum and organization.

In the third year of the unprovoked and unjustified war of aggression of Russia against Ukraine, we feel compelled to renew our call for Russia to stop the war. It is a war that neither Ukraine nor our community of like-minded nations chose, a catastrophe conceived by the decision of one country and, indeed, one delusional dreamer of an old, imperial past. Rewarding an aggressor that annexes the territories of a sovereign country by disarming the victim of aggression does not bring peace but paves the way for more war.

All those who seek peace by trying to stop Ukraine instead of stopping neo-imperialist Russia's aggression are wrong and they should be aware of a very simple truth — a peace that defeats Ukraine would bring only further aggression and turn our world into one ruled by might, not by right. Yes, we seek peace too, and we want peace to be made between Ukraine and Russia as soon as possible. Of course, we would support any peace attempt and format that would include Russia around the table, but we seek a just peace based on the Charter of the United Nations, international law and the resolutions of the General Assembly — a peace that cannot undermine Ukraine and its rights.

Earlier this year in Tirana, our capital, we hosted the second summit between Ukraine and South-East Europe and welcomed President Zelenskyy, a true and brave leader of a resistance that is not simply a resistance to brutal aggression against its homeland, but a resistance for the very existence of democracy and a just, rules-based Europe and world. Albania will continue to stand by Ukraine and support it for as long as necessary and until a lasting, just peace is achieved.

There is another war waging in Europe's South-East. Albania stands firm in its position that there is no place for Hamas and its like in the world we want to live in, just as we fully recognize the right of the Palestinian people to have their own safe place in this world and to give birth and raise their children in their own State. Guaranteeing such a basic condition for millions of Palestinians is much easier said than done, just as it is much easier said than done for the Jewish people to live in their land without anyone questioning their right to exist. We need to restore our moral compass in the Middle East, yes, but there is no moral compass that can relativize and, God forbid, normalize terror and a terrorist organization like Hamas as a part of the peace we all want between Israel and Palestine. Doing so would be like relativizing the scourge of anti-Semitism and agreeing to coexist with a new

vicious form of Nazism, which is the worst thing that could have happened for so many years to, first and foremost, the Palestinian people themselves.

Nevertheless, it is not too difficult to state loudly and strongly that so much violence and destruction cannot be the long-term solution for either Israel or Palestine and should stop. We reaffirm here our national support for a just and comprehensive resolution of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, based on the two-State solution. Albania supports the international community's efforts related to the conflict, through dialogue and negotiations leading to a true solution of two independent States living in peace and good-neighbourliness, a functional State of Palestine and a secure State of Israel, which, instead of being lectured to from afar, should be supported — with no “yes, buts” — in its fight against terror, while still more than 100 innocent people are being held hostage in hellish holes under the face of the Earth by the butchers of 7 October last year.

The rule of law stands at the heart of one of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, a goal that plays the role of enabler and accelerator of all the other Sustainable Development Goals. Its importance stands on the promise of achieving more inclusive, just and peaceful societies. Without strong institutions, access to justice and respect for human rights, progress on the other goals — such as ending poverty, ensuring food security and promoting health and well-being, including by fighting climate change — will be limited.

Albania is living proof of the radical transformation of good governance practices and mindset. Our public services are now over 95 per cent paperless and the digitalization of access and services has curbed corruption, informality and mistrust in institutions. With its unprecedented justice reform, Albania has invested tremendously over the past few years in achieving SDG 16 as a crucial tool for securing a sustainable future, social progress, economic prosperity, environmental sustainability and justice.

But the struggle of a developing country for just and fair institutions and good governance is not one that can be won within a year, through a few reforms or even during a single decade. On the contrary, it is a perpetual effort to transform domestically at the highest levels of policymaking by adopting the most effective practices of providing access to citizens at all levels and instances of Government. We are committed to playing our part and collaborating with the international community to ensure the successful realization of our Albania 2030 Agenda.

Building upon the ongoing work during our previous mandate as a non-permanent member of the Security Council, we will continue to work with like-minded countries to improve the governance and institutional efficiency of the United Nations, as well as multilateralism and respect for human rights. As a member of the Human Rights Council, Albania is committed to the universal principles of human rights and dignity in a world where every human being can realize her or his full potential and live with dignity and respect.

A very dear daughter of the Albanians, Saint Mother Teresa, once said, “I alone cannot change the world, but I can cast a stone across the waters to create many ripples”. No better saying can mirror today's need to work together on what is clearly the substance of multilateralism.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister of the Republic of Albania for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Edi Rama, Prime Minister of the Republic of Albania, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Ms. Fiamē Naomi Mata’afa, Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs and Trade of the Independent State of Samoa

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs and Trade of the Independent State of Samoa.

Ms. Fiamē Naomi Mata’afa, Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs and Trade of the Independent State of Samoa, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming Her Excellency Ms. Fiamē Naomi Mata’afa, Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs and Trade of the Independent State of Samoa, and inviting her to address the Assembly.

Ms. Mata’afa (Samoa): I extend my congratulations to Mr. Philemon Yang of Cameroon on his assumption of the presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. The theme of his presidency is one that resonates with us as we strive to navigate a path towards a more peaceful, sustainable and resilient future for our peoples and the planet. He may be assured of Samoa’s support in the successful execution of his mandate.

The effects of climate change are being lived in real time. We are not even at the end of 2024, yet we have witnessed countries in all corners of the globe endure extreme weather events, from ferocious wildfires to devastating floods and scorching heatwaves. In July, we saw the earliest Category 5 hurricane, Beryl, hit the Caribbean with great ferocity, causing devastation even in parts of Mexico, Venezuela and the United States.

Our collective efforts must not end at national borders. In our most difficult times, it is easy to abandon the collective to safeguard the individual, but history reminds us of the folly of that approach. Climate change remains one of the gravest concerns for all countries, especially the small island developing States (SIDS). Its impacts are felt more extensively due to our special circumstances and lack of capacity to respond quickly and effectively. Unless substantial investments are made to mitigate climate change, boost adaptation and build more resilient economies, we face urgent climate and financial risks.

Climate change also has significant security implications for our food, water and energy supplies, competition over natural resources, loss of livelihoods, climate-related disasters and potentially forced migration. We must do more to turn the tide, to honour our commitments and obligations and to take urgent and ambitious climate action now. Our expectations for the upcoming twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (COP29), in Azerbaijan, include securing an agreement on a new collective quantified goal on climate finance that is truly fit for purpose. It is time to review the outcomes of the first global stocktake to ensure that new nationally determined contributions due in 2025 are as ambitious as possible.

We must keep global temperatures below 1.5°C. That is a red line for many SIDS like my country, Samoa. In this era of unprecedented sea level rise, international law must evolve to meet the climate crisis and the disproportionate effect it has on SIDS. Earlier this week, the leaders of the Alliance of Small Island States (AOSIS) adopted the Declaration on Sea Level Rise and Statehood. The Declaration provides affirmation that international law is based on the fundamental principle of the continuity of States. Our statehood and sovereignty cannot be challenged. No matter the physical changes wrought by the climate crisis, we will remain sovereign States unless we choose otherwise.

As part of the blue Pacific continent, Samoa is committed to ensuring that our ocean spaces, resources and ecosystems remain healthy for current and future

generations. We have witnessed many demands on our marine resources from a variety of sectors. Cognizant of the threats that such demands and pressures place on those critical resources, in 2020 we launched the Samoa Ocean Strategy, our national policy framework that seeks to sustainably manage Samoa's vast ocean and marine resources. The Strategy provides bold and comprehensive integrated ocean management solutions to advance ocean stewardship and ensure that the cultural and economic values that Samoans derive from the ocean continue to be available to all generations.

Stewardship of the ocean extends beyond our national boundaries. In that regard, Samoa is working towards ratification of the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction, while continuing to engage regionally and internationally on advocacy of ocean health and the sustainability of our marine ecosystems, including fisheries resources. We call on our partners to continue working with us to combat illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing, which deprives us of resource benefits and undermines our management efforts. We continue to engage in the work of the Intergovernmental Negotiating Committee on Plastic Pollution for an international legally binding instrument on plastic pollution. For Samoa, the need to address the global plastic pollution problem, especially in the marine environment, is a priority.

We need to protect our biodiversity, both terrestrial and marine. Healthy biological diversity maintains the web of life that we rely on, such as food, water, medicine, economic growth and sustainable livelihoods. The protection of our mangroves and reef systems increases our resilience to climate change-driven erosion and flooding, supporting healthy ecosystems and the sustainable well-being of coastal communities.

Our experience with the coronavirus disease (COVID-19) pandemic has taught us to be better prepared for global pandemics. Non-communicable diseases (NCDs) are a priority concern and account for much of the burden of diseases in Samoa. Chronic NCDs are overtaking communicable diseases as the dominant health problem and are the leading causes of mortality, morbidity and disability. At the national level, NCDs account for almost half of the deaths and premature deaths in Samoa.

Food security is a priority that requires the transformation of our food systems. We must return to locally produced, quality fresh foods with less reliance on processed imported foods. Just as important is the need to address the balance of issues of access, affordability and convenience against quality and well-being.

In May, we met in Antigua and Barbuda for the fourth International Conference on Small Island Developing States, where we adopted the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for SIDS, a 10-year action plan for our sustainable development. SIDS are in the crossfire of multiple crises, including climate change and the economic and social repercussions of COVID-19, which many of us still have not fully recovered from. We face a unique set of vulnerabilities that impede our ability to achieve sustainable development. Most SIDS, like Samoa, face high indebtedness, compounded every time there is a natural disaster. Those disasters will only increase and intensify as long as climate change remains unaddressed. The work of the Systematic Observations Financing Facility and the Risk-informed Early Action Partnership in that space is much appreciated and fully supported by SIDS.

Samoa looks forward to the timely and effective implementation of the multidimensional vulnerability index by the international financial institutions and our development partners as a tool to assist SIDS in accessing finance. I am determined in that call, not only as Prime Minister of my country but as Chair of AOSIS. In July, Samoa presented its third voluntary national review report to the

High-level Political Forum on Sustainable Development. Its focus is on the continued commitment of the Government to the implementation of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development at a pace commensurate with our prioritization, resource availability and the active engagement of our communities. Samoa continues to place emphasis on achieving the Sustainable Development Goals through a balancing of the strengths of our culture and society, transformative reforms, effective resource mobilization and the careful management of our natural environment.

The Global Digital Compact (resolution 79/1, annex I) was a focus of this year's Summit of the Future, aimed at establishing a comprehensive framework for the governance of digital technologies and the Internet. We request that support for SIDS include capacity-building, technical assistance and the strengthening of digital infrastructure through cybersecurity measures and educational initiatives for public and private enterprises. The successful implementation of the Digital Compact will require a coordinated and multifaceted approach, with the assistance of United Nations entities and development partners in applying the principles to our national context, as well as at the regional and global levels.

Samoa remains a peaceful country, committed to justice and the protection of human rights. We are concerned that the war in Ukraine and the conflict in Gaza and surrounding areas are still ongoing, with no resolution in sight. The terrible loss of civilian lives, the displacement of people and the destruction of infrastructure and the environment are something we do not condone. The provision of arms to those conflicts needs to cease. Arms and weapons only fuel more death and destruction.

The United Nations can play a greater role in finding a path towards peace and we are committed to the collective responsibility of the global community to achieve that through international cooperation and diplomacy. Next year, the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations, will present an opportunity for all of us to seriously consider reforms of the Security Council. We must consider the expansion of both the permanent and non-permanent seats of the Security Council to enhance the representation of the underrepresented and unrepresented regions.

The more things change, the more we cannot afford to stay the same. The tools of a bygone era can no longer ensure our future. The complexity of the challenges that beset us requires a greater understanding of the challenges themselves, as well as of those being challenged. Samoa remains committed to the United Nations and our conviction that it remains the foremost forum to address all international issues.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs and Trade of the Independent State of Samoa for the statement she has just made.

Ms. Fiamē Naomi Mata'afa, Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs and Trade of the Independent State of Samoa, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Mr. Sonexay Siphandone, Prime Minister of the Lao People's Democratic Republic

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister of the Lao People's Democratic Republic.

Mr. Sonexay Siphandone, Prime Minister of the Lao People's Democratic Republic, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Sonexay Siphandone, Prime Minister of the Lao People's Democratic Republic, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Siphandone (Lao People's Democratic Republic) (*spoke in Lao; interpretation provided by the delegation*): At the outset, I would like to express

my sincere congratulations to Mr. Philemon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. I have full confidence that, with his extensive diplomatic experience and wisdom, he will successfully lead the Assembly under the theme of “Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations”, which is of the utmost importance and relevance to the current global situation.

In the same vein, I commend Mr. Denis Francis for his successful conduct of his tenure as the President of the General Assembly.

Today the international community is facing multifaceted challenges across various regions, such as geopolitical tensions, armed conflicts, economic and financial crises, ever more frequent and devastating natural disasters resulting from climate change, rising poverty and widespread social unrest worldwide, among others. Those remain real threats to international peace, stability and security and obstacles to the national development efforts of Member States, as well as to the implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), leaving many countries that have yet to fully recover from the impacts of the coronavirus disease with exacerbated economic and financial difficulties. Against that backdrop, I have seen Member States strive to enhance cooperation through multilateral frameworks and regional mechanisms to jointly address pressing issues, seeking to create an environment conducive to the maintenance of peace, which is the most fundamental condition for sustainable development.

However, the challenges that we are facing are much more fragile, could have more dire consequences and could potentially reshape the current and future international peace and security landscape, especially geopolitical tensions that are becoming more confrontational and widening divisions, all of which — including the prolonged conflicts in Gaza, Ukraine and many countries in Africa — require immediate attention.

The Lao People’s Democratic Republic is deeply concerned about the ongoing armed conflict that is threatening to spill across the entire Middle East region, which would exacerbate the humanitarian crisis for innocent civilians. We therefore maintain our consistent support for all international efforts aimed at achieving a permanent ceasefire and the cessation of all violence in Gaza and adjacent areas as the fundamental condition for safe and unhindered humanitarian access to the people and for the early launch of negotiations on a peace agreement. The Lao People’s Democratic Republic reiterates its support for the two-State solution for the Palestinian issue, whereby Palestine and Israel would coexist in peace, in accordance with the relevant United Nations resolutions, and calls for respect for the inalienable and legitimate rights of the Palestinian people and the establishment of the conditions necessary for Palestine to become a full-fledged Member of the United Nations.

Many countries all over the world, including the Lao People’s Democratic Republic, have experienced and suffered first-hand the consequences of war and the resolution of disputes by force, which directly endanger peace and security, with unpredictable loss of innocent lives. As such, the only way to resolve disputes at all levels, with a view towards sustainable peace, is to begin by building mutual trust and engaging in diplomatic negotiations based on respect for sovereignty and adherence to the fundamental principles of international law and the Charter of the United Nations .

I am of the view that the international community must rise to its required responsibility and political commitment, leading to tangible results based on international principles, in addressing various current issues and emerging challenges in the future. Simultaneously, we must further enhance our development cooperation

and global partnership, ensuring the concrete implementation of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, together with the outcomes of the Summit of the Future that world leaders recently endorsed, based on the promotion of multilateralism, with the United Nations at its core, in order to respond in an adequate and timely manner to the needs of the international community.

It is my view that the application of unilateral coercive measures is against the principles of the United Nations Charter and international law. Such measures have severely and disproportionately affected innocent people and obstructed development progress in many countries. In that regard, we reiterate our unwavering support, in line with the calls of the international community, for an end to the economic embargo against Cuba, its removal from the list of State sponsors of terrorism and the lifting of all unilateral coercive measures against any sovereign State.

The Lao People's Democratic Republic has the honour to assume the chairmanship of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) in 2024 for the third time, under the theme "ASEAN: Enhancing Connectivity and Resilience", aimed at building ASEAN into a more connected and resilient community through the implementation of its 2024 priorities and initiatives. The theme is reflective of the Lao People's Democratic Republic's national policy and objective to transform itself from being a landlocked country into a regional connectivity hub. The theme is also in line with ASEAN's common goal of building a more connected, integrated and resilient region that is able to respond in an effective and timely manner to emerging challenges amid complex and rapidly changing regional and global landscapes, thereby contributing to the common global cause of maintaining peace, stability and security, as well as sustainable development in the region and the world.

Importantly, this year ASEAN is focusing on developing strategic plans on each pillar and the ASEAN Community Vision 2045 towards building a resilient, innovative, dynamic and people-centred community, as well as the implementation of the United Nations 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. In addition, ASEAN is accelerating the accession process to admit Timor-Leste as a full member of ASEAN in the near future.

With respect to the developments in Myanmar, the Lao People's Democratic Republic, as ASEAN Chair, continues to uphold ASEAN's commitment to assisting Myanmar in finding a peaceful and durable solution to the ongoing problem there through the implementation of the five-point consensus, based on a Myanmar-owned and Myanmar-led process. The Lao People's Democratic Republic will continue to engage with relevant stakeholders with a view to building an environment conducive to the implementation of the five-point consensus, including the inclusive national dialogue and humanitarian assistance.

The Lao People's Democratic Republic remains steadfast in its efforts to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals, focusing on socioeconomic development, environmental protection and poverty reduction. In July, the Lao People's Democratic Republic presented the third voluntary national review of its SDG implementation at the 2024 High-level Political Forum on Sustainable Development, which demonstrated that progress towards achieving the SDGs remain slow and off-track. Among those, the implementation of our national sustainable development goal 18, "Lives safe from unexploded ordinance", has seen progress in varying degrees. However, unexploded ordinance remains a major threat to the lives of the Lao people and hinders their national development, while obstructing progress on other SDGs. We therefore take this opportunity to call upon the international community to provide predictable and adequate support and assistance to the Lao People's Democratic Republic in addressing that long overdue and challenging problem, in accordance with the Convention on Cluster Munitions.

The Lao People's Democratic Republic is of the view that one of the main obstacles to implementing the SDGs is insufficient funding. As such, there is an urgent need to reform the international financial architecture through collaboration among the United Nations development system, development partners and the international financial institutions, while promoting the participation of the developing countries in international economic decision-making, norm-setting and global economic governance. It is our ongoing position that the United Nations development system at all levels must enhance its role in cooperating with and providing support to Member States, especially the least developed countries, the landlocked developing countries and the small island developing States, in order to help address their special needs and challenges.

Another key factor that can help accelerate national development efforts is the role of science, technology and innovation, including artificial intelligence, in facilitating green growth and digitalization that are environmentally friendly, in addition to investment in carbon capture and storage. The Lao People's Democratic Republic therefore calls on the international community to facilitate access to and transfer of appropriate technology and innovation to help jumpstart development, including support for the implementation of the Lao People's Democratic Republic's strategic plan and vision for the development of its digital economy.

Furthermore, I am of the view that human capital is another decisive factor. Presently, one-third of the Lao population are within the age range of 10 to 24, making the Lao People's Democratic Republic the nation with the youngest population in South-East Asia. Those figures are projected to continuously grow for the next 10 years. At the same time, the working-age population is expected to increase to around 67 per cent of the total population by 2030, as compared to 63 per cent in 2020. The Government of the Lao People's Democratic Republic has invested in its human capital development in order to reap the benefits of its demographic dividend. As part of such efforts, the Government of the Lao People's Democratic Republic organized its first Human Capital Summit on Education in 2023 and its second Summit on Nutrition in 2024, aimed at enhancing education quality, basic health care and nutrition for the Lao people.

On graduation from least developed country (LDC) status, the Lao Government adopted the Lao People's Democratic Republic Smooth Transition Strategy for LDC Graduation by 2026 and Beyond. According to the outcome of the triennial review by the United Nations Committee for Development Policy in early 2024, the Lao People's Democratic Republic continues to meet all three thresholds for graduation by 2026. However, in the current situation, we are of the view that we must continue to focus our forces and efforts on coping with external shocks and addressing domestic economic and financial difficulties, as well as the impacts of natural disasters, including ongoing floods, in cooperation with the United Nations and development partners, in order for the Lao People's Democratic Republic to be able to overcome the various obstacles and maintain its development momentum towards a smooth, quality and sustainable graduation from LDC status.

I take this opportunity to commend the international community for the successful outcome of the Summit of the Future, which reaffirmed the strong commitment of world leaders to supporting multilateralism, the maintenance of peace and the promotion of international cooperation for sustainable development through the adoption of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), which focuses on the world's current challenges and on building a better future for future generations.

In that connection, the Global Digital Compact (resolution 79/1, annex I) has set the goals of eliminating all obstacles and facilitating digital cooperation at the international level, while also ensuring that technological progress contributes to the acceleration of the achievement of the SDGs. The Lao People's Democratic

Republic always takes our common responsibility for future generations into consideration, and therefore highly values the adoption of the Declaration on Future Generations (resolution 79/1, annex II), which prescribes the principles and commitments to protecting our world peace and stability, ensuring equal access to social services, information and innovation and addressing the impacts of climate change, among others. All of those agreements will help ensure the sustainability of our planet so as to guarantee that future generations can continue to use natural resources in the future.

Despite being one of the least pollution-emitting countries in the world, the Lao People's Democratic Republic, like many other countries, has encountered the severe consequences of climate change and natural disasters. The Lao People's Democratic Republic has therefore adopted its National Strategic Plan on Climate Change and committed to contributing to international efforts to address climate change. I take this opportunity to congratulate everyone on the success of the High-Level Meeting on Sea Level Rise on 25 September, which reiterated the need for strong international cooperation to address climate change. Notwithstanding the fact that the Lao People's Democratic Republic is landlocked, we stand ready to contribute to international efforts to protect the environment, while calling for support measures to further increase adaptation capacity and resilience for responding to future impacts.

Last but not least, I reaffirm the consistent support of the Government of the Lao People's Democratic Republic for multilateralism and the principles stipulated in the United Nations Charter and international law. The Lao People's Democratic Republic continues to uphold its cooperation with the States Members of the United Nations and regional countries to contribute to the cause of maintaining peace and security, promoting the prosperity of all nations worldwide, overcoming the challenges of today and achieving the Sustainable Development Goals in order to provide enabling conditions for a bright future for current and new generations.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister of the Lao People's Democratic Republic for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Sonexay Siphandone, Prime Minister of the Lao People's Democratic Republic, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Mr. Feleti Penitala Teo, Prime Minister of Tuvalu

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister of Tuvalu.

Mr. Feleti Penitala Teo, Prime Minister of Tuvalu, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Feleti Penitala Teo, Prime Minister of Tuvalu, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Teo (Tuvalu): I am humbled and indeed honoured to stand before the General Assembly today for the first time as the Prime Minister of Tuvalu. I bring to the Assembly and the related high-level summits the best wishes of my people and the Government of Tuvalu.

I take this opportunity to congratulate Mr. President Philemon Yang on assuming the role of President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. Tuvalu wishes him a very successful presidency.

I also take this opportunity to congratulate the outgoing President, Mr. Dennis Francis, for a job well done and for his exceptional leadership during his presidency.

I applaud President Yang's insightful vision for this session, "Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations". The theme challenges us to work in unison to advance peace and security, sustainable development and human dignity. Considering how off-track the progress of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) is, it is a timely and pragmatic call. We must therefore advance in unity as a family of nations.

However, it is imperative to recognize the inherent disparity in our respective development capacities. The least developed countries (LDCs) and small island developing States (SIDS), trailing at the lower end of the global economic scale, face persistent and significant financial challenges in their development efforts. For Tuvalu, a purely import-oriented economy, our economic fragility is further compounded by poor natural endowment, geographical isolation from major markets and environmental vulnerability to climatic crises.

The President's vision to promote human dignity at this critical moment is highly commendable. Ensuring that all individuals have access to resources and opportunities to participate in international decision-making processes is crucial for a just and effective response to those global challenges. In that regard, it is regrettable that the Republic of China on Taiwan continues to be excluded from the United Nations system, despite its significant contributions and partnerships across various development sectors. Resolution 2758 (XXVI) does not preclude Taiwan's meaningful participation in the United Nations system and therefore must include Taiwan, so that no one is left behind. As a vibrant democracy that has made remarkable progress on the SDGs, Taiwan is well positioned to make meaningful contributions to global efforts in achieving those goals.

It is also regrettable to observe that the people of Cuba continue to bear the economic burden of long-standing unilateral economic blockades. Through such measures, Cuba is denied the crucial international development assistance and partnerships necessary to its recovery and rebuilding efforts. Tuvalu aligns itself with Member States that support the lifting of those blockades and joins other Member States' call for the removal of Cuba from the list of State sponsors of terrorism.

Tuvalu applauds the Secretary-General and his team for their tireless efforts in the organization of several important high-level meetings this week. Tuvalu also commends the commitments and constructive contributions of all Member States that enabled the success of those meetings.

Tuvalu welcomes and supports the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), adopted earlier this week at the Summit of the Future, together with the Global Digital Compact and the Declaration on Future Generations (resolution 79/1, annexes I and II). What is needed now is robust political will and unwavering commitment to implementing the provisions of the Pact. We are heartened by the Pact's call for a bold and comprehensive outcome document on addressing climate change at the upcoming twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, in Azerbaijan.

While climate change affects every nation, its impacts are disproportionately felt more by small island developing States like Tuvalu. Despite our insignificant contribution to climate change, we face the most severe consequences when climate-induced disasters do occur. We therefore urge all Member States to honour their commitments to increasing support for climate financing and technology transfer to help nations like Tuvalu develop and enhance their adaptive resilience.

The science is very clear that atmospheric temperatures continue to rise due to the increasing emission of greenhouse gases from burning fossil fuels. Therefore, phasing out fossil fuels is crucial to global efforts to reduce carbon emissions and

curb global warming. Towards that objective, Tuvalu and several other like-minded nations are leading the promotion of the fossil fuel non-proliferation treaty initiative. The initiative is to garner international support for a binding treaty arrangement that would regulate and limit the use of fossil fuel, with the ultimate objective of total phase out. I take this opportunity to invite other States Members of the United Nations family to support the initiative.

I express the sincere hope that the commitments contained in the Pact will provide a much-needed reboot to the global multilateralism architecture and the United Nations system generally. Tuvalu supports and look forward to the effective implementation of the Pact for the Future to build a more equitable global system in which no nation and no community is left behind.

Climate change-induced sea level rise is and will always be a top priority for Tuvalu. Sea level rise is not only a top development priority but also a top survivability priority for Tuvalu. The Pacific Ocean that used to define would soon engulf us and determine our future existence if sea level rise is not halted and Tuvalu's coastlines are not suitably fortified and reinforced. Sea level rise is a global and multidimensional phenomenon that requires immediate global actions.

For Tuvalu, sea level rise poses the greatest existential threat to our economy, culture and heritage and to the land that nourished our ancestors for centuries. Current predictions of the rate of sea level rise are frighteningly disturbing. The predictions are that by 2050, in 26 years' time, more than 50 per cent of Tuvalu's land territory will be regularly flooded by regular tidal surges. Fifty years later, in 2100, more than 90 per cent of Tuvalu's land territory will suffer the same fate. The predictions do not account for severe climatic conditions like cyclones and hurricanes, which would exponentially accelerate the reaching of those thresholds.

Tuvalu therefore commends the President for the timely and successful organization of the High-Level Meeting on Sea Level Rise on Wednesday. Tuvalu is heartened by the commitment of all Member States to strengthening international cooperation and partnerships for more comprehensive and effective responses to sea level rise. We are committed to providing the Secretary-General with our national report on that issue within the suggested timeframe and look forward to contributing to a concise, action-oriented and intergovernmentally negotiated declaration.

The High-Level Meeting marked the take-off of our global effort to shape an ambitious declaration of the General Assembly in September 2026. The declaration, in my considered view, must be a strong pronouncement in support of the expectations of the 1 billion people affected by sea level rise. The declaration shall be an unwavering commitment to our sovereignty, dignity, prosperity and rights. The declaration must be action-oriented and comprehensive. Towards those objectives, we expect the declaration to include the following principles.

First, the declaration shall ascertain the principle of statehood continuity as a tenet of international law and international cooperation and affirm that statehood cannot be challenged under any circumstances of sea level rise.

Secondly, the declaration shall reaffirm the permanency of maritime zones established in accordance with the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea.

Thirdly, the declaration shall call on the international community and regional institutions to enable human mobility pathways that facilitate movement in a safe, orderly and dignified manner.

Fourthly, the declaration shall devise concrete programmes for the international community to support our efforts to safeguard our unique culture and heritage, both tangible and intangible.

Fifthly, the declaration shall establish dedicated and innovative financing mechanisms to support the positive adaptation journeys of the most vulnerable communities.

Finally, the declaration shall underscore the importance of knowledge, data and science to anticipate and plan for the impacts of sea level rise.

I wish to reiterate the commitment of Tuvalu to addressing the effects of climate change through identified, science-based, transformative and adaptive solutions. Those solutions are designed to reclaim and elevate land, enhance our resilience against sea level rise and ensure that our sovereign rights to our land and cultural identity are safe and protected for our future generation.

I acknowledge the efforts of the Pacific peoples in addressing the pressing issue of sea level rise. The Pacific leaders, in their annual meeting in Tonga last month, reiterated the importance of the 2021 Declaration on Preserving Maritime Zones in the Face of Climate Change-Related Sea-Level Rise and the 2023 Declaration on the Continuity of Statehood and the Protection of Persons in the Face of Climate Change-Related Sea-Level Rise. The Pacific leaders also called for sea level rise to be a stand-alone item on the General Assembly's agenda and other related United Nations processes, such as the Conferences of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change.

Furthermore, in 2021, Tuvalu, in collaboration with Antigua and Barbuda, established the Commission of Small Island States on Climate Change and International Law. In May, the Commission successfully secured an advisory opinion from the International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea that clarifies that greenhouse gas emissions pollute the marine environment and that States have the legal responsibilities to take all necessary measures to prevent, reduce and control them. The advisory opinion is a significant development, as it shifts the conversation from political commitments to binding legal obligations.

The science on climate change is comprehensive and clear that the climate is changing and is significantly impacting small islands through rising sea levels. Nationalized scientific data and information has allowed my Government to create a 3D model that specifically demonstrates the impacts of climate change and sea level rise in Tuvalu. We showcased the 3D model here in New York during the high-level week. I must admit that it is alarming and disturbing to see how quickly Tuvalu's entire land territory will be engulfed by rising seas as greenhouse gas emissions continue to increase.

I am pleased to share with the General Assembly a watershed treaty between Tuvalu and Australia, the Falepili Union Treaty. The Treaty carries the title of the treasured Tuvalu value of *falepili*, which connotes good-neighbourliness, caring and sharing, and mutual respect. The Treaty is firmly grounded on mutual respect for each other's sovereignty, territorial integrity and political independence. The Treaty prioritizes three key areas, namely, climate cooperation, mobility with dignity and shared security.

For the first time, there is a country — Australia — that has committed legally to come to the aid of Tuvalu, upon request, when Tuvalu encounters a major natural disaster, when Tuvalu is experiencing a major public health pandemic or when Tuvalu is subjected to some form of military aggression. For the first time also, another country — Australia — is legally committed to recognizing the permanency of the future statehood and sovereignty of Tuvalu, despite the impacts of climate change, particularly sea level rise. The Treaty also provides for a mobility pathway for citizens of Tuvalu who chose to live, work and study in Australia. I very much look forward to the full operationalization of the Falepili Union Treaty next year, in 2025.

Let me reiterate Tuvalu's unwavering support for the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for SIDS, which was adopted in May. The Agenda addresses the unique challenges faced by small island developing States through a multifaceted approach that includes climate action, economic diversification and social development.

Tuvalu is one of the smallest States in the world in terms of its land territory and population, but it is a very large ocean State because of the extent of its exclusive economic zone. Tuvaluans therefore have a very close affinity with the Pacific Ocean. The Pacific Ocean sustains our daily lives and economic prosperity. The impacts of climate change on fish stock migration and declining marine resources, together with illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing and marine pollution, pose a major challenge to Tuvalu's progress towards sustainable economic development.

As a signatory of the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction, Tuvalu is committed to the sustainable utilization and equitable distribution of marine resources. Tuvalu is also committed to the 2050 Strategy for the Blue Pacific Continent, which is aimed at protecting the ocean. That commitment is reinforced by United Nations Environment Assembly resolution 5/14, which calls for the development of an ambitious, international, legally binding agreement to end plastic pollution, based on a comprehensive approach that addresses the full life cycle of plastic, including its production, design and disposal.

Tuvalu expresses its sincere gratitude to the Economic and Social Council for its consideration of deferring Tuvalu's graduation from the least developed country category earlier this year. It is important to reiterate that, while Tuvalu has met the graduation thresholds for some time now, it continues to have serious reservations about leaving the group. As one of the last remaining Pacific Island countries in the LDC category, Tuvalu is exceptionally vulnerable to the impacts of climate change and rising sea levels. Even the Committee for Development Policy has recognized that Tuvalu's vulnerability to climate change is not only severe but permanent. For that reason, Tuvalu applauds the newly developed multidimensional vulnerability index, which could complement the traditional gross national income indicator as the basis for development and climate finance access.

Tuvalu commends the commemoration and promotion of the International Day for the Total Elimination of Nuclear Weapons this year. The event serves as a powerful reminder of the catastrophic consequences of nuclear testing and warfare, as well as the ongoing threat posed by those weapons. By observing the event annually, as agreed in resolution 78/27, reinforces our commitment to nuclear disarmament. Tuvalu is a party to the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons.

I am also pleased to announce that in June, Tuvalu became one of the few remaining States to accede to the Biological Weapons Convention, further solidifying our steadfast commitment to creating a world safe from nuclear and other weapons of mass destruction.

Twelve months ago, we adopted the Political Declaration of the high-level meeting on universal health coverage (resolution 78/4, annex), following a review of the implementation of the 2019 Political Declaration of the high-level meeting on universal health coverage, entitled "Universal health coverage: moving together to build a healthier world". This year's adoption of the Political Declaration of the high-level meeting on antimicrobial resistance (resolution 79/2, annex) has once again unified us in a concerted global effort to build a healthier world. As unified as we ought to be, achieving equitable and adequate essential health-care services for all must remain a common priority. International cooperation remains appropriate to efforts to improve and strengthen health care systems, particularly those that are lagging.

On 5 September, Tuvalu celebrated its twenty-fourth anniversary of membership of the United Nations. It has been over two decades since Tuvalu joined the Organization as the 189th Member State. Tuvalu remains grateful for the privilege to engage with other Member States in our common pursuit of the advancement of peace and security, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations.

Next week, 1 October will be the forty-sixth anniversary of Tuvalu's independence. As I prepare to celebrate that momentous occasion for the first time as Prime Minister of Tuvalu, I wish to express my special appreciation and gratitude to the United Nations and its Member States, in particular Tuvalu's generous traditional and emerging partners, for all the support and assistance afforded to my country.

In conclusion, I render Tuvalu's unwavering support for the Pact for the Future and the accompanying Declaration and Compact, adopted at the Summit of the Future earlier in the week. I express the sincere and genuine hope that the commitments contained in the Pact provide the much-needed reboot to the global multilateralism architecture and the United Nations system generally.

The global community must seize this opportunity to reaffirm and recommit to multilateralism and international cooperation, to the Sustainable Development Goals and to the principles of the Charter of the United Nations. Tuvalu calls on the global community to rally behind the Pact for the Future and to build a more equitable global system where no nation and no community is left behind, particularly those nations on the front line of the devastating impacts of climate change and climate changed-induced sea level rise, like my country, Tuvalu.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister of Tuvalu for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Feleti Penitala Teo, Prime Minister of Tuvalu, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Mr. Terrance Micheal Drew, Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, National Security and Immigration, Health and Social Security of Saint Kitts and Nevis

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, National Security and Immigration, Health and Social Security of Saint Kitts and Nevis.

Mr. Terrance Micheal Drew, Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, National Security and Immigration, Health and Social Security of Saint Kitts and Nevis, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Terrance Micheal Drew, Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, National Security and Immigration, Health and Social Security of Saint Kitts and Nevis, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Drew (Saint Kitts and Nevis): Today I rise on behalf of my island developing State and yet, in truth, I speak for the many small island nations — large ocean States — that know too well the high cost of inaction. We are small, yes, but our voices carry the weight of rising seas, thundering storms and livelihoods teetering on the edge of erasure. A sustainable future for the small island developing States (SIDS) demands more from us all.

Let me begin by paying tribute to Mr. Dennis Francis, whose leadership and Presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-eighth session demonstrated the fierce determination of the Caribbean. I thank him for his service. We stand ready to drive the changes necessary for a sustainable, secure world. I thank him for his sterling leadership.

I must also acknowledge Secretary-General Guterres, who, with unflinching resolve, has championed justice, equity and hope. This past year tested our commitment to peace and security, yet it also revealed the vast opportunities we must seize if we are to steer humankind towards a better way.

I congratulate Mr. Philemon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. We have great confidence in his leadership as he guides us with the theme, “Unity in diversity, for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for everyone, everywhere.”

As we convene here in the Hall, I recall the words of former Secretary-General Kofi Annan:

“The future of peace and prosperity that we seek for all the world’s peoples needs a foundation of tolerance, security, equality and justice.”

That foundation is fragile, but it is essential and it is crumbling under the weight of neglect, greed and abuse of power.

Seventy-nine years ago, in the wake of war’s devastation, visionaries sought to build a world where diplomacy and dialogue could triumph over destructive intolerance. Yet today we stand on the precipice of a perilous return to a world where peace is kept at gunpoint, where weapons are romanticized and violence is exalted in the pursuit of absolute power. We need more than diplomatic platitudes. We need a humanity steeped in decency, justice, equity and inclusivity. We must rise from these chambers, not resigned to the idea that the children of Haiti, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, the Sudan, and Palestine are less deserving of the rights and freedoms that we enjoy. We are all one people, one world. We cannot have peace without justice or justice without true, solid equality.

In the Caribbean, our lived reality is of rising tides washing away our hopes, of unforgiving heat setting ablaze our dreams. We pray for rain and receive the flood, dragging our homes and our future into the abyss. When the guns flood our communities, tearing children from their mothers’ arms, it is a collective cry for action. When the global South starves while food wastage continues unabated, we must be shaken from our complacency. The harsh truth is that the world is becoming mortally insecure. We stand on disappearing shores. We are besieged by storms, natural and human-made. Corporate greed, colonial arrogance and unchecked consumerism have torn apart our social contract with each other. We are no longer at peace with nature.

The greatest delusion we feed ourselves is that security and sustainability are separate endeavours. They are, in fact, intertwined. We cannot build secure nations while allowing the climate crisis to rob future generations of their birthright. Security is more than an absence of conflict; it is the presence of dignity, justice and hope. Generations ago, the labour movement in Saint Kitts and Nevis paved the way for our people’s emancipation — an emancipation built on the principles of social, economic and human dignity. Today I echo their call. We must do better. We must be better. Our ambitions must be grander, our vision clearer. When we say, “Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations”, it cannot be a hollow phrase. It must be a sacred commitment, a pledge to every soul, from the wealthiest nation to the smallest island State. For when the waters rise in the South, even the North will eventually drown. When the forests burn in the North, the South too will choke from the smoke. For it is one planet; one human race.

The pandemic has left scars that still fester and global economic fragmentation threatens to deepen the divides between us. For small island States like mine, the failure to meet those goals is not just a disappointment; it is a death sentence. The

clock is ticking and we cannot afford to wait any longer. We must act and we must act now.

Today the Caribbean braces for an intense hurricane season, facing the escalating fury fuelled by warming oceans and unprecedented storms. Our brothers and sisters in Grenada, Carriacou and Petite Martinique, and Saint Vincent and the Grenadines are still recovering from the devastation of Hurricane Beryl, which became the earliest-formed Category 5 hurricane on record this past July. In the Pacific, our colleagues remain exposed to the incessant battering of typhoons that ravage their islands. And as I speak, the south-eastern United States is being pounded by Hurricane Helene. Lives and livelihoods hang in the balance as entire communities brace for the next assault.

Hoteliers in my own country of Saint Kitts and Nevis have approached our Government, stating with a sense of dread that they may soon no longer be able to market themselves as beach resorts. Our famous beaches, once the lifeblood of our tourism-driven economy, are steadily disappearing under the relentless rise of the sea. The sands that once beckoned visitors from across the globe are now receding, swallowed by seas that continue to rise. The loss will be irreversible if we do not act and if we do not act now.

The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) were meant to shield us from such devastation, offering a progressive agenda to build resilience and safeguard our citizens. Yet despite their promise, according to the United Nations *Sustainable Development Goals Report 2024*, only 17 per cent of the targets are on track. Nearly half are showing minimal or moderate progress and over one-third have stalled or even regressed. The clock is ticking and we must do more than observe its passage; we must act before those realities become permanent fixtures in our collective future.

In May 2025, the Government of Saint Kitts and Nevis will proudly co-host the Global Sustainable Islands Summit, in partnership with Island Innovation, a pivotal event dedicated to advancing sustainable development on islands across the globe. Under the slogan “Sustainable future for island communities,” the Summit will build on the momentum of the fourth International Conference on Small Island Developing States, held in 2024, tackling the pressing challenges island nations face. The Summit will be a call to action, a space where we shape practical solutions and partnerships that ripple far beyond our shores. Our islands are the sentinels of climate change and the proving ground for sustainable development. It is in that spirit of shared responsibility and urgent action that I extend a heartfelt invitation to all leaders of island nations gathered here to come, to engage and to commit to meaningful change.

A recent and commendable stride towards equity and inclusion was the adoption of the multidimensional vulnerability index (MVI). That serves as a powerful testament to the potential of multilateralism when it is both purposeful and effective. Saint Kitts and Nevis stands with the Caribbean Community (CARICOM) and the Alliance of Small Island States in welcoming resolution 78/322, while urging this organ to rally the necessary political will and resources to drive its implementation across international financial institutions and multilateral development banks.

For us small island developing States, the MVI is not just another metric; it is a lifeline, offering a means to cushion the relentless blows of climatic and economic crises that disproportionately affect us. Its full implementation will demonstrate to the world that the United Nations and, by extension, the global system remain committed to uplifting the most vulnerable. It will restore trust in a system that must not only recognize vulnerability but actively work to address it.

The time has come to reshape the United Nations and to reform its structures so that they reflect the realities of our modern world. Too many voices remain unheard,

too many nations marginalized. The Security Council must include representation from the regions most vulnerable to the threats of our time: Latin America, the Caribbean and Africa. Nowhere is that change more urgently needed than in the international financial architecture. Saint Kitts and Nevis stands in solidarity with the Government of Barbados in its fight for financial and climate justice, pledging our full support for the Bridgetown Initiative for the Reform of the Global Financial Architecture. That bold framework demands a reformation of global finance, making it more responsive to the unique vulnerabilities of small island developing States like mine. We cannot build resilience without first ensuring that the international system works for the most vulnerable among us.

In the Caribbean, we continue to call for and guard our zone of peace. The Declaration of Argyle for Dialogue and Peace between Guyana and Venezuela serves as a shining example of how we in the Caribbean manage security challenges. We go back to basics; we talk to each other. Specifically, the Declaration has been instrumental in facilitating dialogue between Venezuela and Guyana, demonstrating that even the most complex disputes can be navigated through peaceful means. That model of engagement — one of dialogue and cooperation — is the very essence upon which this institution was founded. The international community would do well to follow that approach and inject new life into our diplomacy. To that end, I reiterate CARICOM's call for an unconditional ceasefire in Gaza in order to put an end to the suffering. The only pathway to peace and to securing fundamental human rights and dignity is through the two-State solution, and Saint Kitts and Nevis stands in full support.

As we face those global challenges, we should always remember Haiti. I want to reiterate that again. We should always remember Haiti. Haiti, the beacon of resilience and courage, stands at the crossroads of its next chapter. Saint Kitts and Nevis, alongside the Caribbean Community, firmly supports the work of the Transitional Presidential Council as it strives to create an environment conducive to a multi-stakeholder political solution. Haiti was there for the downtrodden of the world, lighting the path towards freedom for many, and now the world must be there for Haiti — not because it is a place of sorrow, but because it remains a symbol of human endurance and defiance against injustice. With the establishment of the Multinational Security Support Mission — to which I want to thank the Government and the people of Kenya for their significant contribution — the Caribbean Community seeks to usher in a new day for Haiti's families, a day where schools become places of learning, hospitals are places of healing and markets are not arsenals for gangs but havens for community and prosperity. Haiti's future is not only one of security but one of sustainability and we must rally to give it the peace it deserves.

Year after year, this organ sends a strong message to the people of Cuba — a message of hope and support. The embargo that has isolated Cuba for decades is not right; it continues to be a stain on our collective conscience. Saint Kitts and Nevis joins the Caribbean Community in calling for an end to that unjust embargo and for Cuba's removal from the United States State Department's list of State sponsors of terrorism. Cuba has long been a friend to the Caribbean, its doctors and educators exemplifying true philanthropy. I note here that I am a graduate of the Cuban educational system. Instead of denigrating the island, we should elevate and learn from its sustainable solutions, which have empowered its people and, in turn, the region. A stronger, more sustainable Cuba would enhance the security and sustainability of the Caribbean.

In the same breath, we must not forget Taiwan. The people of Taiwan have proven time and again their firm commitment to sustainable development. The theme of this session, "Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations",

compels us to ensure Taiwan's inclusion in the work of the United Nations system, particularly in the World Health Organization and the International Civil Aviation Organization. Taiwan's leadership in innovation and technology is not just an asset; it is a necessity for the global community to meet the challenges of tomorrow. The United Nations must extend its vision to include Taiwan, a nation whose exclusion undermines the very principles we stand for: peace, sustainable development and human dignity.

Saint Kitts and Nevis is not seeking pity. Saint Kitts and Nevis is not asking for anyone to feel sorry for us. We are small but, as we say in our country, we are *tallawah*. Saint Kitts and Nevis is seeking partnerships. We are on a transformative journey to become a sustainable island State, guided by the seven pillars of water security, energy transition, food security, sustainable industry, sustainable settlements, circular economy and social protection.

We are taking bold, tangible actions by building renewable energy desalination plants for a reliable 24/7 water supply; aggressively advancing geothermal energy on our sister isle of Nevis with the goal of building a unified, sustainable energy grid for both islands and extending it to the rest of the Caribbean; constructing our first modern, climate-smart hospital; building climate-smart, affordable housing solutions, ensuring that our people have a safe, sustainable place to call home; and finalizing one of the Caribbean's largest solar-plus-storage projects. We are on track to meet CARICOM's 25 by 25 agenda, reducing our food imports and bolstering local food production. We have created a Children's Medical Fund to ensure that disadvantaged families can access vital medical care for their children. As a result of that policy, Saint Kitts and Nevis recorded no death of any child between the ages of one and four in 2023. We continue to advance education beyond our universal, compulsory system, promoting lifelong learning as key to national development. All of that and more that we are pursuing demonstrate to the world that we do not just complain. We do not want to be just a part of the problems; we want to be a part of the solution. That is why we will continue to seek partnerships.

We stand at a crossroads. We can no longer afford the luxury of inaction. We must meet the moment with the courage it demands. We must reject business as usual and embrace a new path forward — one that values people over profit, one that prioritizes the planet over power. As we gather in the Assembly, let us remember that we are all stewards of this fragile world. The rising tides do not respect borders and the fires of conflict burn without discrimination.

For Saint Kitts and Nevis, for the Caribbean, for every small island nation whose future hangs in the balance — I ask everyone here to stand with us. Let our voices rise like the oceans that surround us, powerful and unyielding, calling for a future where peace is not just the absence of war but the presence of justice, of sustainability, of hope. Together, let us seize this moment and shape the future. Together, let us stand proud and strong. Together, let us act now, for the moment demands it.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, National Security and Immigration, Health and Social Security of Saint Kitts and Nevis for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Terrance Micheal Drew, Prime Minister and Minister for Finance, National Security and Immigration, Health and Social Security of Saint Kitts and Nevis, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Mr. Kay Rala Xanana Gusmão, Prime Minister of the Democratic Republic of Timor-Leste

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister of the Democratic Republic of Timor-Leste.

Mr. Kay Rala Xanana Gusmão, Prime Minister of the Democratic Republic of Timor-Leste, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Kay Rala Xanana Gusmão, Prime Minister of the Democratic Republic of Timor-Leste, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Gusmão (Timor-Leste) (*spoke in Portuguese; interpretation provided by the delegation*): It is an honour to address the Assembly once again on behalf of Timor-Leste.

This session holds special significance for the Timorese. Last month in Dili, in the presence of the Secretary-General, we celebrated the twenty-fifth anniversary of our historic Popular Consultation. A quarter of a century ago, the people of Timor-Leste, under the auspices of the United Nations, exercised their vote for independence. With the support of the international community, we were able to return the destiny of our country to its people — the destiny of living in peace, freedom and independence after 24 years of resistance and a forgotten war in which more than 200,000 Timorese sacrificed their lives. In 2002, the day we became the 191st Member of the United Nations was a memorable day for the Timorese people and, undoubtedly, a triumph for the international system.

Today I stand here with pride, representing a vibrant democracy that has embraced peace, dialogue, human rights and the rule of law. Although a small country and a young State, Timor-Leste is an example of the relentless pursuit of peace and has affirmed that position on the international stage. Immediately after our vote for independence, we began a process of internal reconciliation among Timorese and external reconciliation with our Indonesian neighbours. Reconciliation is a powerful mechanism for healing the past and building the future. Reconciliation and trust are the instruments of peace that the world needs.

The story of Timor-Leste is a story of hope and resilience. The creation of the United Nations was founded on hope — the hope of achieving peace in all its dimensions and in all places, promoting sustainable development, finding collective solutions to global challenges and threats and uniting international cooperation around those goals. However, there has never been so much hopelessness, uncertainty, instability and distrust as there is in today's world.

As everyone knows, global crises are numerous and complex. The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are due in six years, and I must say that we are far from achieving them. Some countries have lost the race before even leaving the starting line. Timor-Leste and the Group of Seven Plus (g7+) countries proposed the inclusion of SDG 16, "Peace, justice and strong institutions", in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development because we believe that leaving no one behind means prioritizing the most fragile first. Peace and stability are priorities for achieving sustainable development. Without peace, there is no justice, no strong institutions and no development, and without development, peace becomes fragile. Two days ago, the g7+ held a side event here at the United Nations at which we discussed our successes and our setbacks, but the common problem we all faced in solving internal problems was a lack of funding.

Timor-Leste is proud to have already made some significant progress. However, we are well aware that much remains to be done. The overlap of crises has exacerbated social and economic inequalities. Hunger is the most illustrative face of inequality, and it is women, young people and children who suffer the most from that tragedy. In a world where global military spending exceeds \$2.4 trillion, more than 800 million people suffer from extreme hunger. Some countries report alarming levels of hunger, while others endure severe hunger in regions devastated by decades of conflict and instability.

Timor-Leste, being a half-island, is currently focused on diversifying its economy, with particular emphasis on agriculture and the blue economy. By investing in those sectors, we seek to improve the livelihoods of our people and enhance food security. Like many other countries, Timor-Leste is grappling with climate change and unsustainable activities in the ocean. As we know, in the words of Sylvia Earle, “We need to respect the oceans and take care of them as if our lives depended on it. Because they do.”

Timor-Leste is located within the Coral Triangle, a magnificent area of marine biodiversity. Our seas host important ecosystems and marine life and serve as an important migratory route for species such as the incredible pygmy blue whales. Timor-Leste is pleased to share that we have ratified the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction, and we support and actively participate in negotiations on the marine plastics treaty. Domestically, we are committed to exploring our ocean resources in a balanced and sustainable manner, ensuring that we can develop our country while simultaneously protecting our marine environment for future generations.

We recognize that small island developing States (SIDS) and landlocked developing countries face enormous challenges in achieving the SDGs. During the fourth International Conference on SIDS, in Antigua and Barbuda, I noted that we shared a perception of geographical and historical disadvantage. Without financial conditions, capacity-building and technology transfer, we cannot do better.

Moreover, we are trapped in international financial systems that place us at a disadvantage, burdening us with conditional aid, financial assistance and debt. The Loss and Damage Fund, launched at the twenty-eighth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, in Dubai, must secure more significant contributions from wealthy and developed countries. That commitment is urgently needed. As Secretary-General António Guterres stated during his visit to Timor-Leste last month, many of us won the battle against colonialism and the struggle for democracy, but we are still fighting for sustainable development. In his New Agenda for Peace, he also notes that the unequal suffering caused by the effects of climate change is among the greatest injustices in the world. Timor-Leste agrees. We all know that we can win this battle only with genuine global solidarity and effort. Unconditional support based on our identified needs and priorities is required.

It is with sadness that I stand here in a world ravaged by international conflicts and wars — a world that, when not entirely at war, is threatened by war. We possess the instruments of international law, diplomacy and multilateral cooperation to resolve disputes peacefully, but those instruments are not applied consistently and are often ignored. We call for the peaceful resolution of international disputes and conflicts, whether related to borders, sovereignty or cooperation. Timor-Leste will host the twenty-fourth Regional Conference of the Special Committee on Decolonization in May 2025.

Western Sahara is a country that has faced political uncertainty for almost five decades. In October 1975, the International Court of Justice held that Western Sahara was a non-self-governing territory and that it should follow the parameters and principles stated in resolution 1514 (XV), on self-determination, through the free and genuine expression of the will of the people of the territory. More recently, rulings by courts of European Union, as well as the decision of the African Court on Human and Peoples’ Rights, state that Western Sahara is separate and distinct from Morocco and that Morocco does not exercise any sovereignty over the territory. When, in 1991, the Security Council established the United Nations Mission for the Referendum in Western Sahara, through resolution 690 (1991), the Timorese

were motivated and hopeful that one day it would be our turn, too. But in 1992, the referendum in Western Sahara was postponed. Following the adoption of dozens of Security Council resolutions, I call for their implementation, leading to a referendum on self-determination for the Sahrawi people.

I am pleased to see the presence of the Palestinian delegation as an observer of the United Nations, and I hope that next year we will also have the presence of a Sahrawi delegation. I call for an immediate ceasefire between the POLISARIO Front and Morocco to pave the way for an exhaustive dialogue based on good will between the parties for a negotiated peaceful solution that is acceptable to both sides and respects the will of the Sahrawi people. I call on Secretary-General António Guterres to embrace the just cause of the Sahrawi people, as Kofi Annan did for the Timorese cause.

War cannot be an instrument of domination. It is a scourge that destroys lives, communities and nations, and it cannot — and indeed does not — remain confined within borders. We must ensure that international law is respected by all, not just by some.

Timor-Leste expresses its deepest concern and full support for a peaceful resolution to the conflict between Israel and Palestine and calls for an immediate end to the genocide and for an end to the war in Ukraine. I call for the principles of the Charter of the United Nations to be applied, with courage and leadership. I call for more thought to be given to peoples and individuals, victims of global policies and leadership and an entrenched status quo.

One example of that is Cuba, a friend of Timor-Leste without which our health sector would still be in a deplorable condition. The economic, commercial and financial embargo imposed on Cuba for decades, with its implications for its people, is unacceptable. If the focus this year is on human dignity, let us please not forget the most forgotten people of the world.

The Security Council must become more representative and its decisions must reflect the collective will of the international community. The voices of smaller nations should not be drowned out by the interests of the more powerful States. The world's main peace and security body must be expanded so that it does not reflect underrepresentation and must include the permanent voice of the African continent, as well as Latin America and Asia. Timor-Leste supports comprehensive and long-term reform of the Security Council to expand both permanent and non-permanent membership, as only then will we have a solid and transparent architecture for global peace.

We also believe that the General Assembly itself should have more power on security issues to prevent Member States from becoming paralysed in critical situations.

We are encouraged by the calls of the Secretary-General to eliminate nuclear weapons and other weapons of mass destruction before they eliminate us. Timor-Leste has ratified the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty and the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons and calls on everyone to contribute to ensuring our common future, including through the ratification of the Treaty by Pacific Island nations. We call on all nations, especially in the developed world, to join us in building a fairer, more equitable and more sustainable future, and in doing so fulfil the vision of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1).

Before concluding, I must express my appreciation to the Secretary-General, who now also holds Timorese nationality, for his efforts to transform the present into a future of dignity for all generations. That vision will be possible only if all United

Nations Member States can overcome their differences and act together to strengthen peace and development. Peace is a global mission; development is a global duty.

I recall that, without the United Nations, our future would be even darker. Even with all its weaknesses and need for change, the United Nations is the most promising mechanism available to us to overcome the challenges of our time. Without the Organization, we would truly have no way out. With perseverance and the will to do good, no matter how inconvenient it may seem, no challenge is insurmountable.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister of the Democratic Republic of Timor-Leste for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Kay Rala Xanana Gusmão, Prime Minister of the Democratic Republic of Timor-Leste, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Mr. Siaosi ‘Ofakivahafolau Sovaleni, Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Tonga

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Tonga.

Mr. Siaosi ‘Ofakivahafolau Sovaleni, Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Tonga, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Siaosi ‘Ofakivahafolau Sovaleni, Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Tonga, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Sovaleni (Tonga): I bring warmest Pacific greetings from the Kingdom of Tonga and our blue Pacific continent.

First, I wish to congratulate Mr. Philemon Yang on assuming the presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session.

I also thank his predecessor, Mr. Dennis Francis, for his able leadership during a period where global challenges continued to increase in numbers and complexity.

I acknowledge Secretary-General António Guterres for his steadfast stewardship of our home, the United Nations, during these troubled times.

We convene at this seventy-ninth session under the theme “Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations”. My delegation pledges our unwavering support for that noble goal. At a time of escalating conflicts and near-conflict situations on the horizon, all too often triggered by political instability, economic disparities, social tensions and the security threats posed by climate change, we must rally around that goal. If we fail to do so, we will further erode world peace and fail peoples’ lives far and wide. The long-awaited reform of the Security Council is now urgent and crucial and must happen swiftly. It is our responsibility to resolve adequately the security challenges of the twenty-first century. We must include non-traditional security issues like climate change on its agenda. Further, we must include the voice of small island developing States (SIDS).

In our quest to leave no one behind, we must take a hard look at the lagging progress in achieving sustainable development by 2030. That goal is equally imperilled unless we change our approach. Human dignity is intrinsically built on peace, security and sustainability. If we cannot act now, decisively and collectively, the goal to leave no one behind will be just words and we will have further eroded peoples’ trust and hopes. The key is not words; the key is our shared commitment to action.

I commend the tireless efforts that led to the ambitious and balanced text of the Summit of the Future. Not only do we stand at a critical juncture in our collective history, but the time is now to safeguard the needs and interests of present and future generations. The spirit of compromise and commitment demonstrated by delegations and regional groups gives us hope that multilateralism can work. As our forebearers, our founders, did, we pledge to spare succeeding generations from the scourge of war and we commit to building a world where there is hope and they can thrive.

Our commitment must be to sustainable development, to the preservation of our planet's resources and to the pursuit of a future that is inclusive, equitable, secure and sustainable. We must commit to the highest values of human dignity and justice. We therefore welcome the adoption of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1). We are resolute in our commitment to working collaboratively with Member States to advance peace, sustainable development and human dignity. We hope for action that will leave no one behind.

Last month, Tonga assumed the chairmanship of the fifty-third Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting. We were honoured to welcome Secretary-General Guterres as a special guest. I reiterate our Forum leaders' and Pacific people's deep gratitude for his in-person participation. We now look forward to continued and augmented support and tailored solutions from the United Nations in our efforts for our peoples' lives and futures.

The theme of our meeting was "A resilient Pacific: Build better now". The urgency of our theme certainly was underscored by the torrential rains, flash-flooding and 6.5 magnitude earthquake that struck Nuku'alofa on the first day of the meeting. That was yet another stark reminder of our vulnerability to natural disasters. Once again, it also demonstrated our unwavering resilience and the priority we place on the full implementation of our Early Warnings For All initiative by 2027 and for disaster preparedness.

The *Sustainable Development Goals Report 2024* before us is grim. The report reveals what we see every day on the ground — a stark divergence from the ambitious targets set forth in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. Climate change, escalating inequalities and persistent conflicts are compounding challenges, leaving many countries struggling to meet even the most fundamental goals. Without urgent and coordinated global action, the vision of a more equitable and sustainable world may remain just another elusive dream. That means eroded trust in our ability to keep promises; it will jeopardize both our planet and its inhabitants. We must and we can confront those seemingly insurmountable challenges with innovation and determination. We can no longer afford business as usual.

Decade after decade, year after year, we present to this body the existential threat that climate change poses to the Pacific, including Tonga. Our situation has become even more urgent this year. Climate change is the single greatest threat to the survival and prosperity of the blue Pacific continent. Once again, we urge the international community to promptly and dramatically act to restrict global warming to 1.5°C. Industrialized nations must strengthen their emissions reduction commitments. We must ensure that climate finance is speedily and easily accessible to Pacific island nations. Let there be no doubt — we are teetering on the brink of a climate catastrophe.

While in Tonga, the Secretary-General issued a global SOS — Save our Seas — warning of rising sea levels. The World Meteorological Organization (WMO) echoed that urgent message, launching the *State of the Climate in the South-West Pacific 2023* report. The report confirms that 2023 was the warmest year on record. The scientific consensus is irrefutable — our climate is changing at an unprecedented rate, with devastating consequences. Extreme weather events are

becoming more frequent and intense. Cyclones and typhoons are wreaking havoc on our communities, leaving behind trails of destruction that take years to repair. The economic toll is immense, but the human cost is far greater: lives lost, communities shattered, hopes lost and futures uncertain.

The most alarming aspect of the crisis is the unprecedented rise in sea levels. The WMO report confirms that sea level rise in the South-West Pacific is significantly exceeding the global average. In some parts of the Pacific, sea levels have risen by 10 to 15 centimetres in the past 30 years — more than double the global average. Without bold and coordinated global action to expedite assistance to the Pacific and its most vulnerable inhabitants, Tonga and other Pacific countries can expect sea levels to rise twofold by mid-century. That will exacerbate the frequency and severity of storm surges and coastal flooding.

For the nations of the Pacific, those changes are not merely environmental issues; they are existential threats that jeopardize the very existence of small Pacific island countries, including Tonga. Rising sea levels are eroding coastlines, swallowing entire islands and forcing families to abandon their ancestral homes. This is not just about losing land; it is about our very identities, losing heritage and culture. We have issued a strong call for including sea level rise as a stand-alone and permanent item on the General Assembly's agenda. The upcoming twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change presents a critical opportunity to operationalize the Loss and Damage Fund, transforming pledges into tangible support for vulnerable nations.

Our ocean, seabed and land are simply who we are. As I mentioned earlier, the severe and irreversible threats posed by climate change-related sea level rise will disproportionately impact the lives, livelihoods, food security, ecosystems and well-being of our people. We have established key declarations, including the 2023 Declaration on the Continuity of Statehood and the Protection of Persons in the Face of Climate Change-Related Sea-Level Rise and the Declaration on Preserving Maritime Zones in the Face of Climate Change-Related Sea-Level Rise. We have also developed and endorsed the Pacific Regional Framework on Climate Mobility and introduced the Framework for Resilient Development in the Pacific. The latter is the world's first regional framework linking climate change and disaster risk. Now we need to act on it.

We commend the United Nations for addressing that critical issue and welcome the high-level plenary meeting on addressing the existential threats posed by sea level rise. The 2023 Pacific Islands Forum Declaration on the Continuity of Statehood takes a clear stance on protecting Pacific peoples' rights and sovereignty. By asserting the continued existence of Pacific Island Forum members' statehood, sovereignty and rights and duties, the Declaration underscores our determination to safeguard both the territorial and human dimensions of our States under international law. The Declaration commits to protecting persons affected by climate change, ensuring that human rights, political status, cultural heritage, identity and dignity are upheld. We call for global cooperation to achieve the Declaration's objectives, in line with international principles of fairness, equity and shared responsibility.

Yes, the challenges we face are immense, but they are not insurmountable. The resilience of the Pacific peoples is legendary. Through centuries, our communities have weathered countless storms, adapted to changing conditions and preserved our rich cultures through adversity. Now more than ever, we must draw upon that resilience. It is now that our Forum islands countries urgently require timely, predictable and scaled-up access to climate financing to protect our communities.

Tonga is proud to announce the establishment of the Pacific Resilience Facility (PRF), a Pacific-led, member-owned and managed climate and disaster

resilience financing facility. Tonga will host the PRF office and we acknowledge the commitments and contributions received from our development partners and friends of the Pacific thus far. We call upon global partners to support our Pacific-led solution, the PRF. The key goal is to bridge the financing gap for smaller, high-impact adaptation projects. I would like to once again thank the Secretary-General for his leadership and commitment in supporting the Pacific Islands Forum by convening a global pledging event for the PRF in 2025. We again urge multilateral climate funds, such as the Green Climate Fund and the Adaptation Fund, to establish dedicated climate finance access windows, tailored to the conditions and needs of vulnerable countries like the Pacific small island developing States.

We appreciate the support for the new 10-year blueprint recognizing the special case of small island developing States, the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for SIDS (ABAS). The Agenda goes beyond being a mere policy framework; it is our collective vision for sustainable growth and resilience in the face of unprecedented challenges. We support the allocation of resources and tailored systems to facilitate the implementation of the concrete actions outlined in the 10 thematic areas of ABAS.

At the same time, reforming the international financial architecture will be crucial to supporting that new programme of action. That includes three substantive global policy agendas: redefining eligibility for development resources, improving access to climate finance and creating long-term debt sustainability. Implementing the ABAS is a vital step toward accelerating the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030. We request the support of key entities within the United Nations system to help implement the ABAS.

Recognizing our unique vulnerabilities, my fellow Pacific Islands Forum leaders welcomed the adoption of the multidimensional vulnerability index (MVI). That practical instrument, advocated over many years by SIDS, offers a more comprehensive understanding of vulnerability, providing renewed hope and impetus to the 2030 Agenda through a more context-responsive approach. We look forward to the operationalization of the MVI in relevant United Nations settings and urge international organizations and financial institutions to consider MVI ratings in their eligibility criteria for grant and concessional financing.

The opinion may be that our Pacific communities are remote and small. Let there be no doubt that our economies continue to suffer, like so many, from the effects of geopolitical tensions and supply chain disruptions. Our people suffer from rising inflation and are experiencing increased hardship and deepening poverty, particularly for the most vulnerable in our blue Pacific region. However, at such critical times, the Pacific Islands Forum is steadfast in its commitment to building a resilient Pacific region of hope and prosperity that ensures that all Pacific peoples can lead productive lives. We invite all partners to support our development aspirations, outlined in our 2050 Strategy for the Blue Pacific Continent and our forthcoming Pacific Roadmap for Economic Development.

Resilient transformation requires Pacific peoples to have access to quality, affordable, accessible and inclusive health and education services. Our blue Pacific region will focus on improving climate-resilient health care, education infrastructures and digital platforms to mitigate risks, manage climate-sensitive diseases and non-communicable diseases (NCDs) effectively, and ensure continuity and equity in learning across our blue Pacific continent. We remain resolute in our commitment to the global fight against NCDs. We reaffirm our commitment to building stronger partnerships among government sectors and other relevant sectors to address the root causes of NCDs through a holistic whole-of-Government and whole-of-society approach.

Addressing the global plastic pollution problem, especially in the marine environment, is a priority. It is a threat to our ecosystems and health. The Pacific Ocean is our Pacific identity. It is a vital resource for food and livelihoods. A healthy ocean will aid in our fight against climate change.

The actions of the Government of Tonga focus on three key thematic areas: national resilience, quality services and affordability, and progressive economic growth. Our goal is to enhance national resilience by creating stronger platforms to tackle natural disasters and address the persistent issues brought about by climate change. We aspire to alleviate relative poverty and improve the quality of social protection measures. We will also mobilize national and international responses to reduce the supply and use of illicit drugs and address harm reduction processes.

We aim to enhance education for everyone, prioritizing safer schools, tackling dropout rates, advocating for gender equality and expanding vocational training opportunities, all while ensuring quality services and affordability. Our efforts are also directed towards improving access to health care that is both affordable and of high quality, with a particular emphasis on addressing the coronavirus disease, NCDs and preventive measures. Our focus is on developing Government services that are of exceptional quality and can be easily accessed by all. That entails enhancing access to high-speed broadband technology and ensuring that energy, communication, drinking water and a clean environment are more affordable. Our main objectives for fostering progressive economic growth include giving priority to trade and private sector development, enhancing the quality and accessibility of public infrastructure and forging stronger partnerships to drive development.

As I conclude, allow me to close the circle and come back to the critical element of this session's theme of leaving no one behind. That aspiration must be our guide for eradicating poverty, ending discrimination and upholding the fundamental rights of individuals, reducing inequalities and vulnerabilities that not only undermine our shared humanity but also leave too many without hope.

The advancement of one community or nation cannot occur in isolation from the well-being of others. By embracing a fair and equitable playing field, we foster a more resilient and harmonious global society, advancing peace, sustainable development and human dignity. We must travel the path to enduring peace and sustainable development with a sense of urgency, just as others have done before us. In that, let us be guided by shared values of justice and human dignity. Our collective endeavour to leave no one behind must ensure that every person's potential is recognized and their rights upheld, and so we must bridge gaps, dismantle barriers and amplify voices that have historically been marginalized. That is what we owe present and future generations.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Tonga for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Siaosi 'Ofakivahafolau Sovaleni, Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Tonga, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Mr. Hamza Abdi Barre, Prime Minister of the Federal Republic of Somalia

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister of the Federal Republic of Somalia.

Mr. Hamza Abdi Barre, Prime Minister of the Federal Republic of Somalia, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Hamza Abdi Barre, Prime Minister of the Federal Republic of Somalia, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Barre (Somalia): Allow me to begin by congratulating Mr. Philemon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. He can be assured of Somalia's full cooperation as he undertakes the responsibilities entrusted to him during his tenure.

I would also like to take this opportunity to thank his predecessor, Mr. Dennis Francis, for his successful presidency of the previous session.

This session of the General Assembly convenes amid a rising number of global challenges, from escalating transnational conflicts and humanitarian crises to the existential threats of climate change and growing economic inequalities. That resonates profoundly with our theme this year, "Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations". In the spirit of unity and shared responsibility, we must confront the persistent and escalating conflicts that continue to cause immense human suffering and destabilize entire regions. Today we are faced with crises that test our collective conscience and our commitment to peace.

In the Sudan, the conflict has escalated into a severe humanitarian crisis, displacing millions and ravaging communities. Civilians endure indiscriminate violence and widespread gender-based assaults. We urgently call for an immediate cessation of hostilities, the protection of civilians and adherence to international humanitarian law. It is crucial to ensure safe, unrestricted access for humanitarian aid and to foster inclusive dialogue that respects the rights and aspirations of all Sudanese.

In Gaza, the situation has reached catastrophic levels, driven by the persistent blockade and relentless cycles of violence that have created one of the most severe humanitarian disasters of our time. Despite the senseless killing of tens of thousands of men, women and children since last October, over 2 million Palestinians are trapped in an open-air prison, where access to basic goods, services and medical care is severely restricted. Children in Gaza have suffered the most, with many enduring unimaginable trauma, malnutrition and a lack of access to education and health care. They live in constant fear as their homes, schools and hospitals are repeatedly targeted and destroyed. The ongoing conflict has not only destroyed the physical infrastructure of Gaza but has also crushed the hopes of an entire generation. The world cannot continue to turn a blind eye to that gross injustice and the continuous violations of international law by the Israeli Government. We call on the international community to take immediate and decisive action to enforce an unconditional ceasefire, lift the inhumane blockade and to recommit to a political process that ensures a just and lasting peace based on the two-State solution, thereby restoring the rights, dignity and future of the Palestinian people.

In Ukraine, the war, now in its third year, has inflicted a devastating toll on civilians, destroying homes and critical infrastructure and leaving millions without essential services. The legacy of trauma and displacement will affect generations. We urgently call for an immediate cessation of hostilities, a ceasefire and adherence to international humanitarian and human rights law, including by avoiding attacks on civilians, critical infrastructure and nuclear facilities. It is essential to open channels for dialogue and achieve a lasting political settlement. The international community must act swiftly to prevent further escalation and support efforts for peace.

While international crises demand our attention, we must not overlook regional threats that directly challenge national sovereignty and stability. Somalia currently faces a serious threat from Ethiopia's recent actions, which flagrantly violate our

territorial integrity. Ethiopia's attempts to annex parts of Somalia, under the guise of securing sea access, are both unlawful and unnecessary. Somali ports have always been accessible for Ethiopia's legitimate commercial activities, reflecting our commitment to regional trade and cooperation. However, Ethiopia's aggressive manoeuvres, including its controversial agreement with one of our regional administrations, undermine Somalia's sovereignty and embolden secessionist movements, threatening our national unity. Those actions not only sow division at a time when Somalia is striving for peace and cohesion, but also serve as propaganda for terrorist groups like Al-Shabaab, which exploit Ethiopia's provocations to recruit and radicalize vulnerable individuals. Such destabilizing behaviour poses a significant risk to the security and stability of the entire Horn of Africa.

Somalia asserts its sovereign right to defend its territorial integrity and calls on Ethiopia to cease its provocations and adhere to international law. We urge the international community to stand with Somalia in condemning those violations and upholding the principles of national sovereignty and territorial integrity, which are the cornerstones of international peace and security. Regional stability depends on mutual respect for those principles, and Ethiopia must be held accountable for actions that threaten to destabilize the Horn of Africa.

While conflicts may capture the headlines, we must not lose sight of other pressing global challenges that demand our immediate attention and collective action. Somalia's experience underscores the importance of sustainable funding for peacekeeping. For over 15 years, we have hosted key African Union missions, including the African Union Mission in Somalia and the African Union Transition Mission in Somali, which have been critical in countering Al-Shabaab and supporting State-building. As the new African Union Support and Stabilisation Mission in Somalia takes over, with a focus on counter-terrorism and capacity-building, its success will depend on reliable funding. Peacekeeping is about creating lasting stability, not just maintaining peace, and we urge the international community to support innovative funding solutions to ensure that those missions fulfil their vital roles.

Climate change is a global crisis that touches every life and every community, but nowhere is its impact more deeply felt than in vulnerable nations like Somalia. We endure relentless droughts, devastating floods and rising temperatures that tear apart our communities and threaten our very survival. While the recent twenty-eighth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change made important strides with the creation of the Loss and Damage Fund and commitments to expand renewable energy, there remains a significant challenge — accessing those funds.

For many developing countries, the reality is that the complex bureaucracy, rigid criteria and lack of necessary resources often stand in the way of receiving the help they so desperately need. It is not just about making promises; it is about ensuring that those promises can reach the people who need them most. We call on the global community to simplify access to those critical funds so that countries like Somalia can build resilience, protect our people and secure a future where everyone has the chance to thrive.

Reforming the Security Council is essential to ensuring that it reflects today's geopolitical realities. The current structure no longer adequately represents the voices and concerns of the world's nations, particularly those in Africa, Asia and Latin America. We support the Ezulwini Consensus, which calls for a more representative and inclusive Council. That reform is necessary to enhancing the United Nations credibility and effectiveness in addressing the full spectrum of global challenges, from peace and security to development and human rights.

Reforming the international financial institutions is also crucial to building a fairer global economy that promotes inclusive growth and sustainable development. The existing international financial system is heavily skewed in favour of a few, perpetuating inequalities and restricting the ability of developing nations to thrive. We call for reforms that make those institutions more accountable, transparent and responsive to the needs of the world's poorest and most vulnerable.

Achieving the Sustainable Development Goals is not just an ambition; it is a necessity. With only six years left, the world is far behind on our collective promise to end poverty, protect our planet and ensure peace and prosperity for all by 2030. We must urgently renew our commitment by increasing funding, creating innovative partnerships and focusing on reaching the most vulnerable. As Somalia takes its seat on the Security Council, we stand ready to work with all nations to address those challenges, strengthen cooperation, promote multilateralism and build a world where no one is left behind.

Somalia has come a long way on its journey towards stability and development. This past year has been particularly significant, marked by critical milestones that signal Somalia's rising trajectory. We have successfully completed the debt relief process, allowing us to reclaim our economic sovereignty and reintegrate into the global financial system. Additionally, Somalia's accession to the East African Community marks a new era of regional integration, trade and cooperation. We have also made a historic stride in lifting the long-standing arms embargo, a step that will further enable us to safeguard our sovereignty and security.

Security is fundamental to development and Somalia has prioritized the fight against terrorism with remarkable success. In the past two years, our national security forces have reclaimed more than two-thirds of the territory that was once under the control of the Al-Shabaab terrorist group, significantly diminishing its operational capabilities.

With marked progress in governance, democratization and political stability, Somalia stands on the brink of significant economic growth, with vast untapped resources and a strategic location along major maritime trade routes. Our arable land offers great potential for agricultural production and our livestock sector is already among the strongest globally. We also have one of Africa's highest potentials for renewable energy, particularly in on-shore wind power, and our extensive coastline provides rich opportunities for sustainable fishing and other sectors of the blue economy. To capitalize on those assets, we are drafting a national transformation plan that outlines our vision for leveraging our resources to achieve stability, self-reliance and prosperity. We welcome international investment and cooperation to help us realize that potential, integrate into the global economy and contribute to regional peace and stability through strong partnerships.

As we look ahead, Somalia is determined to be defined not by the tragedies of its past but by the possibilities of its future. Let us act now to build a future where every nation, every community and every person can thrive in dignity and peace.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister of the Federal Republic of Somalia for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Hamza Abdi Barre, Prime Minister of the Federal Republic of Somalia, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Mr. Christian Ntsay, Prime Minister and Head of Government of the Republic of Madagascar

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister and Head of Government of the Republic of Madagascar.

Mr. Christian Ntsay, Prime Minister and Head of Government of the Republic of Madagascar, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Christian Ntsay, Prime Minister and Head of Government of the Republic of Madagascar, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Ntsay (Madagascar) (*spoke in French*): Driven by a deep sense of honour and responsibility, I address the Assembly today strong in the mandate entrusted to me by Mr. Andry Rajoelina, President of the Republic of Madagascar, and on behalf of the Malagasy people.

I welcome the election of Mr. Philemon Yang as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. His exemplary career and deep knowledge of international issues are invaluable assets in guiding our work. He can rest assured of the support of Madagascar, in its capacity as newly elected Vice-President of the General Assembly for the 2024-2025 term, in the accomplishment of his mission.

The theme chosen for this session, “Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations”, resonates with particular acuity in these times of serious uncertainties in and for the world. How powerfully that reminds us today of the interconnectedness of global challenges and the need for a collective, united and resolute response. Indeed, peace, the fragile foundation of a world plagued by divisions, is today undermined by a multiplicity of crises with dangerous and deep geostrategic ramifications. Far from being a regionalized conflict, the war in Ukraine is shaking the international order, exacerbating geopolitical tensions, heightening food and energy insecurity and endangering global peace and security.

Terrorism and transnational crime continue to sow terror and desolation, disproportionately affecting the most vulnerable populations. The proliferation of weapons and drugs, particularly in conflict zones, fuels a vicious cycle of violence and instability, thereby hampering long-term development efforts and mortgaging the future of entire generations.

The climate emergency has become a tangible and devastating reality. The increase in extreme weather events, the degradation of ecosystems and the loss of biodiversity are all warning signs that must push us to act with determination and speed.

Growing inequalities on an international scale are fertile ground for social tensions, conflicts and instability. The coronavirus disease pandemic, far from being a great leveller, has exacerbated existing fractures, highlighting the vulnerability of health-care and social protection systems in many countries and further widening the gap between rich and developing countries.

Faced with those threats, we cannot give in to fear or resignation. Multilateralism, embodied by the United Nations, remains our best weapon and our collective instrument for building a safer and more peaceful world. However, and unfortunately, it is clear that the current multilateral system, dating back to the post-war period, is struggling to respond effectively to the challenges of a rapidly and profoundly changing world. A courageous and ambitious reform of the United Nations, particularly of the Security Council, is more essential than ever. Africa, a continent in full demographic and economic growth, cannot remain on the periphery of global decision-making centres.

The effective implementation of the Paris Agreement on Climate Change and the strengthening of commitments to reducing greenhouse gas emissions are categorical imperatives for safeguarding the future of our planet and guaranteeing the well-being of future generations. To that end, the President of the Republic of Madagascar,

Mr. Andry Rajoelina, recalled in his speech at the twenty-sixth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, held in Glasgow in September 2022, the need to accelerate the mobilization of \$100 billion from the Paris Agreement to finance an energy transition policy in Africa. The fight against climate change cannot therefore be disassociated from the issue of development. It is imperative to support developing countries in their transition to a green and resilient economy by providing them with adequate financial and technological resources and by recognizing their right to development.

It is imperative and urgent to promote a more inclusive and equitable model of world development that leaves no one behind. It is time to move from words to action. It is time to translate our commitments into concrete actions, especially for Africa, by investing massively in education, health care, drinking water, social protection for all, infrastructure, innovation and job creation, especially for young people and women. If we aspire to inclusive multilateralism, it is time to promote fairer and more equitable international trade and to promote and guarantee equitable access to knowledge, technologies and fairer financing and investment systems. Social justice and lasting peace in the world depend on it.

Madagascar, aware of those global challenges and the urgency of providing concerted and lasting solutions, is committed with determination, alongside the United Nations and its Member States, to build a fairer, more united and more sustainable world. The culture of *Fihavanana*, the art of living together deeply rooted in Malagasy culture, guides our action. It reflects our deep aspiration to live in harmony, mutual respect and solidarity, ensuring that no one is left behind and never forgetting the most vulnerable, thus working towards a fairer society.

The general policy of the State of Madagascar, reflecting the vision of Mr. Andry Rajoelina, President of the Republic, makes human capital the first pillar of development. Over the past five years, Madagascar has invested heavily in education and teaching, health care and family planning, security, innovative and inclusive social programmes, the fight against malnutrition, and infrastructure to catch up on development and break the vicious circle of poverty. The country continues to invest heavily in those areas, which constitute the basic pillar of our action for human development.

True to its tradition as a country with a peaceful and tolerant people, Madagascar has made democracy, respect for the rule of law and good governance crucial tools for maintaining stability, strengthening peace and security and consolidating its path toward sustainable development. Of course, that explicitly and amply justifies the Global Peace Index ranking of Madagascar in second place among the most peaceful countries in sub-Saharan Africa in 2024.

Certainly, the challenges are numerous for my country; nevertheless, the leadership of Mr. Andry Rajoelina, President of the Republic, is living up to the hopes of my fellow citizens, who have given him a new mandate in 2024 for the agricultural and industrial transformation of Madagascar in order to create more jobs and decent incomes for young people and rural people, to generate more added value for the Malagasy economy and to establish more peace and sustainable development for the country. Today Madagascar is the third-largest rice producing country in Africa, but aspires to become the first, through the Government's new political orientation of rural development, by focusing on the optimal exploitation of all the rice basins of the country; on new knowledge and technologies in the use of agricultural inputs by all farmers and improving irrigation infrastructure in order to double or even triple productivity in the short term; and on agricultural aggregation to better attract private investment in the intensive production of rice and other agricultural speculations, such as potatoes, dry grains and others.

In relation to development challenges, Madagascar intends to strengthen its tireless efforts to improve its road network, in particular by building the Route du Soleil, linking all the regions of the eastern side of the big island. That will further generate growth in public and private investments, the fluidity of trade, the promotion of tourism in the regions, the accelerated transformation of regional economies, and the strengthening of peace and security in the country.

Those efforts with respect to our road network are part of the Government's priority action to build major structural projects for my country. Renewable energy is therefore among the priorities to which my Government is committed today in carrying out its industrialization plan and multiple actions to improve the living conditions of the population, particularly the rural population, by substantially and sustainably reducing the State subsidy of the cost of electricity production so as to allocate it judiciously to development projects. To that end, we are currently accelerating the implementation of a solar parks initiative for 47 districts across the country and the start of construction on several hydroelectric power plants and solar power plants with private investors and development partners, which could achieve an additional production of nearly 500 megawatts over the next four to five years. Our objective is to double the contributions of the agricultural and industrial sectors to Madagascar's gross domestic product in order to generate real growth that creates jobs and sustainable income for young people and rural inhabitants, thereby transforming the economy and substantially reducing poverty for a new development boom for the big island.

Aware of the threats of climate change to peace, security and development, Madagascar, although a low emitter of greenhouse gases, is among the countries most vulnerable to the effects of climate change, suffering the full brunt of cyclones, drought, coastal erosion and loss of biodiversity. That threatens to significantly reduce or even destroy the economic and social progress generated by the agricultural and industrial transformations currently being driven by the country. As Madagascar is one of the rare countries that are saving the planet, with a negative carbon footprint thanks to our forests, one of the true green lungs of the African continent, I urge the international community to intensify and accelerate financing for climate adaptation for all vulnerable countries, particularly island countries like Madagascar. Madagascar is thus determined to preserve that precious natural heritage for future generations.

In conclusion, Madagascar calls more than ever for a strengthened and fairer multilateralism, a multilateralism based on dialogue, cooperation and solidarity. Madagascar will continue to work tirelessly, alongside the United Nations and its Member States, to build a world of peace, development and dignity for all.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister and Head of Government of the Republic of Madagascar for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Christian Ntsay, Prime Minister and Head of Government of the Republic of Madagascar, was escorted from the rostrum.

The Acting President: I now call on His Excellency Mr. Filip Ivanović, Deputy Prime Minister for Foreign and European Affairs of Montenegro.

Mr. Ivanović (Montenegro): It is my pleasure to address the General Assembly today on behalf of Montenegro and to reiterate our unequivocal support for and commitment to the goals and principles of the Charter of the United Nations, as well as the overall mission of the world Organization, as we are confronted with unprecedented challenges across the globe, not only in terms of international peace and security but in other domains as well.

Allow me to extend due acknowledgement and gratitude to the President of the General Assembly at its previous session, Mr. Dennis Francis of Trinidad and Tobago, for his achievements and guidance through these unsettling circumstances.

Furthermore, I would like to express our best wishes to his successor, Mr. Philemon Yang of Cameroon. We wish him a successful tenure and we welcome his choice of this year's debate theme, as it faithfully portrays the very mission of the United Nations. He can count on the full support of the Montenegrin delegation.

Leaving no one behind while acting together for peace and security, sustainable development and human dignity is the key challenge before the United Nations, to which, unfortunately, as a community, we have still failed to provide an effective and a comprehensive response. The achievement of a peaceful and sustainable future, against the backdrop of the one-sided, arbitrary and authoritative actions of a handful of international actors whose actions are jeopardizing the peace and welfare of the majority, will require our full-scale vigilance and awareness and put our words and our rhetoric to a practical test.

Even though ongoing geopolitical developments have clearly demonstrated that our efforts have fallen short and that we must do much more — and not just more, but much better — there is a solution and an alternative. It is multilateralism at its best and strongest, led by a more powerful United Nations at the helm of international cooperation and global response, if we are to have a peaceful and prosperous global society.

Nation-based, narrow approaches, as opposed to global solutions, still dominate the international environment and, rather than uniting in joint endeavours with positive global implications, we are losing ground to authoritarianism and unilateral behaviour. In addition to the crisis in the Middle East, Russia's aggression against Ukraine, civil war in the Sudan and instability in the Horn of Africa, Yemen, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Myanmar and Haiti, we are facing a number of other issues, including the climate emergency, growing food insecurity, the erosion of democracy and human rights, growing terrorism and violent extremism, cyberthreats and backsliding on the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), which only contribute to an already alarming global situation.

We commend and support the Secretary-General's New Agenda for Peace, which offers and, indeed, identifies the needed tools and measures for generating a quality response to ongoing challenges, especially through disarmament, greater investment in diplomacy and mediation, the mitigation of geopolitical influence on populations, the prevention of further fragmentation of global trade rules, the effective tackling of climate change issues and the prevention of violence and human rights violations.

As we are all very much aware, the pace of SDG implementation is not at the percentage we hoped for. Member States need to commit to the realization of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development as the best possible way to build long-standing peace and prosperity. However, we need to take into consideration that developing economies are not able to sufficiently finance policies to implement the SDGs, especially in the light of the negative impacts of the coronavirus disease pandemic and Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

We are committed to the promotion of good governance and strong institutions at all levels as key enablers of sustainable development, peace and security, and we strongly advocate reforms towards a more inclusive and representative international financial architecture. Therefore, we support the Secretary-General's appeal for a wholesale reform of the financial architecture, which, at the moment, does not offer developing countries the affordable financing needed to achieve the SDGs, and we join the United Nations in calling upon the international financial structure to finance those countries in the form of eligible credit arrangements.

Within its capabilities, Montenegro will continue to fully support transformation based on accelerating the implementation of the goals and objectives of sustainable development, with the aim of achieving continuous, inclusive and sustainable economic growth while protecting natural resources, improving the state of human resources and strengthening social inclusion.

In view of the volatile situation in the Middle East, I would like to express Montenegro's deep concern over the escalating violence and the humanitarian situation in Gaza, with the destruction of infrastructure and the lack of water, food and health care. We call upon all the parties to de-escalate and engage in meaningful dialogue. Our position is clear — we have condemned the indiscriminate terrorist attacks by Hamas on Israel from 7 October 2023. At the same time, however, we also condemn every act of violence against the civilian population, as well as the interruption of water, food and energy supplies in the Gaza Strip. It is of absolute importance that the humanitarian corridors be opened and humanitarian aid provided to civilians. Any response to a terrorist attack must be undertaken in accordance with international humanitarian law.

We call for a humanitarian ceasefire in Gaza, during which negotiations would be conducted towards reaching a two-State solution, as only a two-State model guarantees lasting and sustainable peace in the region. Again, regardless of the outcome of the negotiations, international law must be upheld by all the parties to the conflict and all hostages still in captivity released immediately and unconditionally.

Montenegro also reiterates its strong condemnation of the destruction that the Russian aggression has caused in Ukraine, including the killing of civilians, as well as unlawful attacks on civilian infrastructure, sexual and gender-based violence and reports of child abductions. We emphasize yet again that there can be no impunity for war and other heinous crimes and that we must ensure responsibility, as a precondition for ensuring a durable peace. In that regard, we support all accountability initiatives to fight impunity and ensure justice.

As the aggression has been particularly devastating for children, we call on the Russian Federation to fully respect international humanitarian law and to immediately implement measures to protect children. In addition, we call on the Russian Federation to cease its attacks on civilian infrastructure and to allow aid to the affected civilian population, including areas under temporary Russian military control.

I would like to reconfirm our support for Ukraine's territorial integrity and sovereignty. Montenegro will continue to support Ukraine and to provide financial, humanitarian, military and diplomatic aid. Like the entire international community, we want to see a comprehensive, just and lasting peace in Ukraine in accordance with the Charter of the United Nations and the resolutions adopted by the General Assembly.

I believe that we can all agree that the ongoing global crises represent one of the gravest challenges to international peace and security since the creation of the world Organization. The world ought to be united as ever before in defending democracy, human rights, freedom of choice and the rule of law, ensuring peace and prosperity and, above all, preserving human lives.

The international community must also do significantly more in the fight against climate change through much-needed decisive actions, such as the full implementation of the Paris Agreement on Climate Change. The recognition of the interconnections between the threefold planetary crises of climate change, biodiversity loss and pollution is needed as we strengthen climate action. The Sustainable Development Goals and the fight against climate change are fundamentally linked to peace and security and human rights. Without peace, no other goals — from human rights

and gender equality to addressing climate change and water, energy and food security — will be achieved.

The increasing number of conflicts, as well as ever-growing threats to international peace and security, require a change in current global practices and the application of a holistic and coordinated approach within the United Nations system, based on prevention. It is in that context that we must take better advantage of the preventive capacity of the Human Rights Council (HRC). As a member of the Council for the term 2022-2024, we fully recognize its contribution to the early warning system when it comes to the prevention of violence and mass violations of human rights. Unfortunately, as is the case with other forums, I am afraid that we do not use them properly or to the fullest scope of their potential.

Nevertheless, Montenegro remains a dedicated defender and promoter of human rights and freedoms and their universality and indivisibility, which we must not take for granted. Advancing and supporting the integration of human rights and the gender perspective into all aspects of the work of the United Nations and preserving the universality and independence of the human rights system, remains our absolute priority. In that light we must further strengthen the HRC role in responding to situations of serious human rights violations globally.

There are still far too many places in the world where peace, stability, human rights and even basic necessities are a luxury. That is something that we cannot be proud of — on the contrary. We place emphasis more often on reactionary humanitarian response rather than on a preventive one. Nevertheless, although of vital importance for the affected population, humanitarian aid needs to be followed by an adequate political solution, representing the best way to sustainably end violence and establish long-term peace.

Montenegro is firmly committed and determined to actively and constructively contribute and support collective efforts to preserve world peace and security, and in that regard supports the New Agenda for Peace as an opportunity to shape new responses to old and emerging threats, including by strengthening prevention, adapting United Nations peacekeeping forces to the new environment and strengthening the peacebuilding architecture, including by ensuring adequate, predictable and sustainable financing for peacebuilding and the implementation of the women and peace and security agenda in all its dimensions, as well as the youth, peace and security agenda. At the same time, Montenegro continues to actively participate in peacekeeping missions, aware that only a safe neighbourhood can provide a guarantee of our own security and prosperity.

Furthermore, we hope that the New Agenda for Peace will contribute to the preservation, implementation and further strengthening of the global architecture for arms control, disarmament and non-proliferation, as well as the multilateral export control regimes, while at the same strengthening multilateral capacities to address the challenges of terrorism and violent extremism, hybrid threats and cyberrisks.

The solution to all of those challenges must go hand-in-hand with the reform of the United Nations system, in line with the reform agenda of the Security Council. In particular, as a small country, we are interested in strengthening the authority and role of the General Assembly, as well as its efficiency, and of other main United Nations bodies. The reform of the United Nations system presupposes a flexible attitude on the part of all participants in the negotiating process, especially in the process of reforming the Security Council. We believe that the reform of the Security Council as the guardian of international peace and security is necessary through the expansion of its membership to achieve a more equal representation of regional groups, which would enable the more effective maintenance of international peace and security. In order for the United Nations to maintain and strengthen its

central position in the global governance system, it is vital that the Organization be reformed and adapted to the geopolitical realities of the twenty-first century and modern democratic values.

In the conditions of increasingly sharp international polarization, fragmentation and instability and of economic and geopolitical uncertainty, it is our common responsibility to show the true value of the United Nations and effective multilateralism as a global solution to global challenges. Either we can choose further isolationism, the erosion of trust, growing xenophobia, nationalism and extremist ideas, or we can make a breakthrough by choosing a future based on the highest civilizational values of equality, justice, responsibility and solidarity, and not on retrograde ideologies, selfishness and unscrupulous populism.

As John Adams once said, “Every problem is an opportunity in disguise”. That is precisely what we have in our hands — a unique opportunity to use the current deteriorating international environment to create momentum for building a more equal, just and sustainable world, with a revitalized multilateralism based on fair and humane globalization and respect for the human rights and dignity of all. We must act for peace and progress now while we still have the chance, built on achieving a just and quality of life for all.

Montenegro, proud of its centuries-old multiethnic and multiconfessional tradition, remains steadfast on the course of a Euro-Atlantic future, good-neighbourly relations and multilateralism. Being a geographical part of Europe, as well as in our values and principles, we are convinced that only the acceleration of integration processes and the stronger incentive of our European Union partners can bring about the stability and prosperity of the region, which is undoubtedly an important asset and contribution to the overall security and stability of Europe. Montenegro will continue to tirelessly pursue and promote those policies, with undiminished commitment to the values of multilateralism and open and friendly cooperation.

The very core principles of the United Nations Charter are not just being compromised, but essentially nullified. We cannot act as innocent bystanders, because we are not. We must rise to the challenge, raise our voice and stand up for those in need, and demonstrate that our common values are not subject to interpretation, but that those who violate those principles have to be held accountable.

Too many people have already lost their lives in recent conflicts across the globe. They have lost their loved ones and their homes, and in most cases are forced to flee their countries. That must not happen in the twenty-first century. It is not what our predecessors fought for. We are better than that, but we must show it. This cannot be the heritage we wish to leave to our children. We must do better, for the sake of the generations to come.

The Acting President: I now call on His Excellency Mr. Rashid Meredov, Deputy Chairman of the Cabinet of Ministers and Minister for Foreign Affairs of Turkmenistan.

Mr. Meredov (Turkmenistan): First of all, allow me to congratulate the General Assembly on the beginning of its seventy-ninth session.

I congratulate Mr. Philemon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly and wish him every success.

I would also like to express my gratitude to Ambassador Dennis Francis for his effective leadership of the General Assembly during the seventy-eighth session.

Strategic partnership with the United Nations and cooperation with Member States comprise the main approach of Turkmenistan in addressing pressing global issues and challenges. For Turkmenistan, the key condition and major criterion of

that work are adherence to the Charter of the United Nations, international legal norms and recognized beneficial models of relations based on equality, sovereignty and mutual respect among all participants in international affairs. In that logic, Turkmenistan supports the global mission of the United Nations as a conductor of the collective mandate and the balancing of the interests of Member States. That position was reaffirmed at the meetings of the Secretary-General with the President of Turkmenistan and national leader of the Turkmen people during his visit to Turkmenistan this summer.

For the seventy-ninth session, Turkmenistan has decided to follow four priorities, which are peace and security, sustainable development, climate change and humanitarian issues. All of those areas are closely interconnected. That means that their implementation must be comprehensive and based on unified principles and approaches. In that context, Turkmenistan advocates for an equal, fair and balanced approach that would ensure that the United Nations pays the same attention to all key areas of the international agenda.

In matters of ensuring peace and security, Turkmenistan's efforts at the current session will be aimed at strengthening peace and trust, enhancing the role of preventive diplomacy mechanisms and furthering peacebuilding processes in line with the New Agenda for Peace. When it comes to global security, Turkmenistan especially promotes the model of neutrality within the United Nations, which can provide the world community with practical tools to resolve existing and prevent potential conflicts and contradictions.

Next year we will celebrate the thirtieth anniversary of resolution 50/80, on international recognition of the neutral status of Turkmenistan. Over the years, our neutrality has demonstrated its alignment with the high ideals, basic principles and goals of the United Nations. The unanimous adoption in 2015 of the corresponding resolution 69/285 demonstrated that neutrality has become a heritage of the entire world community. At the seventy-ninth session, our country will be promoting further support for the political and legal foundations of neutrality and their application across a broad range of United Nations activities.

Preventive diplomacy holds an important place in that context. We are convinced that the time has come to reflect on the significance of neutrality for global politics and its potential in the current strategic landscape. In that regard, Turkmenistan has put forward an initiative to provide neutral countries with the status of priority partnership with the United Nations in its peacekeeping efforts. We are confident that this will serve as an effective impetus for the international community to more actively utilize the tools of neutrality and preventive diplomacy.

One of the essential aspects of the United Nations security agenda is the practical implementation of resolution 78/266, declaring 2025 the International Year of Peace and Trust. Naturally, as the country that initiated the resolution, Turkmenistan will take the lead role in organizing relevant events next year. At the same time, we rely on the support of all Member States, the Secretariat and its leadership to ensure that the International Year of Peace and Trust becomes a manifestation of the goodwill of the international community, its desire for peace and harmony and for overcoming differences and conflicts, and its rejection of dividing lines.

In the regional dimension, the most important aspect of ensuring security is cooperation on the Afghan issue and support for the people of Afghanistan in their aspirations to begin peaceful, constructive work to rebuild the economy and social sphere and solve humanitarian problems. In that context, I would like to highlight the major infrastructure projects in Afghanistan being implemented by our country, together with international partners. Among them is the construction of the strategic Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India gas pipeline. Just two weeks ago,

we began a new stage of construction of the pipeline on Afghan territory. Other significant projects include the construction of power transmission and fibre-optic communication lines along the Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan route, as well as a new railway from Turkmenistan in the direction of Afghanistan. Turkmenistan's humanitarian aid to the Afghan people will continue, including the free construction of social facilities there and the education of Afghan students in our country's educational institutions. In that way, Turkmenistan in practice confirms its strong position of solidarity with the people of Afghanistan.

In addressing the global climate agenda, Turkmenistan will be focusing on the protection of the environment in Central Asia and the Caspian Sea region. In that regard, our country advocates for more active and extensive United Nations involvement in saving the Aral Sea. Turkmenistan initiated the adoption of two recent General Assembly resolutions on cooperation between the United Nations and the International Fund for Saving the Aral Sea. Furthermore, in 2023 the United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific adopted a resolution on the modalities for creating a United Nations special programme for the Aral Sea basin.

Among other problems specific to Central Asia that have much broader consequences and impact, we highlight desertification and the reduction of water resources. All of that requires more active cooperation with the United Nations and the presence of its resident offices in the region on a permanent basis. Turkmenistan is ready to work to that end. As a concrete step, in cooperation with the United Nations, our country is promoting the establishment of a specialized regional centre for climate-related technologies.

Another topic that extends far beyond regional borders is the Caspian issue. In that regard, we especially emphasize that preserving the Caspian Sea as unique natural complex is not just the internal affair of the littoral States but a problem and challenge at the global scale. The approaches to resolving them should be appropriate. Therefore, Turkmenistan appeals to the United Nations and its relevant agencies, including the United Nations Environment Programme and the United Nations Development Programme, financial institutions, environmental funds — primarily the Global Environment Facility and the Green Climate Fund — and other structures, urging them to move towards systematic and targeted cooperation with the Caspian States to combat the sea's shallowing, the destruction of its ecological balance, the reduction of biodiversity, and other ecological and climate issues affecting the Caspian Sea. The President of Turkmenistan, at the previous session of the General Assembly, proposed the Caspian ecology initiative (see A/78/PV.4). We are ready to start an active dialogue on that topic and hope for the full support of the General Assembly.

In matters of sustainable development, we propose moving forward with a number of specific initiatives from Turkmenistan. In particular, we are talking about developing a global framework programme for the transition to a circular economy. Other initiatives include the creation of a global atlas of sustainable transport connectivity and an alliance for global energy security and sustainable development. In cooperation with the United Nations, we are ready to begin developing algorithms for joint work on those proposals.

Turkmenistan will continue to work with the United Nations to overcome the consequences of humanitarian crises, address population issues, protect motherhood and children and safeguard the rights of persons with disabilities, refugees and stateless persons, among other topics. I would like to note that our country has done significant work in reducing and preventing statelessness. Currently, more than 32,000 people, including refugees and stateless persons, have been granted Turkmen

citizenship. With that achievement, this year we have fulfilled our five-year national action plan to eliminate statelessness.

Next year, the entire world will celebrate the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations. We are approaching a milestone where responsibility, foresight and realism must guide all our thoughts and actions. It is time to reflect on the path travelled, assess the experience, correct mistakes and shortcomings and together move forward in improving the work of our Organization and its institutions.

The one thing that must remain unshakeable is our commitment to the values, principles and goals of the United Nations, because they have proven their viability and alignment with the fundamental long-term interests of humankind. On the basis of that fact, it is now more necessary than ever to combine all responsible forces. Turkmenistan believes in the United Nations and its huge creative potential. For our country, the United Nations has always been and remains the unique international organization with universal legal status. The voice of the United Nations must remain strong in ensuring global peace and security and sustainable development and solving humanitarian problems. Turkmenistan will continue to contribute its efforts in addressing the global challenges for the future of the world through the realization of its priorities.

The Acting President: I now call on His Excellency Mr. Cho Tae-yul, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Korea.

Mr. Cho (Republic of Korea): I should like to extend my congratulations to Mr. Philemon Yang on assuming the presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session.

Let me also pay tribute to Secretary-General António Guterres for his dedication to global peace and prosperity.

The year 2024 has, sadly, earned the distinction of being the most conflict-ridden year since the Second World War. Across the globe, from Ukraine to the Middle East, conflict and division have torn at the fabric of human dignity. Two billion people, or roughly one in four, reside in conflict zones. Some 310 million people require humanitarian assistance worldwide and more than 120 million, or one in 70, are refugees. Meanwhile, records suggest that we are brushing dangerously close to the critical threshold of 1.5°C. Most worrisome of all, the international community seems to be losing the sense of what those numbers really stand for: real lives disrupted, families displaced, futures lost and a planetary crisis looming. As the war of aggression against Ukraine drags on into its third year and as seemingly intractable challenges mount with no end in sight, cynicism and powerlessness are hardening in some quarters. There is a growing belief that multilateralism is ineffective and the United Nations is no longer relevant.

But I stand before the General Assembly today to affirm that this is not true. My nation's very existence as a free, democratic and prosperous country is proof that the United Nations in action works. It was the first-ever United Nations-led coalition that defended freedom and democracy in the Republic of Korea, ravaged by war in the early 1950s. Our journey from devastation to democracy and prosperity was made possible by the continued support of the international community, particularly through United Nations agencies and programmes. The story of the Republic of Korea provides the antidote against paralysing defeatism. It is a story of what we can achieve when good men and women choose to act together — the concrete evidence that the multilateral system can make a real difference. If global challenges are mounting, then we must double down on multilateralism. We need more United Nations in action, not less.

That is why I applaud the timely and proactive initiative of Secretary-General António Guterres to convene the Summit of the Future this year. As we prepare to mark the eightieth session of the General Assembly next year, we must ask ourselves what role the United Nations role will play in the decades to come. Where do we see ourselves in the ninetieth and hundredth session of the General Assembly? The Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) is the culmination of all our soul-searching at the Summit of the Future. It galvanizes our resolve to act not just for the present but for future generations as well. Now the onus is on each and every United Nations Member to fulfil its commitments in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and the Paris Agreement on Climate Change.

Earlier, I mentioned that the United Nations in action works, but we must not forget that the United Nations in action actually means United Nations Members in action. Under the foreign policy of vision of President Yoon Suk Yeol, the Republic of Korea seeks to be a global pivot State, recognizing both its indebtedness to the multilateral systems and its growing ability to be their champion. The Republic of Korea is committed to doing its part as a United Nations Member by serving the three functions of facilitator, supporter and initiator.

First, in global efforts to build sustainable peace, the Republic of Korea will act as a facilitator. Peace is not merely the absence of conflict; it is the sustainable presence of security and opportunity. The Republic of Korea understands that deeply, having endured the trials of war and division. Today the Republic of Korea is one of the core contributors to United Nations peacekeeping and peacebuilding efforts around the world. Its troops and experts serve in some of the world's most volatile regions, providing not just security but hope.

To ensure that peace is durable, however, it is important to go beyond the individual efforts of contributing countries. The Republic of Korea advocates strengthening the United Nations peacebuilding architecture, with the Peacebuilding Commission at its core, fulfilling its unique mandate to bridge all three pillars of the United Nations in order to bring greater coherence and a more integrated approach. We will actively participate in the peacebuilding architecture review next year, with a focus on how to strengthen the humanitarian development and peace nexus. We also align our humanitarian aid and development cooperation programmes with the United Nations activities to promote peace and security around the world and collaborate with the United Nations in identifying multifaceted challenges and addressing root causes in a coherent and holistic manner.

At the heart of our mission as a facilitator is our role as an elected member of the Security Council for the 2024-2025 term. Our focus is on peacekeeping and peacebuilding, advancing the women and peace and security agenda and addressing the complex relationship between climate and security. However, we must also face the dysfunctions that have hampered the Council's effectiveness. It is increasingly difficult to justify the current structure when a permanent member continues its war of aggression on its neighbour, challenging the fundamental tenets of the Charter of the United Nations it is tasked with upholding. The misuse of its right of the veto is deadlocking important and urgent work.

As we seek practical solutions by actively building common ground among the diverse views of the Council members, we will also work with all United Nations Member States to achieve a comprehensive Security Council reform in the intergovernmental negotiations. Expanding the elected membership through equitable geographical distribution and regular elections will contribute to making more democratic, effective, transparent, representative and accountable Council. The compromise proposal of longer-term, re-electable seats deserves due attention in that regard.

The Republic of Korea will also actively address the surging demand for humanitarian aid in the midst of ongoing conflict. This year, the Republic of Korea has committed \$200 million in humanitarian aid to Ukraine, and we also plan to provide \$100 million to tackle humanitarian crises by this year's end, including \$30 million for civilians affected by the ongoing Israel-Hamas conflict. Sadly, conflict in the Middle East is now being further escalated, especially along the Israel-Lebanon border. The Republic of Korea joins the United States, France and many others in urging the parties to pause their fighting and instead give diplomacy a chance to succeed.

Secondly, the Republic of Korea will play a role as a supporter of the global South in its efforts to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and take climate actions. As the first country to transition from recipient to donor nation, we firmly believe that we can and should be the tide that lifts other boats. That philosophy underpins our approach to official development assistance (ODA), which has grown by 30 per cent this year from last year and quadrupled since 2010. With only six years left to meet the SDGs and only 17 per cent of the Goals on track, we also wish to be smart about how our ODA is put to use, regardless of how fast-growing it is. Our initiative to serve as a green leader through our green ODA demonstrates our commitment to tackling the nexus of climate change and the SDGs. Recently, the Republic of Korea committed an additional \$300 million to the Green Climate Fund and \$7 million to the Loss and Damage Fund and has plans to continue expanding its green ODA.

But financial support is only part of the equation. We are buttressing our funding with intangible support by sharing our unique development know-how and building wider and more sustained partnerships. The inaugural Korea-Pacific Islands Summit, held last year, as well as the first-ever Korea-Africa Summit, held in June this year, were landmark events that highlighted our commitment to deepening mutually enriching partnerships with those regions. At the June Korea-Africa Summit, we pledged to increase our ODA to Africa up to \$10 billion by 2030 and to collaboratively address global challenges such as climate change, food insecurity and supply chain disruptions. We put a particular focus on empowering the youth of Africa, the youngest continent in the world, to drive sustainable development through such initiatives as Tech for Africa. Next year, we plan to organize the inaugural Korea-Central Asia summit, where sustainable development will again take centre stage. All of this would only be a half measure without Korea's own green transition. We will remain fully committed to carbon-free energy initiatives.

Thirdly, the Republic of Korea will act as an initiator in global efforts to install new norms and governance for human dignity and well-being. The exponential growth of technology, particularly in the field of artificial intelligence (AI), has not only opened new frontiers, but also poses potential risks to human rights and dignity. Meeting such a new challenge requires new norms and governance fit for our time. To that end, my President, standing in this very Hall last year (see A/78/PV.6) pledged to lead the global discussions on AI governance, and we have since spearheaded efforts to establish frameworks that ensure AI is developed and used in service of humankind. The Seoul Declaration for safe, innovative and inclusive AI, adopted at the AI Seoul Summit in May, marked a significant milestone in building the norms for civilian AI. The adoption of the Blueprint for Action at the second Summit on Responsible AI in the Military Domain, held earlier this month in Seoul, further laid the groundwork for norms for the military use of AI.

We are also dedicated to addressing cyberthreats and promoting open, free and safe cyberspace that respects human rights. Leveraging its expertise in cybersecurity, the Republic of Korea has actively participated in global efforts to establish comprehensive norms, including the United Nations Convention against

Cybercrime. Our work extends to the Security Council, where, as an elected member, the Republic of Korea is helping to lay a solid foundation for the Council's effective and agile response to cybersecurity issues.

Another area of concern is plastic pollution, a global crisis that threatens both ecosystems and human health. The Republic of Korea will host the fifth and last session of the Intergovernmental Negotiating Committee on Plastic Pollution in Busan in November, where we hope to work with United Nations Members to reach a binding agreement to end that form of pollution.

The heartbreaking tragedy is that just miles from Seoul, we find cynicism at its bleakest. North Korea continues to pose threats to peace and security on the Korean peninsula and beyond with its ongoing development of nuclear and missile capabilities, as shown by the recent disclosure of uranium enrichment facilities, as well as provocations that have stooped to despicable levels, such as sending trash balloons into the South. Moreover, North Korea has been engaged in military cooperation with Russia, providing it with missiles and vast amounts of ammunition. It is indeed deplorable that Russia, a permanent member of the Security Council and one of the founding States of the non-proliferation regime, is engaging in an illegal arms trade with North Korea and, in April (see S/PV.9591), vetoed the extension of the mandate of the Panel of Experts of the Committee established pursuant to resolution 1718 (2006), which had been functioning effectively for the past 15 years.

The heart of the matter is that North Korea's nuclear missile programmes and egregious human rights abuses are two sides of the same coin. North Korea is able to develop those weapons of mass destruction with impunity only by repressing the human rights of its people and diverting scarce resources from its starving populace. What Pyongyang offers is not a vision, but a cold and self-serving calculus that only sees twin deficits persisting indefinitely — a deficit of peace on the peninsula and a deficit of freedom in North Korea.

The 15 August unification doctrine unveiled by President Yoon Suk Yeol last month presents a vision of a unified Korean peninsula that is free, peaceful and prosperous. Recognizing that achieving sustainable peace is an unfinished task on the peninsula, we firmly believe that the road to peace runs through the expansion of freedom and through the unification of the Korean peninsula. Such peace would contribute to global peace and security. Under that vision, the freedom that has underpinned the Republic of Korea's independence, growth and prosperity will at last be fully unlocked in the North, restoring the human rights of each and every Korean. Achieving the vision will require the international community to advocate the freedom and human rights of North Koreans who have no voice. The Republic of Korea is committed to working together with the international community to steer North Korea towards making the right decisions.

Nearly 75 years ago, the founders of the United Nations stood together, bound by faith in multilateralism, to defend freedom and sovereignty and uphold the United Nations Charter. As we approach the eightieth session of the General Assembly next year, we must recommit ourselves to the principles that brought us together. Multilateralism is not an outdated concept; it is the only path forward. To stand idle in the face of today's challenges would be to abandon both the vulnerable today and the generation of tomorrow.

The Acting President: I now call on Her Excellency Ms. Penny Wong, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Commonwealth of Australia.

Ms. Wong (Australia): Steeled by the horror of the most catastrophic conflict in history, humankind forged our United Nations. Its purpose is often defined not as taking us to heaven, but saving us from hell. Yet we convene this week with so much of the human family enshrouded in darkness and more conflict than at any time since

the Second World War. Russia's invasion of Ukraine, the Sudan, Myanmar, Yemen, Gaza and now Lebanon — those are brutal, degrading conflicts ingraining hatred and division, pushing peace into the unseeable distance and pulling neighbours into an endless, reflexive cycle of blame and retaliation. Such entrenched violence has its own gravity; more violence becomes the path of least resistance. Seeing past hatred is hard. Building trust is hard. Compromise is hard. Making peace is hard. But the future otherwise is not worthy of our children and the present is not worthy of ourselves.

We must remember why we built this institution. The United Nations system is where the world comes together to agree and uphold standards and rules and to protect all of the world's peoples and the sovereignty of all nations. Those rules always matter, and never more so than in times of conflict, when they help guide us out of darkness and back towards the light — back on a path towards peace, stability and prosperity.

Not long after we last gathered here, Israel was attacked by the terrorist group Hamas, which killed 1,200 people. It was the greatest loss of Jewish life in a single day since the Holocaust, and Hamas continues to hold hostages. It was an attack that cannot and should not be justified. Like many countries, Australia has imposed sanctions on Hamas, its leaders and financial facilitators. In Israel's response, more than 40,000 Palestinians have been killed, more than 11,000 of them children. Nearly 2 million Gazans have been displaced, some many times over. More than 2 million face acute food insecurity. That must end. Palestinian civilians cannot be made to pay the price of defeating Hamas. All lives have equal value.

Last month, we marked 75 years since the world established the Geneva Conventions, the foundations of international humanitarian law, to limit human suffering in conflict. War has rules. Every country represented in the Hall must abide by them, even when confronting terrorists and even when defending its own borders. Israel must comply with the binding orders of the International Court of Justice, including by enabling the provision of basic services and humanitarian assistance at scale. Australia shares the frustration of the great majority of countries.

More than 77 years ago, the General Assembly adopted resolution 181 (II), a plan for two States — one Jewish, one Palestinian — living side-by-side. Seventy-seven years later, that Palestinian State, long held out as the promise at the end of a peace process that has ground to a halt, still does not exist. The world cannot wait. We must all contribute new ways to break the cycle of conflict. Earlier this year, Australia voted in the General Assembly in support of Palestinian aspirations to full membership of the United Nations. We have sanctioned Israeli extremist settlers and will deny anyone identified as an extremist settler a visa to travel to Australia. But individual country actions alone are not moving the dial. The international community must work together to pave a path to lasting peace. The world cannot keep hoping that the parties will do so themselves; we cannot allow any party to obstruct the prospect of peace.

As I have said for many months, Australia no longer sees Palestinian recognition as the destination of a peace process, but as a contribution of momentum towards peace. Australia wants to engage on new ways to build momentum, including the role of the Security Council in setting a pathway for two States, with a clear timeline for the international declaration of Palestinian statehood, because a two-State solution is the only hope of breaking the endless cycle of violence. It is the only hope of seeing a secure and prosperous future for both peoples, of giving the Palestinian people the opportunity to realize their aspirations through self-determination, and of strengthening the forces for peace across the region and undermine extremism. A two-State solution, Israel and Palestine, is the opposite of what Hamas wants. Hamas does not want peace and it does not want security for the State of Israel. Any future

Palestinian State must not be in a position to threaten Israel's security. There can be no role for terrorists. It will also need a reformed Palestinian Authority.

Right now, the suffering across the region must end. Hostages must be released. Aid must flow. Australia has provided more than \$80 million in humanitarian aid to support civilians who have been devastated by the conflict, but humanitarian aid is not a long-term answer. It is now nearly 300 days since Australia and 152 other countries voted for a ceasefire. Today I repeat that call, just as I repeat Australia's call for a ceasefire in Lebanon and for parties to fully implement Security Council resolution 1701 (2206). Lebanon cannot become the next Gaza. We know that Australia is not a central player in the Middle East, but we seek to be a constructive voice for peace and the upholding of international law, including the protection of civilians.

In order to protect civilians, we must also protect aid workers who deliver the food, water and medicine civilians need to survive. Aid workers are the best of humanity. Their selfless devotion to improving the lives of others should not cost them their own. Yet 2023 was the deadliest year on record for aid workers and 2024 is on track to be even worse. Gaza is the most dangerous place on Earth to be an aid worker. Australia felt that deeply with the Israel Defense Forces strike against World Central Kitchen vehicles, which killed Australian Zomi Frankcom and her colleagues. That was not a one-off incident. More than 300 aid workers have been killed since the start of the conflict.

This week, Australia has convened a group of ministers to pursue a new declaration for the protection of humanitarian personnel. The declaration will be developed over the coming months to demonstrate the unity of the international community's commitment to protecting aid workers and to channelling that commitment into action in Gaza, in the Sudan, in Ukraine and in all current and future conflicts. All countries will be invited to join the declaration. I want to thank my fellow ministers from Brazil, Colombia, Indonesia, Japan, Jordan, Sierra Leone, Switzerland and the United Kingdom, and the humanitarian leaders who have partnered with us in this. As Zomi Frankcom's family said this week, "People like Zomi are rare and their bravery and selflessness should be not only celebrated but protected. They cannot be brave at any cost."

The world's peoples are counting on all of us here to rededicate ourselves to international humanitarian law and the rest of the rules we have agreed to preserve peace and security. Russia continues its vicious assault on the people and sovereignty of Ukraine, in flagrant violation of the Charter of the United Nations. Aside from terrible damage and loss of life in Ukraine, Russia's invasion of Ukraine is also propelling the global crisis in food and energy security, raising the cost of living for working people all over the world. This year, we saw Russia end the mandate of the Security Council's Panel of Experts of the Committee established pursuant to resolution 1718 (2006) after 14 years of unanimous support. The Democratic People's Republic of Korea continues its unlawful activities with impunity, conducting illegal arms transfers to Russia and threatening our region, including the Republic of Korea and Japan. We are concerned that Russia is sharing nuclear and space information and technology with Iran.

Rules are being blurred, undermined and, at times, blatantly violated. We must rally to defend the rules that protect us all. Those rules form the character of the world that we want — a world where Australia and other countries have the freedom to decide our own futures without interference and intimidation; a world where we can find collective solutions to our toughest problems. Those problems are evolving and changing, but the commitment of some States to the rules underpinning the international system has not evolved for the better. Whether through cyberattacks, interference, disinformation or economic coercion, some States circumvent the rules, putting further out of reach collective approaches to countering new and emerging

threats and pressing challenges like climate change, technology, poverty, reform of financial architecture and, increasingly, necessary peacebuilding work.

We need reform of the United Nations system to better serve us all, but reform cannot become a means for disruptors to dismantle protections for smaller countries. No State should pretend that the rules do not apply to itself, ignoring international rulings, using might over multilateralism, ruling by power alone, not by law, favouring impunity rather than facing accountability, or forcing outcomes by economic coercion or military muscle rather than on the level playing field we established so carefully. We see some States trying to set us against each other when the challenges demand that we come together and stand together in support of the security, prosperity and sovereignty of all countries.

Australia has a different vision for the world, one where no country dominates and no country is dominated. When disputes inevitably arise, we insist that those differences be managed through dialogue and according to the rules, not simply by force or raw power. That is why we have consistently pressed China on peace and stability in the South China Sea and the Taiwan Strait, and why we have welcomed the resumption of leader- and military-level dialogue between the United States and China.

Some countries may dismiss the rules as a Western construct. Our Asia-Pacific region tells a different story. One example is the agreement between Viet Nam and Indonesia to delimit their exclusive economic zone after 12 years of negotiations — an example of how long-standing maritime disputes can be resolved in accordance with international law. Another example is Vanuatu's landmark International Court of Justice initiative on climate change, or Fiji's and Solomon Islands' maritime boundary agreements. There is the Bay of Bengal arbitration, whereby States peacefully resolved long-standing and sensitive claims under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), or Australia and Timor-Leste initiating the first-ever compulsory conciliation under UNCLOS, leading to the resolution of our maritime boundary dispute. We see it in the Philippines' decision to go to the Arbitral Tribunal, constituted under UNCLOS, and its unanimous, clear ruling in the South China Sea arbitration between the Philippines and China, which is final and binding on the parties.

Those cases in our region illustrate how international law has been built, defended and promoted by small and medium-sized countries from different traditions. The countries of our region have embedded the rules that serve us all and we make an ongoing contribution to maintaining and promoting them. Together, we want to pursue peaceful ways to resolve disputes. We know that this does not happen on its own. All of us help make it happen.

Australia is doing so by being active, by exercising agency and by contributing our efforts to the balance of power in our region and in the world. Our candidacy for a non-permanent seat on the Security Council for the term 2029-2030 reflects our deep commitment to contributing to international peace and security. The Security Council is a foundation of our collective peace and security, but we must reform it. Australia wants greater permanent and non-permanent representation for Africa, Latin America and the Caribbean, and the Asia-Pacific. That organ must represent the world as it is in the twenty-first century.

We must also reform the peacebuilding and conflict prevention architecture. It is not working. That will be the focus of our coming term on the Peacebuilding Commission (PBC). We will support national prevention strategies in our term, essential for local peacebuilding. We are providing additional resources and staff to the PBC's support and secretariat bodies and we will increase our voluntary contribution to the Peacebuilding Fund to \$15 million per year. We are committed to

doing all we can to de-escalate and prevent conflict. We do so by responding when we or our neighbours are coerced or have our sovereignty threatened. We do so by supporting our region's security, as we did at the Pacific Islands Forum this month, when we stood side-by-side with Pacific leaders to announce a Pacific-led, Australia-backed Pacific Policing Initiative. We do so by backing the call of Fiji's President for a cessation of ballistic missile testing in the Pacific. We do so by combining reassurance and deterrence and by working with our friends and partners, openly and transparently, so that no potential aggressor thinks that the pursuit of conflict is worth the risk. But there is so much more to do.

For peace to be truly durable, it must be built by and for all of society, including women. Yet here, in the world's premier peace forum, only around one in ten speakers at this rostrum so far this week have been women. Gender equality is a primary predictor of peace, even more so than a State's wealth or political system. That is why Australia champions the women and peace and security agenda. We support initiatives that we know are working, like the Southeast Asian Women Peace Mediators, who link stakeholders to enhance the potential for constructive dialogue, or the Pacific Women Mediators Network, a locally-led, vibrant and inclusive platform to support women's political leadership. Earlier this week, with Germany, Canada and the Netherlands, Australia invoked Afghanistan's responsibility under international law for violations of the rights of women and girls. The Taliban has erased women from Afghanistan's self-portrait. Effectively imprisoning half its society's population immediately halves its country's potential, depleting the soul and prospects of a nation.

Any country that wants to develop fully must encourage the full participation of all its people, so we cannot pursue only parts of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development; we must achieve all of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). And yet, with just over five years to 2030, over a third of the SDGs are stalled or regressing and finance targets are not being met. In times of scarcity, we need every development dollar to count. That is why we need to strengthen the global financial architecture. It is why Australia is backing the multidimensional vulnerability index and the Bridgetown Initiative for the Reform of the Global Financial Architecture. It is why Australia is championing reforms that make the multilateral development banks more responsive to global shocks and build sustainability and resilience, particularly in the smallest and most vulnerable countries. This year, Australia committed 492 million Australian dollars to the Asian Development Fund, working with Japan to unlock a record \$5 billion in new assistance to the region's most vulnerable countries over the next decade.

Financial pressures are further strained by the trend of trade being used as a point of leverage rather than as an opportunity, as economic interdependence is misused for strategic and political ends. Nearly every country represented in the Hall depends on open trade with transparent and predictable rules. We must therefore keep working together to uphold those trade rules that underpin our economic growth and the livelihoods of our peoples.

Of course, it is not just finance and unfair trade arrangements that threaten development. Climate change is causing more disasters, reversing years of development gains overnight. Extreme weather threatens food and water security, with grave implications for global stability. Australia is acting at home, enshrining our ambitious emissions reduction targets into legislation — 43 per cent by 2030 and net zero by 2050. We are transforming our economy. Within this decade, 82 per cent of our electricity generation will be renewable, up from around 32 per cent when I first addressed the Assembly two years ago (see A/77/PV.11). We are building new industries to accelerate our economic transition and to export reliable, renewable energy to the world, and we are acting internationally to respond to our

partners. By the end of 2025, Australia will offer climate resilient debt clauses in our sovereign loans.

The groundbreaking Australia-Tuvalu Falepili Union Treaty entered into force on 28 August. It is the first time that two nations have recognized, in a legally binding treaty, continuing statehood and sovereignty, notwithstanding the impacts of sea level rise. The agreement supports Tuvaluans to live and thrive at home through land reclamation and investments in infrastructure, education and health. At the same time, Tuvaluans have the choice to live, study and work in Australia. Mobility with dignity means ensuring that people have a genuine choice to stay.

Pacific voices have demonstrated sustained, clear and innovative leadership, as well as tremendous resilience. That is why we are bidding to host the thirty-first Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, in partnership with the Pacific. We want to show the world the unique climate challenges facing our region and amplify the voices of small island developing States, the custodians of our world's oceans.

We know that along with climate change, technology will define the multilateral system and development goals for decades to come. We want safe, accessible technology that is used for the global good, not as a tool for censorship, surveillance, exclusion and division. From the start of negotiations for the Global Digital Compact (resolution 79/1, annex I), Australia advocated that all States should boost access to digital technologies that offer benefits to our world. We know that if countries do not have digital infrastructure, they will miss out. That is why we are building sustainable South-South connectivity, including submarine cables across the Pacific.

We also know that not all knowledge is new. First Nations people's deep knowledge must be preserved and protected. Australia's aboriginal and Torres Strait islander peoples have been innovators, inventors and knowledge-holders for over 65,000 years. Whether it is in fire-stick farming used to sustainably manage countryside or the engineering of great stone fish traps across rivers and seas, that unbroken line of innovation has continued to this day. Earlier this year, Australia's Ambassador for First Nations People helped bring countries together to finalize the World Intellectual Property Organization Treaty on Intellectual Property, Genetic Resources and Associated Traditional Knowledge. The Treaty acknowledges the link among traditional knowledge, innovation and intellectual property. It helps First Nations communities identify and protect the use of their knowledge by others, which will in turn spur collaboration among researchers, innovators and communities, opening up new opportunities for First Nations entrepreneurship. But the treaty is remarkable for another reason. It serves as a source for optimism. One hundred and ninety-three Member States have agreed on new rules to the world's intellectual property system. That is an extraordinary achievement.

As I said at the outset, the international outlook is framed by entrenched division, where consensus often seems a lost cause, but we have collectively moved the intellectual property system a step forward, just as we collectively moved forward this week with the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1). Those recent wins remind us of the gains we have made that we need to protect; of the ways our lives are better because of the United Nations; of the ways our world is better because of our collective contribution to the international system. It promotes economic development and makes trade fairer, together supporting job creation, overcoming poverty and enabling small and medium-sized countries to resist coercion. It guards against the spread of nuclear weapons. It sets the standards that keep food safe. It assigns the satellite orbits that take the Internet to the most remote reaches. It sets the standards that keep 120,000 flights and 12 million passengers safely in the sky every day. It is resolving and preventing conflicts in 53 peacekeeping and political missions. Each year, it saves more than 350 million children from malnutrition.

Most of all, let us always remember that we are collectively descended from people who lived in a harsher, more dangerous world, who built the United Nations system to confine horrors of the past to history and to give us all a better life. We have no option and no excuse but to find a way through our challenges today, immense and intractable as they are. We must work together. We must drive change where it is needed, transparently, together. We must drive change to include all the world's peoples. To deploy the collective agency that this forum provides so we can combat climate change, poverty and coercion; so we can negotiate peace.

We must not allow others to divide us for their own gain or to dilute the protections that are inherent in the United Nations Charter and codified in the Geneva Conventions. Rather, we have to reinforce those protections in the interests of all States and civilians. That is what Australia is for — a peaceful, stable and prosperous world for all where sovereignty is respected and where civilians are protected.

The Acting President: I now call on His Excellency Mr. Alva Romanus Baptiste, Minister for External Affairs, International Trade, Civil Aviation and Diaspora Affairs of Saint Lucia.

Mr. Baptiste (Saint Lucia): I begin my address to the seventy-ninth session of the General Assembly by invoking the wisdom of one of America's most outstanding orators, the late Martin Luther King, Jr., who said,

“We are now faced with the fact that tomorrow is today. We are confronted with the fierce urgency of now. In this unfolding conundrum of life and history, there ‘is’ such a thing as being too late. This is no time for apathy or complacency. This is a time for vigorous and positive action.”

Over the decades, we, the representatives of small island developing States (SIDS), have come to the General Assembly Hall to state the case for fairer treatment of our development needs and our challenges by the international community. We have argued for special and differential treatment because we are indeed different, indeed special and indeed unique in our sizes, our economies, our finances, our social circumstances and our vulnerabilities. We are indeed severely disadvantaged by an unfair global financial system that has amplified its inequities by the measurements and standards it has employed to assess our development. Despite our best efforts, it seems that we were simply engaging in odes to the deaf because there have hardly been the type of concrete and fundamental responses and actions to change the rules and the systems that have been suppressing our development aspirations.

However, we have persisted in our advocacy. We have not abandoned our faith in the strength and advantages of multilateralism. And so today we are pleased to applaud two recent decisions of the international community that provide an expectation that the unique vulnerabilities and special circumstances of Saint Lucia and other SIDS will receive the particular attention they deserve.

I speak first of the fourth International Conference on Small Island Developing States, recently held in Antigua and Barbuda, which adopted a new 10-year plan of action for SIDS. The Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for SIDS is a bold new plan to give priority at the international level to the sustainable development needs of SIDS over the next 10 years and maps out the nature of the support which the international community must deliver in order to achieve them. Through the Agenda, the economies of SIDS can be transformed, so there must be absolutely no delay in its implementation and in delivering on the commitments made to bring life to its provisions. That cannot wait.

The second decision that we applaud is the recent adoption by the United Nations of the multidimensional vulnerability index (MVI). While we note that resolution 78/322, advancing the MVI, calls for its voluntary adoption, Saint Lucia urges the

international community to speedily adopt and implement the MVI. It took the international community 32 years to develop and adopt that vital and necessary tool for sustainable development and global equity. Let us not wait another 32 years to test and implement it. The MVI must be brought into use today. It cannot wait. It is urgent because the challenges facing our small, open and vulnerable economies are quite complex.

Caribbean economies have, over the past two decades, been plagued by a number of interrelated and interlocking factors, including persistent fiscal deficits and high debt, stubborn and persistent structural rigidities. Those interrelated factors have been significantly exacerbated by external shocks, including frequent and major fluctuations in energy prices, financial crises and, more recently, the coronavirus disease pandemic and the Russian-Ukraine war, not to mention the planet's greatest existential threat — climate change. In that regard, there is a pressing need for immediate action to reactivate and accelerate the slow progress that is being made on the issue of climate change and climate justice. The General Assembly needs no reminders of the violent and destructive impact of climate change and the extent of the peril in which the world, particularly SIDS, finds itself as a result.

Saint Lucia is considerably dismayed and disappointed that, after years of advocacy by SIDS to establish the Loss and Damage Fund at the twenty-eighth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (COP28), the Fund, which should have been activated in July, is yet to be operationalized. Saint Lucia therefore urges those concerned to swiftly and urgently operationalize the Loss and Damage Fund so that SIDS can receive timely support on the scale required to recover from the disastrous impact of climatic events on their small economies and societies. Further, it is essential that, at the forthcoming COP29, the special circumstances of SIDS be protected and operationalized across the entire climate change policy agenda. That cannot wait.

In the same way the world must recompense SIDS for the injustice of the climate crisis that we are suffering, those countries that propelled their economic development through the unholy and inhumane transatlantic slave trade and the enslavement of our African ancestors must pay reparations for that crime against humanity, which they inflicted upon the people they brought from Africa to the Caribbean and the Americas, as well as on the indigenous peoples of those regions. Saint Lucia therefore reiterates the call it made at the seventy-eighth session that the United Nations should become seized of the question of reparations for the transatlantic slave trade and slavery in the Western Hemisphere.

It is also why, in part, our Caribbean civilization resents the current carnage in Gaza and the West Bank. In Gaza for the past year, over 41,000 persons, the majority of them women and children, have been killed by the Israeli army in the name of self-defence, occasioned by a terrorist attack on Israel on 7 October 2023, in which approximately 1,200 persons were killed. Saint Lucia condemns terrorism in all its forms, by whomever and whatever commits it, but humanitarianism has been lost in the carnage. Since October last year, 289 aid workers, including 207 team members of the United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East, have been killed in Gaza. In addition, more than 110 journalists have been killed. The war in Palestine, what some have referred to as genocide, whatever it is called, must be brought to an end today, for the world has no future with it and no appetite for it.

Year in, year out since its independence, Saint Lucia has been calling for the recognition and establishment of a Palestinian State. However, to date there continues to be needless impediments to that accomplishment. I respectfully submit that the unnecessary undermining of Palestinian statehood is, to a large extent, the root cause of the current Israeli-Palestinian conflict. Israelis and Palestinians deserve to live

side-by-side in peace. However, peace for Israel must not come at the expense of the Palestinian people, nor can a permanent ceasefire be based on the whims and fancies of Israel. It must be predicated upon meaningful and honest negotiations, utilizing the tools of diplomacy. Hence, no State should become a material accomplice to aggression against the Israeli and Palestinian people.

The solution is not far-fetched or unreachable. The Palestinians must be allowed to exercise their right to self-determination and to have their own State and full membership of the United Nations alongside the State of Israel, in accordance with United Nations resolutions that go back to resolution 181 (II) of 1947 and include resolution 3236 (XXIX) of 1974, which reaffirmed the inherent rights of the Palestinian people to self-determination, national independence and sovereignty, and the right of the Palestinians to return to their homes and property. The only way to secure a just and peaceful future in the Middle East and for Israel to have secure borders is for the Palestinian people to live in their own internationally recognized homeland. The right to self-determination is a universal right, and the Palestinians are no exception. The people of Palestine cannot wait.

It is that same right which says that the people of Ukraine must be allowed to choose their own destiny and that Russia must end its unwarranted war against Ukraine and restore and respect the territorial integrity of Ukraine.

It is that same right of self-determination that dictates that the heroic people of Cuba have a right to determine their own path to political, economic and social development and that the economic embargo imposed on Cuba for the past 64 years by the United States is illegal, unjust and inhumane. It must be ended forthwith, in accordance with the many resolutions of the General Assembly dating back to 1992, which have rejected that embargo totally and overwhelmingly. The people of Cuba cannot wait.

Further, Cuba's emphasis on medical internationalism as its central foreign policy objective, as well as its non-involvement in armed conflicts abroad, invalidate Cuba's inclusion on the United States list as a State sponsor of terrorism. Instead, given that it is well established that Cuba's alternative model of development has provided important social benefits to the Cuban people, coupled with its emphasis on medical internationalism, it should be on a list of countries acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations. No one must be left behind.

It is that same right to self-determination that says that the 23.5 million people of the Republic of China on Taiwan have the right to be a Member of the United Nations and other international organizations and that resolution 2758 (XXVI) of 1971 does not preclude Taiwan's inclusion and participation in the United Nations system. We believe that Taiwan, with the twentieth largest economy in the world and with its important role in technological development and world trade has much to offer from which the international community can benefit. No one must be left behind.

It is that same right to self-determination that says that the people and the Government of Venezuela must be allowed to conduct their internal affairs without sanctions imposed upon them by other States.

The President took the Chair.

In Haiti, the situation remains unstable and deeply concerning, although some political advances have been registered through the efforts of the Caribbean Community's Eminent Persons Group of three former Prime Ministers. However, the international community has provided only 14 per cent of the resources required by the Multinational Security Support Mission for Haiti. We welcome the announcement of the President of Kenya this week that it will deploy 600 more security forces to

Haiti by November and we thank the Government of Kenya for its support of the Haitian people. The funding required for humanitarian assistance in Haiti is also woefully short of its target. We therefore call upon all other countries that have pledged to assist Haiti to urgently and immediately fulfil their commitments to doing so. Haiti cannot wait.

In view of the foregoing, to safeguard the future we have to be prepared to take action now — this moment, this very minute, at this time — on certain issues that are essential for a peaceful and sustainable future. We cannot and must not be selective about which declarations of the Pact or of the principles of the Charter of the United Nations we will respect and when we will do so.

In the convening of the Summit of the Future this week and in the theme that is guiding the deliberations of the seventy-ninth session, the international community has seemingly come to understand that it can no longer procrastinate and no longer delay the actions needed to secure a better future for humankind. Let us for once, therefore, turn our words into actions. The time for action is now. The time to make multilateralism truly work, not just for SIDS but for all of us, is now. The time for reform of the Security Council is now. The time for climate justice for SIDS is now. The time to end the conflicts, genocides and wars is now. The time to give the youth of this planet, who are the people of tomorrow, the hope and the opportunities to better themselves is now. The time to put humanity first is now.

If we act together today for peace, sustainable development and justice, no one will be left behind and there will be a better tomorrow. Consequently, if we do not act with the fierce urgency of now, our United Nations speeches and resolutions, in the words of Martin Luther King Jr., “will end up as a meaningless drama on the stage of history... shrouded with ugly garments of shame”.

The President: I now call on Her Excellency Ms. Kamina Johnson Smith, Minister for Foreign Affairs and Foreign Trade of Jamaica.

Ms. Smith (Jamaica): I extend Jamaica’s congratulations to you, Sir, on your election to the leadership of this body. You can be assured of our full commitment to the successful execution of your mandate for the seventy-ninth session.

I also commend your predecessor, Ambassador Dennis Francis of Trinidad and Tobago, a fellow national of the Caribbean Community (CARICOM), for his successful tenure.

We, the States Members of the United Nations, are all facing the same world of multiple and intersecting challenges. The great difference between us, however, is our capacity to meet, withstand and recover from the shocks they bring. If there is one realization we must share, it is that those challenges cannot be solved alone. They can be addressed only through multilateralism, diplomacy and international cooperation.

Jamaica is a small island located in the second-most climate-vulnerable region in the world. We emerged from a brutal history of slavery and colonization, achieving political independence a mere 62 years ago. Until recently, most of our independent history has been characterized by high levels of poverty, debt and unemployment, but as we chart a course towards sustainable prosperity, we are determined that those characteristics will not define the Jamaica we bequeath to future generations.

Against the odds, Jamaica has been building its resilience. Our macroeconomic fundamentals today are stronger than they have been at any time over the past 50 years. Our credit ratings have been upgraded by international rating agencies and our fiscal credibility has improved. Jamaica is now an attractive destination for investment. Over the past 10 years, in spite of the pandemic, we have more than halved our debt-to-gross domestic product (GDP) ratio, significantly reduced our poverty rate, brought unemployment to historic lows and increased our minimum

wage by more than 100 per cent. Our management of the economy has created fiscal space that has allowed us to invest more in social welfare, national security, health care and education. Through our national broadband network project, we have increased Internet penetration to 77 per cent and Internet user penetration to 85.1 per cent. We are closing our domestic digital divide, providing more and better Government services online. We have also embarked on Jamaica's largest-ever expansion and upgrade of infrastructure, using a mix of pure budgetary financing and public-private partnerships.

Those advancements have been hard-won. Our effort has required social, political and international partnership, measured policy and strategic management. Even as we acknowledge the sacrifices made to enable our achievements, we recognize that our many successes can be eroded by exogenous shocks, including climate change, which we view as a clear and present danger to humankind.

As a small island developing State (SID), Jamaica is severely affected by higher temperatures, warmer seas, sea level rise and the increased intensity and frequency of natural disasters. Hurricane Beryl, which impacted the Caribbean in July, was the earliest Category 5 hurricane on record. Beryl resulted in the dislocation of families and communities, along with significant damage to infrastructure, houses, schools and farms. Damage was most severe in our agricultural belt, wiping out crops, killing livestock and triggering the knock-on effects of higher food prices and inflation. Our new climate-smart agricultural practices were no match for the hurricane; its winds took the panels for solar-powered irrigation pumps and flattened 70 per cent of greenhouses.

We experience almost half of each year in the uncertainties of a hurricane season. Natural and climate-based disasters continue to set back our efforts to attain the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and realize sustained, inclusive growth and development. We have therefore sought to strengthen our ability to respond to, and recover from, such disasters through a risk-layered approach to disaster response financing. Jamaica has therefore significantly increased resources to our Contingency Fund and the National Natural Disaster Reserve Fund. We have established the National Disaster Fund, triggered by measured impact on GDP, and became the first small island developing State to independently sponsor a catastrophe bond. Additionally, we participate in the Caribbean Catastrophe Risk Insurance Facility. Those mechanisms, however, do not reduce the occurrence of disasters or prevent the disruption, dislocation and destruction they cause.

It bears repeating that no country can combat the effects of climate change on its own. Jamaica therefore affirms its unwavering commitment to international cooperation to counter the negative impacts of climate change and to the pursuit of climate justice. We urge the major polluting nations to honour their commitments under the Paris Agreement on Climate Change and to meet their finance obligations.

Furthermore, we welcome the adoption of the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for SIDS at the fourth International Conference on Small Island Developing States. More particularly, Jamaica endorses the calls for a redoubling of international cooperation and action to accelerate mitigation and adaptation. All countries must adopt or maintain the target of limiting global temperature increase to 1.5°C through enhanced nationally determined contributions, based on the principle of common but differentiated responsibilities. Allow me to pause here to congratulate the Government of Antigua and Barbuda on having successfully hosted the Conference.

Jamaica calls on the United Nations and international financial institutions to adopt a new climate finance goal at the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change. We further call for the urgent and accelerated mobilization of international action and resources. That

includes the full and effective operationalization of the Loss and Damage Fund to address issues of responsiveness and scale that are the most critical to SIDS.

Jamaica welcomes the adoption of the multidimensional vulnerability index. We call on our development partners, including multilateral development banks and other international financial institutions, to urgently examine the index and commence its use. Rather than considering gross national income alone, it accurately takes into account the structural and environmental vulnerabilities of SIDS. Its use by multilateral development banks will better align access to and the terms of financing while supporting those countries' development needs. Jamaica also commits to advancing dialogue and cooperation with stakeholders in the international capital markets to adapt their operations to the vulnerability-resilience profiles of SIDS. Improved access to development financing is critical for SIDS, which are particularly off-track in attaining the SDGs.

The SDGs were adopted by leaders as a universal clarion call to tackle poverty, ensure peace and promote prosperity. Jamaica shares the concern that, globally, only 17 per cent of the SDG targets are on track. We are proud that our progress is further along domestically and we fully support and are honoured to co-lead the Secretary-General's SDG Stimulus Leaders Group. International cooperation is urgently needed to drive sustained efforts to tackle structural and systemic issues that constrain access to development financing. Through our collective advocacy, we aim to elevate the global agenda to ensure no one is left behind. We call upon wealthier countries and the international financial institutions to partner with developing countries and redouble their efforts to create and implement innovative strategies to unlock financing and spur investments towards attaining the SDGs.

The upcoming fourth International Conference on Financing for Development will present an opportunity to commit to tangible deliverables to address the current financing challenges. Those include impactful, practical and meaningful reform of the international financial architecture to strengthen the voice and representation of developing countries in international decision-making and to substantially improve the quantity, accessibility and affordability of financing for development.

This brings me to the Summit of the Future. The adoption of the Pact for the Future, the Declaration on Future Generations and the Global Digital Compact (resolution 79/1) signals renewed hope in multilateralism. The consensus demonstrated our collective resolve to deliver inclusive and durable solutions to current and emerging global challenges. With foresight, political will and joint action, we can deliver a better world for future generations. Jamaica commends the work of Namibia and Germany in their facilitation of the Pact, and we were honoured to have co-facilitated, together with the Kingdom of the Netherlands, the Declaration on Future Generations.

Jamaica believes in leveraging multilateralism to advance sustainable development, human rights and international peace and security to deliver results for all the peoples of the world. No country or region should be excluded from the opportunities to attain the SDGs. Jamaica therefore again joins the call for the discontinuation of the crippling economic, commercial and financial embargo against our closest Caribbean neighbour, Cuba. We further call for a cessation of the classification of Cuba as a State sponsor of terrorism. Those measures continue to have a devastating impact on the economic and social well-being of the people of Cuba and preclude progress towards their attainment of the SDGs.

Jamaica once again condemns the brutal 7 October attacks in Israel and the devastating counterattacks in the Palestinian territories. The undeniable humanitarian crisis and instability compel all parties to resolve the conflict through dialogue and diplomacy. We commend the United States, Qatar, Jordan, Egypt and others that are making concerted efforts towards a peaceful resolution. We continue to

support Security Council resolution 242 (1967) and believe that a two-State solution is the best way to achieve lasting peace between Israel and Palestine. It is in that context that Jamaica has recognized the State of Palestine. We call for an immediate ceasefire in Gaza and the release of hostages to bring an end to the protracted war and human suffering.

Much closer to home, Haiti continues to face one of the most challenging periods in its storied history. Rampant gangs are causing chronic instability and unspeakable violence, especially against women and children. Millions of Haitians are facing hunger and dislocation. They need and deserve the unwavering support of the international community to restore peace, security and democracy and to address the devastating humanitarian crisis.

Jamaica will continue to play its part, including through CARICOM and the Eminent Persons Group, in supporting the political process in Haiti. Significant progress has already been made, particularly since the Kingston talks convened by CARICOM in Jamaica in March. We welcome the installation of the Transitional Presidential Council, the appointment of an interim Prime Minister and ministerial Cabinet and the finalization of the Provisional Electoral Council.

The Multinational Security Support (MSS) mission is critical to the restoration of peace and security in Haiti. We reiterate our gratitude to the Government of Kenya for its leadership of and commitment to the MSS mission. We are pleased to confirm that on 12 September, Jamaica deployed its initial command contingent along with Belize, as part of the MSS mission. We are committed to scaling up to our committed numbers, but we also call on the international community to contribute more personnel and equipment. The restoration of peace and security is critical to the creation of an environment in which free and fair elections can be held. The establishment of democratic governance is critical for sustainable economic growth and development.

Since the deployment of the MSS mission, we have seen improvements in the situation in Haiti and have cause for cautious optimism. More is needed, however, and time is not on Haiti's side. It is critical that we preserve and advance the gains made. It is critical that we maintain hope and stability. We therefore urge the Security Council to renew the mandate of the MSS mission and to consider future transition to a peacekeeping framework to guarantee funding. We also call for continued and increased support from member states, including financial contributions to the Trust Fund. That is needed for the deployment of additional personnel to support the Haitian National Police as it recovers communities from criminal gangs.

We further call on the international community to significantly increase contributions to the humanitarian response plan for Haiti, which remains underfunded at 39 per cent of the target. Support to the United Nations Integrated Office in Haiti must also be ramped up so that displaced families can be fed and provided with critical health care, and children can return to the classrooms to resume their education. Jamaica will continue to do what we are able. We will support our sister CARICOM nation in the effort to restore peace, security and stability in Haiti and, by extension, the region.

Jamaica is seeking to comprehensively address the issue of gangs, crime and violence in our own society, fully recognizing the compounding impact of transnational crime, including illicit trafficking in drugs, arms and ammunition. We have embarked upon a mission of transforming and strengthening our security forces and agencies, while preserving human rights, increasing operational efficiency and delivering high-quality policing services to the public. We have made significant improvement to the working conditions of our police men and women and the National Police College of Jamaica has now received the highest international

accreditation for curriculum and quality of training. We continue to expand closed-circuit television networks in collaboration with our stakeholders, have increased mobility and introduced new equipment and technology, including forensics. We have also introduced new community policing models. The Government is also undertaking social interventions in vulnerable communities. We have trained and certified approximately 40,000 at-risk youths and enrolled approximately 81,000 parents in parenting programmes. We are also working closely with the private sector and non-governmental organizations to expand social services in vulnerable communities.

On transnational organized crime, Jamaica has made substantial investments in advanced coastal radar systems and the acquisition of off-shore patrol vessels. We are also increasing the use of technology in securing our ports. As a result of those initiatives, major crimes have consistently declined to the lowest levels in 25 years. So far this year, there has been a 17 per cent decline in homicides over last year. Jamaica is a safer place to live, work, raise families and do business.

We recognize that continued bilateral, regional and multilateral cooperation, especially in the areas of training, intelligence sharing and joint operations, is vital if we are to comprehensively and sustainably continue to reduce crime and violence. In that regard, while we appreciate the steps taken, we reiterate our call for more concrete action from bilateral partners to stem the illicit flow of small arms and ammunition from their ports. We welcome the recent outcome of the fourth Review Conference of the United Nations Programme of Action to Prevent, Combat, and Eradicate the Illicit Trade of Small and Light Weapons in All Its Aspects. More particularly, we welcome the emphasis placed on technical assistance and capacity-building, customs control, emerging technologies and through-life conventional ammunition management. Those matters are all critically relevant to ultimately turning around crime-ridden inner-city communities into peaceful and prosperous ones.

Cybercrime is a major threat to citizen security and an obstacle to sustained economic development. International cooperation is necessary to address the matter of cybercrime. Jamaica actively participated in the negotiations, together with our fellow CARICOM partners, on the United Nations Convention against Cybercrime. We therefore look forward to the adoption of the Convention by the General Assembly and look forward to future engagements within the framework of that instrument.

In conclusion, Jamaica has taken difficult decisions and has taken responsibility for our economic future. We have demonstrated that we are able to positively impact our own outcomes and redefine our future. We continue to believe not only in our own resolve but also in the power of multilateralism and international cooperation to overcome shared global challenges. The people of the world are counting on the United Nations and the international community to deliver on climate, on human rights, on peace and security and on development. With that support, Jamaica is committed to doing our part to meet the challenges of today, while laying a solid foundation for present and future generations.

The President: I now call on His Excellency Mr. Mohamed Ali Nafti, Minister for Foreign Affairs, Migration and Tunisians Abroad of the Republic of Tunisia.

Mr. Nafti (Tunisia) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I am pleased to extend to you, Sir, and through you to the Republic of Cameroon my warmest congratulations on assuming the presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. I wish you success in managing its work and affirm Tunisia's support for your vision of "Unity in diversity, for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for everyone, everywhere".

I also offer Mr. Dennis Francis, President of the Assembly its seventy-eighth session, my sincere thanks and appreciation for his successful presidency.

I reiterate my appreciation for the ongoing efforts of Secretary-General António Guterres to restore confidence and respect for multilateral action.

As hopeful as we are of achieving the necessary transformations and reforms and establishing a more peaceful, secure, just and sustainable world through the initiatives and paths proposed within the framework of the Secretary-General's Our Common Agenda (A/75/982) and the outcomes of the Summit of the Future, we express our deep concern and condemn the current situation in the Middle East and the terrible humanitarian tragedy of the Palestinian people, who, for nearly a year now, have been subjected on their own land to the most heinous war crimes, genocide and all forms of violations of human rights and the purposes and principles for which the United Nations was founded. The occupying forces perpetrate their crimes with impunity in the face of abhorrent international silence and unjustified and immoral paralysis.

The failure of the international community to enforce respect for international humanitarian law, despite the measures approved by the International Court of Justice to protect Palestinians in the Gaza Strip from the risk of genocide, puts the lives of Palestinians in the balance. Suddenly, the slogan repeated from various rostrums, calling for human rights and humanitarian issues to take precedence, falls silent when it comes to the Palestinian people.

The only way to a secure future for all peoples begins with the belief that all human lives are equal, without discrimination or selectivity and free of double standards. We cannot launch a new phase of multilateral action, international relations and sustainable development, based on the principle of leaving no one behind, while the tragedy of the Palestinian people continues to be ignored. In that context, we call on the international community to take immediate, effective and responsible steps to save what can still be saved, stop the bloodshed and end the war of extermination and starvation in Gaza — a war in which schools, hospitals, facilities and civilian infrastructure have been targeted and more than 40,000 people have been killed. We also call on the Security Council to awaken from its state of stagnation and impotence and to assume its natural role in maintaining international peace and security by holding the occupation authorities responsible for the humanitarian tragedy in Gaza, imposing an immediate ceasefire, halting the blatant and heinous aggression against the defenceless Palestinian people, and preventing all plans for forced displacement, settlement and the violation of holy places.

The war on Gaza has created a deep rift in the conscience of humankind and undermined peoples' trust in the ability of the international community and its main bodies to enforce its decisions. We recall the opinion issued by the International Court of Justice on 19 July, at the request of the General Assembly, on the legal consequences of the policies and practices of the Zionist occupation in the occupied Palestinian territories, which recognized the illegality of the continued presence of the occupying Power in the Palestinian territories and that the State of Israel is obligated to halt new settlement activities and immediately evacuate all settlers from the occupied Palestinian territories. Our country believes that the Court's opinion puts the international community to the test of its commitment to enshrining the principle of the supremacy of international law and applying its rules to everyone, without exception or selectivity.

Our country remains committed to its steadfast and unconditional support for the right of the Palestinian people to recover their imprescriptible, legitimate and inalienable rights, foremost among which is their right to self-determination and the establishment of their independent and sovereign State on all of Palestine, with Jerusalem as its capital. Tunisia affirms its support for Palestine's request to obtain full membership of the United Nations. We appreciate the wave of international recognition of the State of Palestine and hope that it will lead to Palestine obtaining

full membership without further delay. Tunisia also reiterates its strong condemnation of the aggression against brotherly Lebanon, targeting its people and threatening its security and stability, at a time when our countries are meeting under the banner of the United Nations. Tunisia calls on the Security Council to take a firm and decisive position against those crimes against humanity without delay.

The principle of leaving no one behind cannot be achieved with slogans, nor can we achieve the declared goals or overcome past and present failures unless we all have a sincere desire to change and reform. That will require agreement on a unified and responsible diagnosis of the root causes of the failure of the current international system to confront the intensification of conflicts and wars, the rise of extremism, terrorism and organized crime, and the deterioration of climate crises and disasters that threaten the survival of millions of people. Those ills are compounded by the unprecedented spread of poverty, hunger and inequality, a significant increase in the number of refugees and displaced persons, the widening development and digital gap between the North and the South, and the inability of the international financial system to respond to the development needs of the vast majority of countries.

All those challenges are serious indicators that the existing international system has gone off track, requiring all of us to carry out the necessary reviews and reforms to correct the state of disorder, chaos and inequality. Those challenges also require all of us — States, institutions and peoples — to engage in a participatory approach based on shared responsibilities, respect for international law and adherence to the purposes of the Charter of the United Nations and human rights on an equal footing, without discrimination or politicization.

The events witnessed by the world over the past eight decades have demonstrated the urgent need to reform the system of international relations and review the foundations and working methods of multilateral action to meet the needs of peoples and put an end to all the imbalances that have prevailed and continue to prevail, unleashing calamities, tragedies and suffering on millions of people and placing the world today at undeniable existential risk, which we cannot continue to address by using the same tools and methods that only take the interests of a minority of States into account at the expense of the majority. In that regard, we stress the urgent need for the countries of the North to respect their commitments to financing development, supporting efforts to combat climate change and effectively participating in reducing poverty, supporting growth and building resilience and sustainability in developing countries.

We also stress the need to put an end to all forms of trusteeship, the imposition of policies and dictates and interference in the internal affairs of States, and to respect their national sovereignty, the independence of their decisions, the choices of their peoples and their cultural and civilizational specificities, which represent a factor for enrichment and diversity. The challenges ahead can be met only by rebuilding international relations on the basis of solidarity, constructive cooperation, justice, mutual respect and equality. We also call for strengthening the role of the United Nations and introducing the necessary reforms to its institutions and bodies in order to make its performance more effective and enhance its credibility, especially that of the Security Council, which has become paralysed as a result of the escalating geostrategic conflicts.

Tunisia, based on its sincere belief in multilateral action and in keeping with the purposes of the United Nations Charter, has engaged in all the tracks and initiatives proposed by the Secretary-General's Our Common Agenda, the Sustainable Development Goal Summit and the Summit of the Future, held recently here at the United Nations. If appropriate follow-up and implementation mechanisms are put in place, their outcomes can represent a historic opportunity and a fundamental tool for

addressing challenges, mitigating risks and establishing a more secure, peaceful and sustainable world.

At the same time, Tunisia reaffirms the urgent need to introduce fundamental reforms to the global financial system, review the role of international rating agencies, reduce the burden of debt and debt service on developing countries, and facilitate their access to sources of development financing. That will allow them to recover from the repercussions of successive global crises, for which they have paid a heavy price, despite not having caused most of them, and to direct their capacities to meet the essential human and social development needs of their peoples.

We also call for developing international cooperation tools at the bilateral and multilateral levels to ensure the recovery of stolen funds moved abroad. That will accelerate the pace of economic recovery and promote development, given that it is the fundamental right of affected peoples, and help to prevent the recurrence of such violations, which deplete State resources and represent one of the greatest manifestations of corruption.

The phenomenon of irregular migration is growing in many regions of the world, especially in our Mediterranean basin, and is one of the main indicators of weak global governance and the absence of political will to address the repercussions of development crises, climate change and conflicts. As we have emphasized time and again, that multidimensional issue requires the adoption of a joint approach that is based on shared responsibilities and brings together all parties from countries of origin, transit and destination, along with international and regional organizations, to address the deep causes of the growth of that phenomenon and not just its consequences.

We have also called for comprehensive solutions that are based on addressing vulnerabilities, the decline in literacy rates and weak development programmes. Such solutions would usher in a new reality in countries of origin, especially in the African continent, and provide their children with a dignified life and decent work opportunities that preserve their right to life and development, protect them from the perils of journeys in search of a better life on the northern shore of the Mediterranean, and shield them from the exploitation of criminal smuggling and human trafficking networks.

Our approach to dealing with irregular migration flows is clear and based on respect for human rights and rejection of all forms of racial discrimination and hate speech, within the framework of our international obligations and national legislation. We continue, to the extent of our ability, to strive to save lives and provide the necessary care and support to those who deserve it while safeguarding their dignity, but we refuse to accept projects for the hidden settlement of irregular migrants. We also reject all political and media exploitation of the situation and suffering of migrants to achieve political goals and serve suspicious agendas.

We in Tunisia are aware of the challenges of the coming phase and have continued steadfastly on the path of reform and strengthening the pillars of democracy, the rule of law and good governance, which are based on combating and preventing corruption and achieving the aspirations of our people to greater prosperity, well-being and sustainable development. We adhere to the pillars of our foreign policy and our international commitments and rely on our own human capacities and energies and on constructive cooperation and partnership relations with our friends and partners on the basis of shared benefit, equality and mutual respect. Our young people are a source of inspiration and the face of the future; we therefore ensure that they play their pioneering role in transformative solutions and decision-making. We also continue to strengthen legislative frameworks and strategic plans for the

economic integration and empowerment of women and to expand their participation in public affairs and in all fields, including global peacekeeping.

With the same resolve and commitment, Tunisia continues to play an active role in all international and United Nations efforts to promote regional and international security and peace, ensure respect for international law and international humanitarian law, end all forms of injustice, occupation and human rights violations, and achieve development for all.

In our immediate neighbourhood, we affirm Tunisia's firm position in support of the efforts of our Libyan brothers and sisters to overcome differences and achieve a political settlement through constructive dialogue, with the assistance of the United Nations, in a way that preserves the security and stability of sisterly Libya and strengthens its national unity. We also reiterate Tunisia's rejection of all forms of foreign interference in the internal affairs of sisterly Libya.

In the same context, we call for concerted United Nations and international efforts to identify political solutions to the situations in Syria and Yemen that will end the suffering of their brotherly peoples, restore security and peace and preserve their sovereignty, independence and territorial integrity. Tunisia also calls on the Sudanese parties to stop fighting and resort to dialogue and peaceful means to overcome the crisis, restore security and stability to the Sudan and put an end to the suffering of its people from the scourges of war and displacement.

As for the African continent, which is the most affected by climate change and the repercussions of global crises, terrorism and instability, we call for more concerted international and United Nations efforts to help Africa overcome its challenges and crises and move to restore stability, security, peace and sustainable development. My country believes in the need to find African solutions to African challenges as a method to achieve our goal of silencing the guns by 2030. We also reiterate our call for the United Nations financial and logistical support for peace operations led by the African Union and stress the need to pursue cooperation and coordination among international and regional structures to achieve the Africa we want.

The world has entered a new phase of digital transformation and the increasing use of modern technologies in all fields. In emphasizing the importance of the Global Digital Compact (resolution 79/1, annex I), we call for strengthened cooperation in the areas of technology transfer and for bridging the digital gap that still separates the North and the South so that no one is left behind. In that context, we highlight the need to confront manifestations of digital chaos, misinformation and the criminal and illegal use of digital technologies to sow the seeds of turmoil, destabilize communities and undermine their resources.

The coming phase will be complicated by the challenges and risks facing the security and well-being of present and future generations and the future of our planet. We can no longer address the situation of our world with the same old tools and methods, nor can we reproduce the mistakes and imbalances of the past. The only way forward is one based on the values of solidarity, multilateral cooperation and a sense of shared destiny.

Tunisian foreign policy and its diplomatic tools have always been characterized by optimism and pragmatism. Despite all the challenges and shocks facing the world, Tunisia believes that the United Nations remains our only refuge as the home of international legitimacy and the bearer of the hopes of the peoples of the world as we prepare to celebrate the eightieth anniversary of its founding next year.

The President: I now call on His Excellency Mr. Peter Shanel Agovaka, Minister for Foreign Affairs and External Trade of Solomon Islands.

Mr. Agovaka (Solomon Islands): It is an honour and a privilege to address the General Assembly. I bring warm greetings from the Government and people of Solomon Islands.

Solomon Islands extends our warm and sincere congratulations to you, Sir, on your election as President of the Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. You may rest assured of Solomon Islands support during your tenure in office. We thank His Excellency Ambassador Dennis Francis for his sterling leadership in the previous session.

The theme of this session calls for global solidarity and collective actions for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations, leaving no one behind. We live in a fast-changing environment that is shifting towards a multipolar world. We must seek a multilateral, rules-based world order that is equal, inclusive and free from power politics and geopolitical tensions. We also seek an international system that respects international law and recognizes the special situation of small island developing States (SIDS).

The growing economic inequality between the haves and the have-nots, climate emergencies around the world, poverty, hunger, disease, social injustices and racism, hegemonic interests, militarization and nuclear posturing are dividing the world and creating tensions and fear. The rich and powerful are spending some \$2.4 trillion on arms that would be better invested in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and in fighting the biggest enemy of humankind, which is climate change.

It is our shared and solemn duty to commit to bold collective action in protecting the health of our planet. We must hold ourselves to account and secure the future of our people by unlocking the opportunities of prosperity and planting the seeds of peace. In that connection, Solomon Islands calls for the reform of the Bretton Woods institutions to ensure that they are fair and democratic and represent the rise of the global South, including the multidimensional and complex challenges facing the small island developing States.

We call for global and regional financial institutions to scale up grant support for small island developing States. We reiterate our support for the Secretary-General's Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) stimulus of \$500 billion annually to support developing countries and to get the SDGs back on track. In the same vein, we re-echo our call for the establishment of a permanent seat for SIDS in decision-making within the international financial architecture to ensure inclusivity in the spirit of leaving no one behind. The slogan used by the disability rights activist James Charlton speaks to that call very clearly: "Nothing about us without us".

Solomon Islands was elected this year to serve on the Executive Board of the United Nations Development Programme, the United Nations Population Fund and the United Nations Office for Project Services. We are indeed grateful for the support given and will work to position those United Nations programmes and agencies closer to those that need it most.

As the third-largest Pacific country, and with least developed country (LDC) status, Solomon Islands calls for an enhanced United Nations country presence. In the past 46 years, the United Nations has conducted its relations with Solomon Islands from a distance. In living up to our Charter obligations, Solomon Islands formalized relations this week with the Republics of Rwanda and Colombia. As a testament of our foreign policy of being a friend to all and enemy to none, we uphold respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of all 133 countries we have formalized relationships with, including respect for the one-China principle in the case of the People's Republic of China.

On Security council reforms, the world continues to witness the limits and failures of the Security Council to prevent deadly conflicts with the use of the veto. Fostering international peace demands an expanded Council, with equitable geographical representation, that is democratic and equipped with revised working methods. We urge that, during this session, we shift into text-based negotiations and make the reform happen. Solomon Islands aspires to be a candidate for the regional seat of the Security Council in 2032. As a peace-loving country, we reiterate our standing position of condemning all wars around the world and call for a diplomatic solution.

On the conflict in Palestine, Solomon Islands condemns all the violence and carnage committed by all parties, including the terror attack on Israel by Hamas. The suffering and collective punishment of the Gaza population by Israel have claimed more than 41,000 Palestinian lives in less than a year. That is unacceptable. The disregard for international law and humanitarian law has seen the matter referred to the International Court of Justice. We hope that those with influence will do more for peace and not fan the flame of the expanding conflict into Lebanon. Solomon Islands reiterates its long-standing position on the Palestine conflict and supports the global push for a two-State solution, with Israel and Palestine living side-by-side with secured borders in a just, permanent and complete peace.

Colonialism has no place in this day and age. Solomon Islands supports the implementation of the United Nations Fourth International Decade for the Eradication of Colonialism. We also recognize the inalienable right of self-determination of all non-self-governing and trust territories, including New Caledonia and French Polynesia, to choose their political future under Chapter XI of the Charter of the United Nations and resolution 1514 (XV). The recent brutal violence in New Caledonia calls for a new political solution in the spirit of 1998 Nouméa Accord. We call on the United Nations to do more to calm and stabilize the situation in New Caledonia. Solomon Islands welcomes the constructive discussion between France and the New Caledonia Government to facilitate a Pacific Islands Forum fact-finding mission to New Caledonia, of which Solomon Islands is a part.

As a large ocean State, 98 per cent of Solomon Islands territory is covered by the ocean. The Pacific occupies 20 per cent of the world's surface and provides 1.5 million tons of annual catch of tuna, which is around one-third of the world's supply. Our approach to the ocean is premised on achieving a healthy, resilient, secure and productive ocean that supports sustainable use and development for the benefit of the people of Solomon Islands, now and into the future.

As stated last year, Solomon Islands will be co-hosting the Honiara Summit on SDG 14.4, with the Pacific Islands Forum Fisheries Agency, the Secretary-General's Special Envoy for the Ocean and the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations. The Summit will examine the status of SDG 14.4 at the global, regional and national levels, share knowledge and experience on the management of tuna stocks, and provide policy and strategic actions that will feed into the third United Nations Ocean Conference in 2025 in France.

On the matter of pollution and waste management, Solomon Islands looks forward to the finalization of negotiations on the treaty to end plastic pollution, including in the marine environment in November. We have already banned single-use plastics. We are also reforming waste management in partnership with our friends Japan and Australia and the Asian Development Bank.

As a steward of the ocean, Solomon Islands values the work of the United Nations Commission on the Limits of the Continental Shelf and will continue to address outstanding continental shelf claims. Solomon Islands upholds its obligations to the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea and will integrate the recently signed Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the

Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction into its domestic legislation.

In response to the discharge of treated radioactive contaminated water into the ocean by Japan, the lack of national and regional scientific knowledge and understanding of the intergenerational impact and transboundary nature of the discharge continues to cause uneasiness and anxiety for my country. United Nations specialized agencies, including the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), must continue to build bridges of trust with States and support their capacity to read and understand IAEA reports and monitor the discharge of treated radioactive contaminated water into the ocean.

Our concern is connected to the sad history of our region being used to test, store and dump nuclear weapons and wastes. Solomon Islands remains a nuclear-weapon-free State under the 1985 South Pacific Nuclear Free Zone Treaty. This week, we signed and ratified the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons. That sent a message of peace to all our friends not to engage in military nuclear projects and to free the world of nuclear weapons.

Education empowers the nation, including my own. Let me thank Cuba for the training of Solomon Islands medical students. Cuba has done so despite enduring more than six decades of the United States of America economic, commercial and financial embargo, a relic of the past that should now be discarded. Once again, we call on our friend and partner the United States of America to end the embargo. The United Nations stands for good-neighbourly relations and peaceful coexistence. The world will benefit from improved relations between Cuba and the United States of America.

Following the conclusion of the Solomons International Assistance Force in August, our priority now is to strengthen our law enforcement capability and institutional capacities. We will work with all our partners to achieve that goal. We thank our partners, particularly Australia, for their ongoing support in that regard and appeal to the United Nations to provide space for Solomon Islands to participate in peacekeeping missions.

Solomon Islands welcome the power of South-South cooperation and acknowledges the People's Republic of China's various development initiatives — such as the Belt and Road Initiative, the Global Development Initiative, the Global Security Initiative and the Global Civilization Initiative — in supporting Solomon Islands development aspiration, including the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

In education and health care, we once again thank China for its commitment to establishing an ocean research centre and acknowledge the ongoing construction of Solomon Islands National Referral Hospital Comprehensive Health Centre. We also welcome India's pharmacopeial cooperation and Japan's commitment to constructing a fisheries research centre in Solomon Islands.

On the international trade front, Solomon Islands acknowledges China as the first major economy to offer zero tariff treatment for 100 per cent tariff lines to all least developed countries. We call on all our partners to follow suit. China has become Solomon Islands largest infrastructure partner and is currently supporting Solomon Islands digital transformation with the ongoing installation of 161 communication towers across the country. Already, we are witnessing more of our rural population now connected to the digital age.

Our inter-island connectivity has been improved with the completion of two all-weather airfields and an international airport. We thank New Zealand and Australia for their support. We would also like to acknowledge Japan, the Asian Development Bank and the World Bank for their ongoing support in improving our infrastructure

connectivity. Nevertheless, as a geographically fragmented country, we need more infrastructure to meaningfully deliver on our SDGs. Solomon Islands values the contribution of all our development partners and calls for partnerships that are country-owned, led and driven. We seek partnerships that are genuine, meaningful, durable and free from onerous conditions.

Climate change is no longer a threat but a crisis. Solomon Islands is located in a hotspot where the impact of climate change is three times the global average. Science tells us that we are on a 2.5°C trajectory. The Paris Agreement on Climate Change is failing humankind. We need a stronger legally binding framework that will put us on a 1.5°C pathway. The voluntary approach under the Paris Agreement has failed miserably. The changing narrative on climate change is unacceptable. Talk of ambitious climate action, survival or the construction of safe islands is replaced by discussions on sinking and migration. We need to give hope to our people on the front line of climate change. The Group of 20 is responsible for 80 per cent of global emissions; it must take a stronger leadership role in the fight against climate change.

In July, Solomon Islands presented its second Voluntary National Review at the High-Level Political Forum on Sustainable Development. The report revealed uneven progress, but it has allowed the country to restrategize and prioritize four key interconnected and people-centred pillars, namely, economic transformation, good governance, national unity and stability, and human capital development. Our economic transformation agenda is centred on enhancing transport infrastructure connectivity, boosting investments in agriculture, fisheries and tourism, improving private sector investment environment for indigenous Solomon Islanders, and reducing the cost of doing business in my country. Over the past three months, the Government has been socializing those priorities through several targeted national forums, including with our development partners.

The Government is leading the preparation of our smooth transition strategy to graduate from LDC status. The strategy will look at what needs to be done not only before 2027 and but also in the following five to ten years, including the implementation of critical economic and social investments to prevent regression. We reaffirm our commitment to the implementation of the Doha Programme of Action for the Least Developed Countries and support the call for the General Assembly to review existing resolutions on smooth transition to ensure that the graduation framework is better, resilient, irreversible and fit for purpose.

Solomon Islands welcomes the adoption of the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for Small Island Developing States, which offers immense opportunities to access adequate and affordable funds to drive economic growth and prosperity for small island developing States. Solomon Islands also welcomes the adoption of the multidimensional vulnerability index and we look forward to its early implementation.

In conclusion, Solomon Islands pledges our commitment to the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), a forward-looking framework that places the health of our planet, people, prosperity and peace at the centre of our agenda, supported by a reformed financing architecture that will turbocharge sustainable development and guarantee a better tomorrow for all that leaves no one behind.

The President: I now call on His Excellency Mr. Lejeune Mbella Mbella, Minister for External Relations of the Republic of Cameroon.

Mr. Mbella Mbella (Cameroon) (*spoke in French*): I am honoured to deliver before the Assembly the full address that Mr. Paul Biya, President of the Republic of Cameroon and Head of State, has authorized me to deliver on his behalf.

“At the outset, I would again like to offer you, Sir, my warm congratulations on your election to the presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-

ninth session. Your accession to that high position is the pride of your country, Cameroon, and Africa and has been welcomed by the international community. I convey our full gratitude to the Member States that supported your candidacy for election, especially those from Africa that unanimously nominated you as the candidate of our continent.

“I salute the work and achievements of your predecessor, Ambassador Dennis Francis of Trinidad and Tobago, who was able to lead with commitment the work of the seventy-eighth session of the General Assembly.

“I also take this opportunity to reiterate Cameroon’s support and appreciation for Secretary-General António Guterres, who, despite the many contingencies our world is facing at this time, is relentlessly engaged in the advancement of the ideals, goals and principles of the Charter of the United Nations and the influence of our common Organization.

“Mr. President, you have chosen to place at the heart of this seventy-ninth general debate the theme ‘Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations’. The theme, it must be emphasized, reflects the imperative and urgent need for joint action in an international environment that is difficult and complex in terms of challenges and opportunities alike. Among those challenges, it is necessary to note that our common home, planet Earth, is the victim of an extreme climatic disruption that threatens the physical survival of certain countries, forests and coastal areas in different regions of the world.

“The torrential rains and subsequent devastating floods we have seen in recent months in Africa, Europe and Asia, heat waves and landslides are the most visible manifestations, with some countries suffering more than others. Today climate-displaced people are now as numerous as refugees and people internally displaced by war. This is no longer a simple view of mind, but a painful daily reality for many.

“Yet we have agreed on a set of measures to combat those scourges in the Paris Agreement on Climate Change and many other subsequent commitments. Cameroon, which is a State party to the Agreement and belongs to the great forest massif of the Congo basin, is sparing no effort in its search for relevant solutions, in consultation with the riparian countries, to the current global climate crisis. It is therefore launching an urgent call for the measures that were jointly adopted in the Paris Agreement to be effectively implemented, without obstacle and without delay. Unfortunately, the financial and technological resources that represent the main resources for implementing the Agreement have so far been mobilized in a parsimonious manner.

“The climate crisis has been compounded by conflicts and hotbeds of tension, old and new, that spare no geographical region. The Sahel, the Sudan, Gaza, Lebanon and Ukraine are the most illustrative examples of that. The situation is fuelling the arms race, including in outer space and in the seas and oceans. It is also fuelling an increasing use of light weapons and weapons of mass destruction. It constitutes a strong threat of the use of nuclear weapons. It also causes geopolitical tensions, rivalries of all kinds and distrust among States, which pose a threat to international peace, security and stability. If nothing is done as soon as possible, we could in the near future be forced to live through yet another dark period in the history of humankind, similar to that of the earlier twentieth century.

“For Cameroon, it is important to reverse that trend as soon as possible. We must do so to free ourselves from war and its scourges in order to safeguard future generations with regard to the ideals defended by the founding fathers

of the United Nations. My country remains convinced that the use of dialogue, consultation, consensus and preventive diplomacy and the establishment of confidence-building measures must always prevail in order to guarantee lasting peace in our world.

“To that end, we must reform the Security Council in order to ensure that it continues to fully fulfil its original mandate as the principal organ for the maintenance of international peace and security. Since Africa remains to date the only continent without a permanent member on the Council, it is imperative and urgent that this injustice be corrected and that our continent rightly enjoy equitable representation as a member of that important organ in its own right. That will require the granting of two permanent seats with veto rights and two additional non-permanent seats.

“When we adopted resolution 66/288, entitled ‘The Future we want’, and the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, we wanted to engage in a decisive battle against underdevelopment. Four years ago, during the celebration of the seventy-fifth anniversary of the United Nations, we made new commitments, reaffirming that the Sustainable Development Goals were our action plan, the implementation of which was a question of survival. As we close in on the 2030 deadline that we have set for ourselves, it is reasonable to note that the hoped-for results are far from being achieved, as attested by various progress reports presented by the Secretary-General.

“As I noted earlier in the case of the Paris Agreement, adopted with a view to safeguarding the planet, the financial and technological means of implementation have not been fully mobilized. Cameroon therefore calls for renewed political will and more decisive action to reverse the situation. We believe that the Doha Programme of Action for the Least Developed Countries; the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for SIDS; the agreement to be adopted at the third United Nations Conference on Landlocked Developing Countries, to be held in Gaborone in December; the African Union Agenda 2063, with its second decade of priorities; and the African Continental Free Trade Area are frameworks for guidance and incentives for the development of the poorest countries that must be actively implemented if we hope to leave no one behind. On that subject, Cameroon has undertaken a number of structuring projects in the fields of energy, transport, communication and telecommunications infrastructure, extractive and processing industries, and many other sectors, aimed at its emergence by 2035.

“Plans, projects and programmes for recovery and reconstruction, as well as humanitarian actions, have been set up by our Government to meet the special and pressing needs of our populations, especially those in rural areas and those affected by the terrorist sect Boko Haram in the Far North and those resulting from the sociopolitical crisis in the Far North, Northwest and Southwest regions. I take this opportunity to sincerely and strongly thank our bilateral and multilateral partners for their ongoing support for our national agenda of progress and development and invite them to continue to honour us with their loyal support.

“No action taken by developing countries can produce the desired results unless the global macroeconomic framework is reformed. It must be recalled that this framework is based on institutions that have been in place since the Second World War and have become obsolete. Their structure and organization are largely at the heart of the disruptions, imbalances, dysfunctions and even inequalities that continue to hinder the full development of poor countries and the global South. Cameroon therefore joins the call and mobilization aimed at the reform of the international economic and financial architecture. That call and

mobilization relate in particular to the improved representation of developing countries in those institutions, a more equitable taxation, an appropriate monetary policy, a more sustainable debt, a better adapted energy transition, a healthy agriculture, a controlled industrialization and decent work.

“We welcomed the holding here on 22 and 23 September of the Summit of the Future, in which we took part, and especially the adoption of the Pact for the Future and its two annexes, the Global Digital Compact and the Declaration on Future Generations (resolution 79/1). The Pact commits us once again to an active search for peace, sustainable development and human dignity, thanks to a series of concrete actions that require significant means of implementation. We cannot shirk those actions, which can pave the way to the future we want in the framework of reinvigorated multilateralism, supported by the ideals, goals and principles of the Charter of the United Nations.

“The issue here is about the safeguarding of the planet, the building of peace and the establishment of sustainable development that ensures, first and foremost, the eradication of poverty, shared prosperity and full respect for human rights centred on human dignity. In the absence of strong political resolve and the means for the active implementation of the provisions agreed to in the Pact and its annexes, we risk not achieving the desired results and, in so doing, letting down our present and future generations.

“At this point, I call once again for all-out mobilization in order to resolutely implement those provisions and prove wrong the sceptics who have lost all hope in the United Nations. As our shared Organization prepares to celebrate its eightieth anniversary, let us give it the means to modernize itself, to respond effectively to the expectations placed in it, to meet the challenges of the time and to keep burning the flame of more humanistic international cooperation.

“We are living in a period not only of threats and challenges to peace and development, but also of great opportunities. We have at our disposal the necessary means thanks to the prodigious growth of science, technology and artificial intelligence. It is therefore up to us to overcome selfishness and act in solidarity with a sense of collective responsibility to meet together the challenges that no country can face alone. It is up to us to use those means wisely to ensure our well-being and the survival of the planet and the human species, today and tomorrow, within the framework of tireless vigilance, enlightened awareness and in-depth reflection on the part of the international community on controlled globalization.”

The President: I now call on His Excellency Mr. Taye Atske Selassie Amde, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia.

Mr. Amde (Ethiopia) (*spoke in Amharic; interpretation provided by the delegation*): I congratulate you, Sir, and your country, Cameroon, on your election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. I wish you a successful term.

I also convey my appreciation to Mr. Dennis Francis, President of the General Assembly at its seventy-eighth session, for his leadership.

It is an honour and privilege for me to address the Assembly, representing my country, Ethiopia.

(*spoke in English*)

As a country that was one of the 51 founding Members of the United Nations, Ethiopia is a strong proponent of effective multilateralism centred on the United

Nations. Ethiopia views with grave concern the challenges the United Nations faces in discharging its role in peace and security and socioeconomic development.

Nevertheless, ensuring the readiness and capability of the United Nations to resolve global challenges has been a generational quest. Seventy-four years ago in 1950, five years after the establishment of the United Nations, Ethiopia in its policy statement stated to the Assembly,

“We are filled with anxiety... concerning the surprises which the future may hold in store; fears that the United Nations may be called upon to face events even more serious than those of the present time, and that such problems may greatly exceed its powers and capacity.” (*A/PV.289, para. 2*)

That future is now and that future is the present. We are faced with persisting peace and security challenges across the globe. There is a devastating existential threat emanating from the arms race, extreme poverty, inequality and climate change. At the same time, global commitment to the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) is receding and the debt crisis in developing countries is worsening. Furthermore, our constrained ability to manage the emerging multipolar world carries the risk of undermining multilateralism.

As envisaged, the United Nations is called upon to face challenges that are proving to exceed its powers and capabilities. It is our view that collective security will be realized if States are able to exercise their authority and carry out their responsibilities to safeguard their national security. Conventional dictates, including peacekeeping missions, can deliver the desired results when we prioritize support for national efforts and capabilities. We must therefore at all times preserve the sovereignty and political independence of States as the foundation of effective collective security. We also call for greater economic and security cooperation among Member States, which is pivotal to empowering national institutions.

The shortcomings of the United Nations reflect the reluctance of the international community to promote the effective realization of the principles and purposes of the Charter. The United Nations should be at the centre of efforts to resolve global peace and security challenges. Without a substantial role for the United Nations, guided by the principles of the Charter, we risk making the General Assembly an inconsequential platform with no guarantee that it can make a meaningful contribution to global peace and security. On its part, the United Nations should play its role by demonstrating impartiality, independence, competence and credibility among all its Members.

Furthermore, we underscore the urgent need to reform the Security Council and its working methods. The reform of the Security Council is not only about rectifying the injustice done to Africa, but also about the credibility of the Council itself. The impacts of Africa’s exclusion and the Security Council’s inability to discharge its cardinal responsibilities, manifest in its disproportionate focus on the internal affairs of African countries. In addition, the Council’s lukewarm attitude towards regional solutions and its implementation of measures detached from the reality on the ground are results of Africa’s non-representation. We therefore call on Member States to commit to prioritizing Africa’s representation in both categories of membership of the Security Council, with all the rights and prerogatives as articulated under the African Common Position. There is no shortcut or half solution to that long-standing quest for equality.

The African Union has designed Agenda 2063 as a blueprint for the continent’s development. The Agenda is being implemented in synchronization with the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. The fact that the SDGs are off-track, mostly due to lack of financing, is a source of concern for Africa. The compounding debt crisis also requires urgent and sustainable solution. Therefore, those Member States

with impact on global financial institutions should make the necessary financial resources available.

On its part, Ethiopia has been consistent in its efforts to achieve those development goals. In parallel with resolving a complex security challenge through an African Union-facilitated peace process, Ethiopia has redoubled its efforts to forge peace and development. We are making progress in poverty eradication and realizing people-centred development. We have introduced transformational shifts to our monetary and economic policies and to advance our digital infrastructure. We are confident that our development path will bring great benefits to our people. We call on all actors in development finance to work with us with a sense of solidarity and cooperation to navigate the challenges of reform and attain sustainable economic growth and development.

I have the distinct pleasure to announce to the Assembly the milestone which the Nile River basin has achieved this year. The Nile Basin Cooperative Framework Agreement (CFA) is poised to enter into force with the required number of ratifications. The entry into force of the first-ever Nile River basin-wide treaty — the Cooperative Framework Agreement — will pave the way for sustained cooperation and shared growth across the entire river basin. Ethiopia, along with its co-riparian sisterly countries, will work towards the realization of the principles of the CFA and the full potential of the Nile River. Furthermore, the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam is generating electricity, responding to the energy demands of Ethiopia and the East Africa region. It is our sincere hope that the remaining riparian countries will join the treaty and play a constructive role in ensuring equitable and reasonable utilization of the Nile River.

I am also proud to announce to the Assembly that the Ethiopian Green Legacy Initiative, the notable initiative of Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed, has seen to the planting of over 40 billion seedlings within five years, increasing our forest coverage from 3 to 24 per cent. That stands as a substantial global contribution to the absorption of greenhouse gases and a tangible measure against the adverse impacts of climate change. Based on its Long-term Low-Emission Development Strategy, Ethiopia is also on the path to sustainable energy transformation by developing and transitioning to non-fossil fuel energy sources. Such efforts must be supported by the full activation of global commitments, especially through the provision of adequate climate financing.

Maritime insecurity in the Red Sea and the Indian Ocean is a source of great concern for Ethiopia. With a population of more than 120 million people and significant maritime trade, Ethiopia depends entirely on the safety and security of maritime activity in the Red Sea and Indian Ocean. The region is threatened by conflicts, piracy and other illicit activities. Over the years, Ethiopia has played an instrumental role in combating the causes of insecurity. We are also pursuing our efforts to work with our neighbours to contribute on a durable basis to ensuring peaceful navigation on the high seas. We see a great need to chart a new path for inclusive maritime security engagement, with the equal participation of countries with stakes on both sides of the Red Sea and the Indian Ocean.

Furthermore, terrorism continues to be a grave threat to the peace and security of the Horn of Africa. Violent extremist groups like Al-Shabaab and its international affiliates are growing and continuing their vicious attacks against civilians and the security of the region. The region has reached a milestone in degrading terrorism, owing to the resilience of the people of Somalia and the sacrifices of the sons and daughters of Burundi, Djibouti, Kenya, Uganda and my country, Ethiopia. The authorization of the Security Council and the international financing for the African Union peace support operation have indeed played an instrumental role.

I am confident that the Government of Somalia will soon recognize the sacrifice we have made for Somalia's liberation from the grip of terrorist groups. Ethiopia's memorandum of understanding with Somaliland is based on the existing political dispensation in Somalia. Our objective is shared growth and prosperity in the region. Similar agreements have been concluded by other States and there is no reason for the Government of Somalia to incite hostility that is obviously intended to cover internal political tensions. I therefore reject the unfounded allegations levelled against my country. Ethiopia's name can never be associated with any one of those allegations. Instead, I call on the federal Government of Somalia to join hands in eliminating the terrorist groups that are causing chaos and mayhem for the people of the region.

The recent manoeuvres of actors from outside the Horn of Africa region undermine those efforts. Nevertheless, Ethiopia will not be deterred from its resolute commitment to combatting terrorism. We therefore call upon those actors to immediately stop their reckless actions. We also call on the international community to recognize the imminent risk originating from those irresponsible acts and to take concrete measures to prevent the loss of hard-won gains in combating terrorism in the Horn of Africa.

In conclusion, I would like to reiterate Ethiopia's commitment to the maintenance of global peace and security and to upholding multilateralism.

The President: A number of delegations have asked to speak in exercise of the right of reply. May I remind members that statements in the exercise of the right of reply are limited to 10 minutes for the first intervention and to 5 minutes for the second intervention and should be made by delegations from the assist.

Mr. Assadi Nazari (Islamic Republic of Iran): I take the floor to exercise the right of reply of my delegation in response to the statement made today by the representative of the Israeli regime (see A/79/PV.13).

What we heard here today from the notorious Israeli Prime Minister was nothing but an unsuccessful attempt to distract attention from his genocide and brutal war crimes. To date, in Gaza alone he has brutally massacred more than 42,000 civilians, mostly women and children, wounded 93,000 other civilians, destroyed critical civilian infrastructure and demolished schools, hospitals and mosques. He has even repeatedly killed an unprecedented number of journalists and United Nations staff and attacked many United Nations relief centres. He has brutally used starvation as a method of war.

Making unfounded accusations against regional countries, including my own, has long been a standard practice of the Israeli regime. Its exclusive purpose is to conceal its blatant crimes and brutalities in the region. Obviously, no amount of disinformation, fabrication and lies can cover up the regime's decades-long criminal practices and wicked warmongering policies.

The extent, frequency and gravity of the barbaric crimes of the Israeli regime in Palestine and Lebanon are unprecedented. Those brutalities have all the elements of genocide, war crimes and crimes against humanity. The Israeli forces commit all such crimes on a daily basis, repeatedly and concurrently, before the eyes of all humankind. They have turned Gaza into a graveyard for children and a hell on Earth, as has been said by United Nations staff and officials. The apartheid occupying regime of Israel is now waging an all-out war of aggression against Lebanon. It has targeted civilians, mostly women, children and the elderly, and attacked civilian infrastructure.

Moreover, the deliberate targeting of civilians in Lebanon by detonating pagers and other electronic devices across the country was a blatant terrorist act committed by the Israeli regime. That evil practice is the most outrageous manifestation of the

weaponization of ordinary communication devices to commit terrorist acts and to harm civilians. Such adventurist acts of terrorism must sound a warning bell for the entire international community. That new version of terrorism must be condemned unequivocally by all. If unchecked, the Israeli regime will commit terrorist acts in other countries using such devices. It must therefore be compelled to stop such acts of terrorism everywhere.

The evil regime of Israel is the exclusive source of insecurity and instability in the region and beyond. The continued aggressions and crimes of that regime in Palestine and Lebanon continue to seriously threaten regional and international peace and security. Its aggression against Lebanon cannot be isolated from the overall situation in the region. The Zionist regime's real and ill-intended objective is to drag the entire region into a full-scale war. The military adventurism of that criminal regime must be stopped before it is too late.

For that terrorist regime, international humanitarian and human rights law, the binding orders of the International Court of Justice and the principle of humanity mean nothing. It has persistently and flagrantly violated principles of the United Nations and therefore does not deserve membership of the Organization. The atrocity crimes and genocide committed by the occupying apartheid regime must not go unpunished. Impunity would only continue to embolden the regime to persist in its pattern of war crimes, crimes against humanity and genocide, and to commit more crimes more brutally.

The international community, the United Nations and the Security Council must take their responsibilities seriously and do everything in their power to stop the destabilizing policies and illegal practices of the Israeli regime in the volatile region of West Asia. The regime must also be held accountable for all such inhumane policies and unlawful practices and, as our Foreign Minister said today before the Security Council,

“Netanyahu and his criminal gang must be arrested and prosecuted for their heinous crimes. He should not be permitted to appear before this body and take pride in his evil deeds.” (*S/PV.9734, p. 29*)

Any failure to act to prevent the brutalities of that rogue aggressive regime, which has already crossed all red lines, will further embolden it to pursue further crimes. That must be avoided.

We once again strongly condemn and categorically reject the heinous attacks of the rogue regime of Israel against Palestine, Lebanon and other regional countries. We also reiterate our full support for the realization of the inalienable right to self-determination of the Palestinian people. Under international law, Palestinians have an absolute right to resist occupation and aggression, using all available means. We also fully support the inherent right of self-defence of all regional nations against the aggressions of the Israeli regime. As we have said time and again, the path to escalation is clear. Israel must be compelled to stop immediately and permanently all its attacks on Gaza, the West Bank, Lebanon and other parts of the region. In response to the sabre-rattling and threats made today by the Israeli regime's representative. I must stress that the Islamic Republic of Iran will not hesitate to rigorously defend its territory people and vital interests. Obviously, in exercising our inherent right to self-defence we will do so at the time and in the manner we choose.

The Israeli regime representative also made an unsuccessful attempt to falsely portray our nuclear programme as a source of concern. Iran's nuclear programme has always been and will remain exclusively for peaceful purposes. In fact, the real source of serious threat is the clandestine nuclear weapons programme of the Israeli regime and its nuclear weapon arsenal. To avert that dangerous threat to regional and international peace and security, the Israeli regime must be compelled to abandon

its nuclear weapons, join the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons promptly and unconditionally and place all its nuclear activities and facilities under the comprehensive safeguards of the International Atomic Energy Agency.

Ms. Dhanutirto (Indonesia): My delegation wishes to exercise our right of reply in response to the statement made by the representative of Vanuatu earlier today (see A/79/PV.13).

We appreciate the reaffirmation of respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of Indonesia. That is the right to uphold towards fostering friendly and constructive relation in line with the core principles of the Charter of the United Nations.

Indonesia has taken note of the remarks made regarding development in the provinces of Papua in Indonesia. As a vibrant and robust democracy, Indonesia continues to listen to the will and aspiration of its people, who seek peace, prosperity and development. I wish to take this opportunity to emphasize the following points.

First, on the call for greater autonomy, since 2001 special autonomy laws have granted Papuans the authority to directly elect their own representatives and leaders through democratic processes. Those laws provide a solid ground and assurances that only Papuans can be elected as leaders in the Papua provinces, a special arrangement that is only applied in the Papua provinces. Moreover, the establishment of the Papuan People's Assembly and other representative bodies reserved for Papuans ensures their political and cultural representation, in line with their customs and identities.

Indonesia remains committed to further increasing the meaningful participation of the people of Papua in decision-making. On the twentieth anniversary of the special autonomy law in 2021, the number of seats in the local Parliament increased from 25 in 2001 to 60 seats. Similarly, the membership of the Papuan People's Assembly grew from 93 to 225 seats in 2021. Those improvements will further guarantee their direct and active participation in governance and development, not only for Papua but for Indonesia as a whole.

Secondly, on the call for progress in development, the Government of Indonesia has been steadfast in its commitment to ensuring that Papuans benefit from the same progress seen across the archipelago. All provinces in Papua are among the top eight provinces with the highest budget allocation in Indonesia. Those resources are focused on the development of extensive infrastructure and social welfare projects, including roads, airports, seaports, schools and hospitals. At the same time, human development has been a central priority. Over the past decade, the human development index in Papua and West Papua has risen from 54.45 to 61.39, while West Papua's human development index has risen from 59.60 to 65, transitioning from low to medium status, according to United Nations Development Programme standards. Poverty rates have also seen a marked decline and life expectancy has significantly increased.

Finally, I wish to reaffirm Indonesia's unwavering commitment to the long-term development and prosperity of its people, including those in all provinces in Papua, and to ensuring that their aspirations to peace and progress are realized.

Ms. Shino (Japan): In the statement delivered by the representative of Solomon Islands, there was a reference to "treated radioactive-contaminated water" with respect to the discharge of water treated through the Advanced Liquid Processing System (ALPS) at the Tokyo Electric Power Company holding, the Fukushima Daiichi nuclear power station, into the sea. It is unfortunate that I am compelled to exert my right of reply in response to that misleading statement.

First, I must make it clear that the ALPS-treated water being discharged from the Fukushima Daiichi nuclear power station is not nuclear-contaminated water.

It has undergone a rigorous purification process through ALPS, which effectively removes multiple radionuclides to meet international safety standards. As ALPS-treated water is discharged after sufficient purification and dilution, it will have negligible radiological impact on people. That is one of the major conclusions drawn by the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) through its safety review and verified by the monitoring activities of Japan and the IAEA involving interested third countries. Furthermore, in July the IAEA published a report following its second review mission, which began after the discharge started in August last year. That report reaffirmed the fundamental conclusions of the IAEA comprehensive report of July 2023. It stated that the IAEA did not identify anything inconsistent with the requirements of the relevant international safety standards. The report also confirmed that the equipment and facilities are installed and operated in a manner consistent with the implementation plan and the relevant international safety standards.

Secondly, the Government of Japan has shared science-based information on the safety of the discharge with the international community in a transparent manner. In particular, the Government of Japan has provided individual briefing sessions to countries and regions that have expressed interest. As a result, a wide range of countries and regions have expressed their understanding and support for the efforts of Japan and the IAEA regarding the discharge of ALPS-treated water. For instance, Japan and our Pacific neighbours share a special interest in our ocean. At the tenth Pacific Islands Leaders Meeting in July, the leaders of Pacific island countries and regions, including Solomon Islands, acknowledged the dialogue with Japan and concurred on the importance of its being based on scientific evidence in that matter, recognizing the IAEA as the authority on nuclear safety.

One year has passed since the start of the ALPS-treated water discharge. Japan will continue to share the results of the ongoing review and multilayered monitoring by international participants in a transparent manner and in good faith. Japan will also continue with its efforts to gain further understanding from the international community and to engage with various stakeholders in the Asia-Pacific region and beyond,

Mrs. Mangalanandan (India): The Assembly regrettably witnessed a travesty this morning. A country run by a military with a global reputation for engaging in terrorism, the narcotics trade and transnational crime had the audacity to attack the world's largest democracy. I speak about the reference to India in the speech of the Pakistani Prime Minister (see A/79/PV.13).

As the world knows, Pakistan has long employed cross-border terrorism as a weapon against its neighbours. It has attacked our Parliament, our financial capital, Mumbai, market places and pilgrimage routes. The list is long. For such a country to speak about violence anywhere is hypocrisy at its worst. It is even more extraordinary for a country with a history of rigged elections to talk about the political choices of a democracy. The real truth is that Pakistan covets our territory and in fact has continuously used terrorism to disrupt elections in Jammu and Kashmir, an inalienable an integral part of India.

A reference was made to some proposal of strategic restraint. There can be no compact with terrorism. In fact, Pakistan should realize that cross-border terrorism against India will inevitably invite consequences. It is ridiculous that a nation that committed genocide in 1971 and that persecutes its minorities relentlessly even now should dare speak about intolerance and phobias. The world can see for itself what Pakistan really is.

We are talking about a nation that long hosted Osama Bin Laden — a country whose fingerprints are on so many terrorist incidents across the world and whose policies attract the dregs of many societies to make it their home. Perhaps it should

come as no surprise that its Prime Minister would so speak in the Hall, yet we must make clear how unacceptable his words are to all of us. We know that Pakistan will seek to counter the truth with more lies. Repetition will change nothing. Our stand is clear and needs no reiteration.

Mr. Faheem (Pakistan): My delegation is obliged to exercise its right of reply in response to the baseless and misleading assertions made by the representative of India.

India continues to peddle a false narrative in this forum year after year, relying on the tactics of denial, distortion and deflection. However, those distortions cannot alter the reality that Jammu and Kashmir is an internationally recognized disputed territory. It has never been and never will be a part of India, nor is it an internal matter. The Security Council, through numerous resolutions, has unequivocally called for a free, impartial plebiscite to enable the people of Jammu and Kashmir to exercise their inalienable right to self-determination. India is obligated, under Article 25 of the Charter of the United Nations, to implement those resolutions.

Yet instead of honouring its obligations, India has chosen the path of repression, suppressing the legitimate aspirations of the Kashmiri people to self-determination through a brutal and oppressive occupation. India's illegal and unilateral actions of 5 August 2019 further intensified that occupation, with nearly 1,000,000 soldiers deployed to suppress the Kashmiris' legitimate right. My Prime Minister shed a spotlight on those facts today, which may be uncomfortable for India, yet this remains a truth that India cannot deny through its sophistry.

India's crimes in Indian illegally occupied Jammu and Kashmir are heinous and committed with impunity. Innocent civilians, including women and children, are being targeted through staged encounters, extrajudicial killings and collective punishment. Entire villages have been razed. The entire Kashmiri political leadership remains incarcerated and a media blackout continues to stifle independent voices. This is the largest military occupation in the world, where over 8 million Kashmiris live in a perpetual state of siege and horror. The reports of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights and statements from over a dozen United Nations special rapporteurs have documented those widespread violations and called for the investigation of human rights violations in Indian illegally occupied Jammu and Kashmir, yet India has consistently denied them access to the occupied territory.

India has once again resorted to the familiar tactic of deflecting global attention from its own terror activities by raising baseless accusations of terrorism. It is ironic that a country that uses terrorism as an instrument of State policy against its neighbours should attempt to point fingers at others. India, which has been sponsoring terrorism and orchestrating assassination campaigns, is hardly in a position to lecture others on that issue. In addition to its State terrorism against the defenceless people of Indian illegally occupied Jammu and Kashmir, India continues to sponsor terror activities not only against Pakistan but also in other countries. For decades, India has been the primary perpetrator, supporter and financier of terrorism. India's sponsorship of terrorist organizations, such as Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan and the Balochistan Liberation Army, has led to the loss of thousands of innocent Pakistani lives. Pakistan has shared irrefutable evidence of India's involvement in terrorism with the international community. The arrest and conviction of Kulbhushan Yadav, a serving Indian naval officer and operative of India's intelligence agency, the Research and Analysis Wing, is irrefutable evidence of India's State-sponsored terrorism against Pakistan, including targeted assassinations in Pakistan. Now, the Indian terrorist franchise has gone global with assassinations and attempted murders of political dissidents on North American soil.

The delegation of India referred to the events of 1971, which were a question not of genocide but of India's foreign aggression and attack on the national sovereignty and territorial integrity of Pakistan. I would like to ask the Indian delegation to refer to resolution 2793 (XXVI), of December 1971, which upheld the sovereignty and territorial integrity of Pakistan against the foreign invasion.

While the Indian representative referred to India as the biggest democracy, the world knows that India's reign of terror against its minorities continues unabated. The Bharatiya Janata Party/Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh Government, which has ruled India since 2014, is imposing a reign of fear and violence not only against the people of Indian illegally occupied Jammu and Kashmir, but also against its own Muslims, Christians, Dalits and other low-caste Hindus. Islamophobia has deeply infiltrated the Indian State, where 200 million Muslims face lynching by cow vigilantes and programmes led by Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, often with Government complicity. Muslims are facing forced conversions, disenfranchisement, restrictions like the hijab ban and the destruction of hundreds of mosques, including the Babri Masjid, all aimed at erasing Muslim identity and culture, which are integral parts of India's history.

India must end its State-sponsored terrorism, cease its illegal occupation of Jammu and Kashmir and fulfil its obligations under international law. Pakistan has been and will continue to highlight India's State terrorism against our people and the people of Indian illegally occupied Jammu and Kashmir. Make no mistake — Indian state terrorism in Indian illegally occupied Jammu and Kashmir will not be able to dampen the indomitable spirit of those seeking their inalienable right to self-determination, nor will India's attempt to divert attention from its sponsorship of terrorism ever succeed.

The meeting rose at 10.30 p.m.